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THE AETHELRED CIPHER

Randy Pellegrini

randypellegrini.com

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About the Author

Randy Pellegrini writes *The Architecture of Survival*, a 12-book epic spanning 3,200 years from Bronze Age Egypt to the modern era. The series explores genetic memory as hard science, civilizational collapse patterns, and the moral complexity of two competing philosophies: knowledge preservation versus genetic control.

The saga weaves real historical events with speculative elements grounded in epigenetics, network theory, and systems thinking. Each book stands alone while revealing how defensive methodology has been embedded into human civilization through every era's dominant technology.

When not writing, Randy travels near and far to better imagine history up close and personal. He continuously wonders why we continue to replay broken patterns of human systems. That wonder was the seed that has grown into this series.

To learn more about the book series, visit randypellegrini.com/series

Randy Pellegrini

Figure 1: Randy Pellegrini

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CHAPTER 1 - THE KEY

1347, St. Martin's Monastery, Mainz

Blood and ink.

The smell hit Thomas first, sharp and metallic beneath the acrid bite of smoke from overturned candles. Brother Hamo lay sprawled across the copying desk, his robes dark with spreading crimson. The manuscript he'd been working on—a commentary on Boethius—was ruined, vellum soaking through with blood.

Thomas froze in the doorway. Breakfast bread forgotten in his hand.

"Hamo?"

The old monk's hand twitched. Thomas dropped the bread and knelt beside him.

"Thomas." Hamo's voice bubbled wetly. A narrow wound gaped in his chest, precise as a scribe's cut. The dagger was gone. "Took… too long…"

"The infirmarian—I'll fetch—"

"No." Hamo's grip seized Thomas's wrist. "They're coming. The Gray Robes."

"Who—"

"The Order." Blood flecked Hamo's lips as he coughed. His other hand fumbled in his robes, pulled out something small. Iron. "Your grandfather… Wilhelm… he made me swear. If anything happened… this goes to you."

He pressed the object into Thomas's palm. A key, crude iron, with an eye symbol etched into the handle.

Thomas stared. "I don't understand—"

"The cipher. The marks in the margins. Wilhelm's network." Hamo's eyes lost focus, then sharpened again with effort. "This is the only tool that can read it. They've done this before, Thomas. Plague of Justinian. Same pattern. They knew this plague was coming—positioned their people, let millions die. Wilhelm found the proof." Blood bubbled at his lips. "The Order will kill anyone who knows. You must—"

Footsteps in the corridor. Multiple sets. Heavy boots, not sandals.

Terror transformed Hamo's face. "Go. The tunnels beneath the wine cellar. Now!"

"I won't leave you—"

"You're weak, Thomas. Everyone knows it. Weak at digging, weak at hauling, weak at everything that matters." Hamo smiled, sad and certain. "But Wilhelm saw something in you. Some gift." Blood ran from the corner of his mouth. "If he believed it… then I believe it too."

The footsteps drew closer. Calm voices, methodical, asking questions in the chapter house.

"Go," Hamo whispered. "See the patterns your grandfather saw. Make my death—"

His eyes went distant. His hand went slack.

Thomas knelt there, the iron key cutting into his palm.

The voices reached the cloister.

"—the scribe boy, Thomas of Eltville. Where is he?"

"—Brother Hamo was the last to see the manuscript—"

"—search the scriptorium first—"

Thomas looked at Hamo's body. At the ruined Boethius. At the key in his hand.

Grandfather Wilhelm had died for this. Now Hamo.

The footsteps turned toward the scriptorium.

Thomas ran.

Left at the refectory, down the stone stairs, past the chapter house—he knew these corridors, had scrubbed them often enough during penance. Shouts erupted behind him, no longer bothering with stealth.

The wine cellar was dark, cool, smelling of earth and fermentation. Squeezing between the large barrels, Thomas found the tunnel entrance Hamo had mentioned—a low arch behind the oldest cask, barely visible in shadow.

He dropped to his knees and crawled into darkness.

Behind him, the cellar door crashed open.

"—saw him come this way—"

"—check behind the barrels—"

Thomas crawled faster, hands scraping stone, the key clutched tight enough to draw blood. The tunnel sloped down and turned, opening into a larger passage—old Roman construction, forgotten when the monastery was built centuries ago.

Voices echoed behind him, but the tunnel was too narrow for a grown man in armor.

"Get the boy from the village. Someone who can fit."

Thomas didn't wait. He ran through darkness, one hand on the tunnel wall, until light appeared ahead—a grating opening onto the city streets.

He pushed through and emerged in an alley reeking of offal and tanning chemicals.

Free—for now.

Thomas opened his palm. Blood on the key—his own, from the sharp edges. Or Hamo's, from those final moments.

Your grandfather saw something in you.

Hamo saw it too.

And they both died for it.

But he was alive. The Gray Robes wanted this key badly enough to kill for it.

Pulling his hood up, Thomas stepped into the crowded streets of Mainz. Plague bells rang their hollow rhythm. Somewhere beyond the market square, someone screamed.

Hamo's dying words echoed: *They knew this plague was coming.*

Not prediction. Engineering.

Thomas stumbled into an alley and pressed his back against cold stone. The key cut into his palm.

Wilhelm's lessons echoed: *"You see patterns, Thomas. That's worth more than strong arms."*

And his deathbed words: *"Scatter their knowledge like seed on wind. Across generations, scattered knowledge distributes power."*

Now those words made terrible sense.

The Order—Gray Robes who controlled knowledge, accumulated power through breeding and secrets, seemed to know catastrophes before they happened.

And the Network—Wilhelm's network, scattered families who believed knowledge should be distributed, not hoarded.

Both claimed to preserve civilization. Somewhere across centuries, they'd become enemies.

Wilhelm had been Network. Hamo's killers were Order.

Then I'd better start seeing them.

The cloth merchant's quarter sprawled like a maze—drying racks casting latticed shadows, funeral shrouds hanging limp in the still air.

Thomas moved through it like a ghost, his monk's robes stained with tunnel filth. The smell here was different from the alley: lye soap cutting through decay, wet wool drying in weak sunlight, and underneath it all, the sweet-sick odor of bodies waiting to be wrapped.

A woman worked at a sorting table, hands moving with numb precision through plague-stained linens. The clothes of the dead.

Thomas started to turn away.

"You're bleeding," she said without looking up.

Thomas examined his palm. The key had cut deeper than he'd thought. "It's nothing."

"Infection kills as surely as plague." She looked up.

Younger than he'd expected—mid-twenties, perhaps. Sharp face, intelligent eyes, a scar running along her jawline. Her hands, though working with fabric, were callused in ways that spoke of harder work than cloth.

"The Gray Robes are watching the gates," she said, returning to her work. "Whatever you stole, they want it back. Three men just came through here asking about a scribe boy. I told them I saw you heading toward the cathedral."

"Why would you—"

"Because the Order killed my father for having books they didn't approve of." Her voice was flat. "I don't help them. Ever."

Thomas stepped closer. "The books. Did they have… marks? Patterns in the margins?"

Her hands stilled. For just a moment, her mask cracked. "Who are you?"

"Thomas. Of Eltville."

"Eltville." She tested the name. "Wilhelm's grandson?"

His breath caught. "You knew him?"

"My father knew him. Worked with him." She studied Thomas with new intensity. "You look like him. Same soft hands. Same naive eyes that think the world should be fair."

"I don't—"

"Good. Because it's not." She pulled a strip of cloth from her pile and walked around the table. "Give me your hand."

Thomas hesitated, then extended his bleeding palm.

She bound the wound with efficient movements. This close, he could smell rosemary, lavender, and something acrid—chemicals used in cloth dyeing. Or erasing ink.

"The river path," she said, tying off the bandage. "Go before dark. There's a warehouse district. Third building, red mark on the door. Knock twice. If I'm not there by morning, run south and don't look back."

"I don't even know your name."

"Margarethe." She met his eyes directly. "And if you're carrying what I think you're carrying, Thomas of Eltville, knowing my name might be the most dangerous thing you ever learn."

She turned back to her work, dismissing him.

Thomas walked toward the river, his bandaged hand throbbing. He looked back once.

Margarethe was watching him, unflinching.

For reasons he couldn't name, his chest tightened.

Margarethe's hands shook as she returned to sorting linens.

Wilhelm's grandson.

Memory came unwanted: **Seven years ago.** Her father's warehouse. Brother Anselm standing over Heinrich's broken body, asking questions with calm precision.

"Where is the index, Heinrich?"

"There is no… master list…"

"We know about the network. The cipher maps. Wilhelm is dead, but his knowledge remains."

Margarethe, hidden in the loft, had bitten through her lip.

Her father looked up—directly at her hiding place. Their eyes met.

Don't speak. Don't move. Live.

Then: "I'll tell you. The index is in… Abbey of Fulda. Behind the altar stone—"

Anselm's dagger had been quick. Merciful.

The lie saved her. There was no index at Fulda. The real locations were in her father's head—and he'd spent her childhood teaching her to memorize them. Two hundred and seventeen locations. The complete network.

She was the index. The living catalog.

And she'd just revealed herself to Wilhelm's grandson.

But when she'd seen Thomas's eyes—that same naive belief her father had—she'd seen all the good men the Order had murdered.

Maybe this time, she'd be fast enough to save one.

Margarethe locked her shop and strapped her daggers beneath her cloak. Her father's blades.

If Wilhelm's grandson was carrying the cipher key, the Order would hunt him properly.

And Thomas of Eltville would be dead by nightfall unless someone kept him alive.

1347, Night. River Path.

Thomas followed the path along the Rhine, the water black and cold beside him. Behind him, the city bells tolled for the dead. Another plague cart rattling through the streets.

He'd made it perhaps half a mile when he heard the footsteps.

Two sets. Heavy boots on cobblestones. Not bothering to hide.

Thomas's heart hammered. He walked faster. The footsteps matched his pace.

"Scribe boy!" A voice called behind him. "Brother Anselm would speak with you. No need to run."

Thomas ran.

The river path narrowed—warehouses loomed on one side, the drop to the water on the other. Thomas's sandals slipped on wet stone, his breath coming in ragged gasps.

A hand grabbed his shoulder and yanked him back. Thomas spun, fell, hit the cobblestones hard. Stars exploded across his vision.

"Easy now," the first man said. He wore the gray robes, the silver key pendant. "We just want the little iron toy you're carrying. Give it over, and maybe you live to copy another psalm."

The second man drew a dagger. "Or don't, and save us the trouble."

Thomas's hand closed around the key in his pocket. Hamo's blood was probably still on it. Grandfather's legacy.

"No," he whispered.

"What was that?"

"I said no." Louder now. "You killed my grandfather. You killed Hamo. You're not getting this."

The first man sighed. "Brave and stupid. The worst combination." He nodded to his partner. "Make it quick."

The dagger came toward Thomas's throat.

And stopped.

The second man made a strange gurgling sound, looked down at the blade protruding from his neck, confused. Then he collapsed.

The first man spun, reaching for his own weapon—

Margarethe rose from the shadows behind him, a second dagger already in motion. She drove it under his ribs with practiced precision, twisted, withdrew. The man fell.

Thomas stared from his position on the ground, ears ringing. The world narrowed to Margarethe standing over the bodies, wiping her blades on the first man's cloak.

She looked at Thomas. Calm. Practiced.

"Breathe," she said. "Unless you want to faint and crack your skull."

Thomas breathed. The ringing subsided.

Margarethe sheathed her daggers and extended a hand. Her grip was strong, callused. She pulled him to his feet.

"You were supposed to go to the warehouse," she said.

"I was going—"

"Too slow. The Order doesn't just guard gates. They watch the paths too." She looked at the bodies without emotion. "I followed you. Figured you'd be dead within the hour if I didn't."

"You've been following me since—"

"Since you left my shop. Aye." She checked the alley behind them. "These two won't be the last. Can you run?"

"Yes."

"Then run. Toward the warehouses. Third door, red mark. I'll make sure no one else is tracking you, then meet you there."

"Wait—" Thomas found his voice. "You killed them."

"Aye."

"You just… killed two men."

"Would you prefer I let them kill you?" Her tone was matter-of-fact, but something flickered in her eyes. "This isn't the scriptorium, Thomas. Out here, you either run or you bleed. Sometimes both."

She turned to leave.

"Thank you," Thomas said.

Margarethe paused. Didn't turn around. "Don't thank me yet. You're not safe. Neither of us is." A beat. "But I owed your grandfather a debt. I pay my debts."

"Is that the only reason you helped me?"

Now she did turn. Looked at him directly. "I don't know. Ask me again when we're not standing next to corpses."

She disappeared into the shadows.

Thomas ran for the warehouse, fear and adrenaline driving him forward.

Thomas found the warehouse. Third building. Red mark painted on the door. He knocked twice.

Silence.

He waited. Minutes dragged. Every shadow became a gray cloak.

The door opened. Margarethe stood there, still wearing the same bloodstained dress. She'd made no effort to clean it.

"Inside. Quick."

The warehouse was vast and cold. Bales of fabric rose like monuments in the gloom. A single lantern burned on a makeshift table.

Margarethe locked the door behind him—three separate bolts—then turned, arms crossed, and studied him.

"Sit."

Thomas sat on a crate, legs grateful for it.

Margarethe didn't sit. She circled him slowly, like a merchant appraising wares.

"You're a terrible liar," she said finally.

"I didn't lie—"

"You're afraid. Of me, of the Order, of yourself. That's honest." She stopped in front of him. "But you're hiding something. Everyone does. So here's how this works: I ask questions, you answer truthfully, and maybe we both survive the week. Lie to me, and I throw you out. Clear?"

Thomas nodded.

"Name."

"Thomas. Thomas of Eltville."

"Family."

"My father is alive. In Eltville. We… don't speak. He wanted me in the vineyards. I was too weak for it." The admission hurt. "My grandfather raised me. Wilhelm."

"How did he die?"

The Order killed him. I didn't know it then. Thought it was an accident. But I saw the man who visited the day before. He wore a silver key.

Something softened in Margarethe's expression. Not much. But enough.

"Your grandfather was brilliant," she said quietly. "Reckless, but brilliant. My father said Wilhelm could hold an entire library in his head. Memorize every location, every cipher mark, every hidden text." She paused. "Did he teach you?"

"Some. He showed me how to see patterns. How to remember sequences. But I was young. I didn't understand…" Thomas pulled out the iron key. "Until Hamo gave me this."

Margarethe's breath caught. She reached for the key, then stopped herself. "May I?"

"Aye."

She took it gently, reverently, turning it over in her hands, examining the etched eye symbol.

"I thought this was lost," she whispered. "When my father died, Anselm searched for weeks. He tore apart our warehouse, our home. He never found it."

"Because Wilhelm had it?"

"Wilhelm kept it separate. Safe." She looked up at Thomas. "Do you know what this is?"

"Hamo said it reads the cipher. Shows which dots matter."

"It's more than that." Margarethe pulled a folded piece of parchment from her bodice and spread it on the table.

Thomas leaned forward. The parchment showed what looked like a manuscript page, covered in dense Latin text. But in the margins, faintly visible, were geometric dot patterns.

Margarethe placed the iron key over the page. The eye symbol aligned with a specific section of text. Through the aperture, certain dots were highlighted.

"The key is a template," she explained. "Position it correctly, and it tells you which dots to count, which to ignore. Without it, the cipher looks random. With it…" She counted quickly. "Abbey of St. Gall. Third shelf. Volume on Aristotelian comedy."

Thomas stared. "Madness. Those dots—they're tiny. Random—"

"Not random. Never random. Every mark has meaning. Position, color, depth. It's a language, Thomas. A mathematical language your grandfather helped create." She handed the key back. "And now you're holding the only decoding tool that exists."

"Why not make more?"

"Because more copies mean more chances for the Order to find one. This key is unique. The knowledge of how to make it died with the original architects." Margarethe's jaw tightened. "My father tried to recreate it. He couldn't. The mathematics were beyond him. Beyond anyone alive."

Thomas turned the key over in his hands. Such a small thing. Iron, worthless. But it held the power to unlock centuries of hidden knowledge.

"What do we do with it?" he asked.

"We?" Margarethe raised an eyebrow.

"You saved my life. You clearly care about protecting this cipher. I have the key, but I don't know how to use it properly. You know the system, but you don't have the tool." Thomas met her gaze. "Separately, we're incomplete. Together…"

"Together we're bigger targets."

"Perhaps. Or perhaps we're strong enough to actually do something with this."

Margarethe studied him for a long moment. "You're naive."

"Aye."

"Weak. Probably useless in a fight."

"Almost certainly."

"And you think because we share a dead grandfather's legacy, that makes us allies?"

"I think," Thomas said carefully, "that you could have let those men kill me. You could have taken the key off my corpse and been done with it. But you didn't. So either you're a worse pragmatist than you pretend, or…" He trailed off.

"Or?"

"Or you're just as tired of being alone as I am."

The silence stretched between them. The lantern flickered.

Finally, Margarethe sat on a crate across from him. "Here's what you need to understand, Thomas of Eltville. Everyone I protect dies. My mother. My father. The merchants who worked with him. The Order doesn't leave loose ends."

"But you're still alive."

"Because I'm careful. Because I trust no one. Because I've made myself useful enough to too many people that killing me would cause problems." She leaned forward. "You want to be allies? Very well. But don't mistake alliance for friendship. Don't expect me to save you again. And don't—" Her voice caught slightly. "Don't ask me to care whether you live or die. Because everyone I care about ends up dead."

Thomas heard what she tried to bury: grief, and something close to fear.

"I won't ask," he said softly. "I'll try not to get killed, anyway. Can't promise about the caring part."

"What?"

"I already care whether you live or die. You saved my life. That tends to create attachment."

Margarethe stared at him. Then, unexpectedly, she laughed—sharp and bitter. "You're going to be a problem, aren't you?"

"Probably."

She shook her head, but something in her expression had shifted. "We start tomorrow. I'll teach you to decode the cipher properly. You'll teach me everything your grandfather told you about the network. And we'll figure out what to do with this damned key before the Order finds us."

"Where do I sleep?"

"There." She pointed to a pile of wool blankets in the corner. "I'll be on the other side of the warehouse. If you try anything, I have more daggers."

"I wouldn't—"

"I know. You're too naive to be dangerous." But she almost smiled. "Sleep, Thomas. Tomorrow we find out if you're really Wilhelm's grandson or just another dead scribe waiting to happen."

She walked into the shadows, leaving Thomas alone with the lantern and the weight of his grandfather's legacy.

He lay on the wool blankets, the key pressed against his chest.

For the first time since Hamo's death, he felt something other than fear.

He felt purpose.

Tonight, he just needed to survive.

CHAPTER 2 - THE GHOST

1347, Warehouse, Mainz

Scrape.

Pause.

Scrape.

Thomas woke to the sound of steel on stone.

The whetstone against blade cut through his dreams—rhythmic, deliberate, patient. Gray dawn filtered through gaps in the warehouse walls, dust motes swirling in pale shafts like ash from distant fires. The air smelled of damp wool and old fabric, and underneath, faintly, the rosemary scent he'd come to associate with Margarethe.

His back ached where stone had pressed through the blankets all night, ribs protesting from yesterday's fall on the cobblestones.

When Margarethe had saved him.

She sat cross-legged on a crate fifteen feet away, methodically sharpening her daggers. The whetstone moved steadily—scrape, pause, test, repeat.

"You snore," Margarethe said without looking up.

Thomas blinked, still foggy. "I don't—" He stopped. "Do I?"

"Like a dying goat." She tested the blade's edge against her thumb. Nodded, set it aside, started on the next. "But quietly enough. No one heard us from the street."

"How long have you been awake?"

"Since before dawn. Habit." She finally looked at him, gaze direct and appraising. "You slept well for someone who watched two men die."

The river-path images surged back: a throat opening under Margarethe's blade, lanternlight turning blood black, the wet gurgle that went on too long.

Thomas's stomach rolled.

"I didn't have nightmares," he said quietly. "Should I have?"

"Most people do. First time they see death up close." She sheathed the first dagger, started on the second. "Either you're tougher than you look, or very good at lying to yourself."

Thomas considered it. "Perhaps both."

She almost smiled.

He walked to the makeshift table—a rough plank balanced on two crates. Someone had left bread and cheese there. The bread was hard as stone, the cheese not much softer. He tore off pieces of each, chewed mechanically. It tasted like dust and salt.

"We start today," Margarethe said, setting down her whetstone. The scraping stopped, leaving the warehouse suddenly quiet. She stood and walked to a stack of fabric bales against the far wall, movements fluid and economical. "Your grandfather's gift won't save you if you don't know how to use it."

She pushed the bales aside. Behind them sat a wooden chest, old and scarred, bound with iron straps. Margarethe produced a key from somewhere—perhaps her boot—and unlocked the chest.

Inside were manuscripts.

Thomas's breath caught. Even from here, he could see the quality—good vellum, careful script, the kind of work that took months to produce. Each one worth more than his father's entire vineyard.

"My father's collection," Margarethe said softly. For the first time since they'd met, something shifted in her expression—grief, raw and unguarded. "The ones he hid before the Order came. Not the originals—those are scattered across Christendom. But copies. Careful copies." She pulled out three and carried them to the table with reverence. "Everything I know about the cipher, I learned from these. My father would show me page after page, teaching me to see the patterns. To remember them."

Thomas leaned over them. The vellum was beautiful—smooth, nearly translucent in the dawn light. Latin text: psalms, biblical commentary, what looked like a merchant's ledger. And in the margins, faint but deliberate, geometric patterns of colored dots.

Red. Blue. Yellow.

Just like the ones in Hamo's scriptorium before blood had ruined everything.

"What do the words say?" Margarethe asked, pointing to the first page. "The Latin. Which psalm is it?"

Thomas blinked at the odd question. "Psalm 23. *Dominus regit me*... The Lord is my shepherd."

She nodded, as if confirming something from memory. "Good. Sit."

Thomas sat.

She pulled the iron key from Thomas's pocket—he hadn't even felt her take it. Pickpocket's touch. She placed the key on the table between them. The eye symbol etched into the handle caught the light, seemed to stare at them both. Accusing. Demanding.

"The cipher is a language," Margarethe began, her teacher's voice different from her merchant voice or survivor voice—more patient, almost kind. "But not one written in words. It's written in positions, colors, and counts." She gestured to the dots in the margins. "What do you see in the markings? Describe them."

Thomas studied the margins near Psalm 23. A cluster of dots. Three red, two blue, one yellow. Arranged in what looked like a triangular pattern.

"Dots," he said. "Three red, two blue, one yellow."

"Deeper. What pattern do they form?"

Thomas looked closer. Squinted. The three red ones formed a perfect triangle, apex pointing upward. The two blue dots sat at the triangle's base, equidistant. The single yellow dot was offset to the right, like a waypoint.

"Geometry," he said slowly. "The placement is deliberate. The red dots form a triangle."

"Good." The faintest hint of approval crossed her face. "That's what my father taught me to see. Not the words—I can't read those. Never could. But the shapes. The patterns. The positions." She picked up the iron key. "Now watch."

She positioned it over the page with practiced precision, her movements careful and deliberate. "My father taught me that the eye symbol aligns with specific words. Common phrases that appear in many manuscripts. In Psalm 23, there's a word—six lines down from the beginning. Read it for me."

Thomas scanned down. " 'Righteous.' "

"That's the anchor." She had the key positioned perfectly over that word, as if she knew exactly where it would be without reading it. "Through the aperture in the key's handle, certain dots are highlighted while others fall into shadow."

Thomas leaned closer, looking through the key's opening. She was right—the aperture created a frame that isolated specific dots.

"The key is a filter," Margarethe explained. "Position it correctly over the textual anchor, and it tells you which dots to count, which to ignore. Count what you see through the opening."

Thomas counted. "Three red, one yellow. The blue ones are hidden."

"Three-one. That's a position indicator." She set the key down. "Every page has these anchors—specific words my father taught me to find by memory. I know where they sit on the page, how many lines down, roughly where in the line. I memorized hundreds of them."

"Position of what?"

"The location being encoded." She pulled out a second manuscript—a merchant's ledger, pages stained with wine or blood. Found a page with similar marginal markings. "Same key, different page. Different anchor point." She positioned the key with the same practiced precision. "There should be a word… merchant accounts typically have repeated phrases. Look for something about payment or debt, about three fingers' width from the left edge, maybe ten lines down."

Thomas scanned the page where she'd indicated. "There. 'Debitor.' Debtor."

"That's it." She adjusted the key slightly to align with the word. "Now count what you see through the opening."

Thomas looked. "Two blue dots. The yellow and red are outside the frame."

Two-zero. That's a danger marker. A warning. The cipher isn't just hiding information—it's protecting people. Warning them where not to go.

Thomas's mind raced, patterns clicking into place like pins in a lock finding their positions. "So the colors mean different things. Red is safe locations. Blue is dangerous. Yellow is—"

"Neutral ground. Trade routes, markets, places where the network operates but doesn't control." Margarethe set the key down between them. "The cipher encodes three types of information: location, status, and timing. Together, they create a map of the known world that tells you where to hide, when to travel, and who to trust."

"Timing?"

She turned to another page, one with a different pattern of dots. "Describe what you see here. The yellow ones."

Thomas studied them. "They're arranged in a circle. Twelve positions, like a clock face."

"Seasonal markers," she said. "When to travel, when to hide, when to wait. The network moves with the seasons, with trade fairs, with pilgrimages. Your grandfather was brilliant at this. He could look at a page and memorize fifty dot patterns in an hour. Pair them with the text you can read, and you have the complete system."

"I'm not my grandfather."

"No." Margarethe pushed the manuscripts toward him. "But you see patterns like he did. Your turn. Take the key. Find me a location."

Thomas picked up the iron key, heavy and cold against his palm, edges sharp enough to cut if held wrong. He positioned it over the first manuscript, trying to mimic Margarethe's smooth movements.

The aperture didn't align properly. Through it, the dots looked random, meaningless.

He adjusted, moving the key slightly left. Still wrong.

"You need to find an anchor word first," Margarethe said, patient. "My father taught me the common ones. In psalms, look for words like 'restoreth' or 'righteousness' or 'salvation.' They appear often enough to work across many manuscripts, but not so often that they're everywhere."

Thomas scanned the psalm. *"The Lord is my shepherd…"* Too common. But further down: *"He restoreth my soul."*

"There," he said. "Restoreth. Is that one?"

"It is." She sounded pleased. "Now align the eye with that word."

He positioned the key carefully over *"restoreth."*

Through the aperture, three red dots and one yellow appeared in sharp focus, the blue ones hidden outside the frame.

"Three-one," he breathed, heart hammering. "Three red, one yellow."

"And what location is that?" Margarethe asked.

Thomas frowned. "I… I don't know. How would I know?"

"You wouldn't. Not yet." But she was smiling slightly. "That's the Abbey of St. Gall. Three-one. You'd learn it the way I learned it—by having someone tell you, over and over, until the pattern and the place become linked in memory. My father spent years teaching me the 217 locations. You'll need to learn them too."

"Two hundred and seventeen," Thomas said faintly. "That's…"

"A lifetime's work. My father started when I was five years old." She pulled out another manuscript. "But you have an advantage I didn't. You can read the text yourself. Find your own anchor points. I had to memorize where every anchor word sat on every page. You just need to know which words to look for." She met his eyes, something vulnerable flickering there. "We need each other, you see? You can read what I can't. I can remember what you'll forget. Together, we're stronger than either of us alone."

"Again," Margarethe said, her merchant mask back but something warmer underneath. "Find me another location."

Thomas worked through it. This one was harder—a dense commentary on Boethius's *Consolation of Philosophy*, the Latin theological and philosophical. But he understood the principle now. He scanned for repeated phrases, found one that seemed right: *"fortune's wheel."*

"Is this an anchor?" he asked, pointing.

Margarethe leaned over, studied the position without reading the words. "Yes. That's one my father taught me. Align the key there."

Thomas positioned the key carefully, counted the dots that came into focus.

"Two red, three yellow. Position two-three."

"Cologne. Private collection, merchant district. Second house, third door." Margarethe took the key back, fingers brushing his. "You're learning fast. Too fast, maybe."

"Is that a problem?"

"It is if you start thinking you're invincible." She closed the manuscripts with finality. "The cipher is powerful, Thomas. It can tell you where to hide, who to trust, how to survive. But it can't tell you everything. It can't warn you about betrayal from someone who seems trustworthy. It can't predict when someone you consider a friend will sell you to the Order for fifty gold marks and a promise of safety."

"Anyone would? For the right price or the right threat?" She stood, walked to the warehouse door, checked the street through a crack in the weathered boards. Morning light slanted in, harsh and revealing. "Which is why we're going to the market. You need to see how the network really works. Not on vellum and in theory, but in flesh and blood and lies."

"You're taking me to meet more people? After you just said anyone might betray us?"

"No. I'm taking you to watch people. There's a difference." She turned, expression serious, almost grave. "The cipher is information. But information without context is just noise. You need to learn to read people the way you read manuscripts. Their tells, their patterns, their weaknesses."

"I'm not good at that," Thomas admitted.

"I know. You're transparent as glass." She pulled a cloak from a hook on the wall, tossed it to him. It smelled like rosemary and old smoke—like her. "Which is why you're going to keep your mouth shut and watch. Understood?"

Thomas caught the cloak, pulled it around his shoulders. "Understood."

"Good." Margarethe pulled her own cloak on, checked that her daggers were concealed beneath the fabric. "And Thomas?"

"Aye?"

"If something happens—if we're separated, if the Order finds us—you run. You don't try to be brave. You don't try to save me. You just run and don't look back."

He wanted to argue. Wanted to say he wouldn't abandon her the way everyone in his life had abandoned him.

But the look in her eyes stopped him.

"I'll run," he lied.

She studied him for a long moment, and he saw the exact instant she knew he was lying. But instead of calling him on it, she just sighed. "You're a terrible liar. But I appreciate the effort."

Then she opened the door, and they stepped into the plague-haunted streets of Mainz.

The market square was a ghost of what it must have been.

Half the stalls were empty, their owners dead or fled. The merchants who remained sold food at criminal prices—turnips for a silver penny, half a loaf of bread for three. Clothing stripped from plague houses, blood stains scrubbed out but death still clinging to the fabric. Amulets and charms promising protection, carved with saints' names or stranger symbols.

The smell hit Thomas like a wall.

Rotting vegetables mixed with unwashed bodies. The sharp tang of vinegar—people dousing themselves with it, hoping it would ward off the plague. Smoke from braziers burning herbs someone swore would purify the air. And underneath it all, seeping up from the gutters and the cellars and the mass graves beyond the city walls, the sweet-sick stench of death.

The noise was worse. Haggling voices gone shrill with desperation. A woman weeping over a cartload of her dead husband's tools. Somewhere, a child coughing—that wet, rattling sound that meant plague or consumption. Everyone who heard it took a step back.

Thomas pulled his hood lower, trying not to breathe too deeply.

Margarethe moved through the crowd with practiced ease, transformed again—not the hardened survivor from the warehouse, not the patient teacher. Now she was a cloth merchant, shrewd and focused, examining goods with a critical eye. She'd wrapped a scarf around her lower face—plague caution, but also disguise. The scar on her jaw was hidden.

Thomas followed three steps behind, as she'd instructed.

"Third stall on the left," she murmured without turning her head. "Bookseller. Gray beard, green tunic. Watch him. Don't stare, but watch."

Thomas looked.

The bookseller was old—seventy at least, maybe older. Gray-white beard, face weathered like old leather. He sat behind a small stall displaying religious texts and prayer books. Nothing remarkable.

But then Thomas noticed the pattern.

People didn't browse casually. They came with purpose. A man in merchant's clothes would approach, lean close, whisper something. The bookseller would nod, pull a specific book from his stock, open it to a specific page. The merchant would look, nod back, and leave. No money changed hands. No book was purchased.

A woman in widow's black. Same pattern. Whisper, specific book, specific page, nod, leave.

A younger man, nervously glancing around. Whisper, book, page, and this time the man's face went pale before he hurried away.

"Information trading," Margarethe said quietly. "Oskar doesn't sell books. He sells what's in them."

Thomas watched as another woman approached—middle-aged, well-dressed, probably a merchant's wife. She whispered something urgent. The bookseller—Oskar—pulled a psalter, showed her a page. The woman's face went white. She nodded once and walked away fast enough to be running without actually running.

"What did he tell her?"

"Probably that her husband's road is no longer safe. Or that the plague has reached the next town. Or that the Order is asking after their name." Margarethe angled them closer, stopping at a neighboring stall that sold fabric dyes. "The network lives on news. Oskar is a knot in their web. He knows who's traveling, who's died, where the Order is searching, which roads are safe, which cities are sealed. People pay him in gossip and coin. He pays them back in survival."

She picked up a small vial of indigo dye, examining it while watching Oskar from the corner of her eye. Thomas mimicked her, pretending to study the pigments.

"Why don't we just ask him what we need to know?"

"Because asking costs more than observing. Information freely given is worthless—he'd wonder why we didn't already know. And because—" She went rigid. "Don't turn around. Gray Robe. Two stalls behind us, near the vegetable seller. He's watching the bookseller."

Thomas's heart hammered. He forced himself to stay still, to keep examining a jar of dye. The pungent smell of woad and madder root filled his nose.

"Is he looking at us?"

"No. He's watching Oskar. The Order knows he's a network contact. They're watching who speaks to him, trying to name the rest of the web." Margarethe's voice was tight, controlled. "We need to approach, but carefully."

She purchased the vial of dye, paid in small copper coins that she counted out slowly, making conversation about the weather and the plague like any normal customer. Then she moved away from the stall. "Follow. Not directly. Circle around. Act like we're shopping."

Thomas obeyed. They moved through the market like water finding a path, never stopping in one place too long, never drawing attention. Margarethe paused at a vegetable stall, haggled over withered turnips. Moved to a rack of used clothing, examined a cloak with holes. All the while, she was angling them toward Oskar's stall from a different direction, keeping crowds between them and the watching Gray Robe.

Finally, she stopped at a stall selling candles. From here, they had a clear line of sight to Oskar, but the Gray Robe was blocked by women haggling over fish.

"Now," Margarethe said. "Quick and quiet."

They crossed to Oskar's stall. Up close, the bookseller was even older than Thomas had thought. Ink-stained hands, fingers bent with age or arthritis. But his gaze was keen behind wrinkled lids. Perceptive. Alert.

He looked at Margarethe and went completely still.

"Heinrich's daughter," he said softly, voice rough from disuse. "I thought you'd fled the city. People said you left after… after your father."

"I tried." Margarethe leaned over a displayed gospel, feigning interest, keeping her voice low. "Got pulled back. Unfinished business."

"The dangerous kind, I imagine." But his eyes were kind. Sad. "Heinrich was a good man. I'm sorry for what they did to him."

"So am I." Margarethe turned a page, casual. "I need information, Oskar."

"Information always costs." He glanced toward where the Gray Robe was still watching, though his view was obscured. "Though for Heinrich's memory, perhaps we can negotiate a discount."

"The Order is hunting someone. Wilhelm of Eltville's grandson." She turned another page. "What's the bounty?"

Oskar's expression didn't change, but his voice dropped even lower. "Fifty gold marks. Alive, preferably. Dead if necessary. They want what he's carrying more than they want him breathing."

Thomas felt cold despite his cloak. Fifty gold marks was more money than most people in Mainz saw in a lifetime.

"Who's hunting?"

"Everyone." Oskar glanced again toward the Gray Robe. "Fifty marks is a year's income for a skilled craftsman. Two years for a laborer. The Order has made it clear—turn in the boy, no questions asked. Half the city is looking. The other half is staying quiet and hoping he gets away."

"And which half are you?"

"The half that remembers Wilhelm was a good man who deserved better." Oskar pulled another book from his stock—a prayer book, small and worn. He showed Margarethe something inside. Thomas couldn't see what. "There's talk of a cathedral search. Tonight. The Order believes Wilhelm hid something there before he died. Documents, maybe. Or another key."

"Did he?" Margarethe's voice was carefully neutral.

"If he did, I don't know where. He kept his secrets close." Oskar looked at Thomas for the first time. "Try not to die, boy. The world needs what you're carrying."

Thomas swallowed. "I'm trying."

"Try harder." Oskar handed the prayer book to Margarethe. "For your troubles. No charge. Consider it a gift in Heinrich's memory."

Margarethe took it, slipped it into her cloak without examining it. "Thank you, old friend."

"Don't thank me yet. The Order is tightening the circle. If you're still in Mainz tomorrow, you'll be in chains. Or dead." He looked past them, expression shifting. "And you're being watched. The Gray Robe is coming this way. Move. Now."

"Run or hide?"

"Neither. Disappear." Oskar raised his voice suddenly, addressing the crowd. "These merchants were just leaving! No purchase today, alas, but perhaps next market when their prices are more reasonable!"

Margarethe nodded, loud enough for others to hear. "Your prices are too high, old man. I'll find better elsewhere."

"My prices are fair!" Oskar shot back, equally loud. "It's your purse that's too light!"

They moved away, blending into the crowd. Thomas's pulse thundered in his ears. He wanted desperately to look back, but Margarethe's earlier instruction held firm: *Don't draw attention.*

They wove through the market. Past the plague cart loading new bodies—Thomas tried not to look, but caught a glimpse of a small hand, a child's hand, dangling over the edge.

He stopped, transfixed by horror.

"Keep moving," Margarethe murmured, pulling him forward.

"That child—"

"Is dead. And we can't help the dead." But her voice was tight. "I've tended plague victims for three years, Thomas. I see how it spreads."

They passed the preacher standing on an overturned crate, shouting about God's judgment. Margarethe's hand found Thomas's elbow, guided him left into a narrow space between stalls.

"Not randomly," she continued, voice low. "Through connection. One sick traveler enters a city. He infects his household. They infect their neighbors. The neighbors infect the marketplace."

She pulled him right into an alley that stank of piss and rotting garbage. Away from the crowds. Away from the dead child.

"Each case multiplies," Margarethe said. "Like fire spreading through dry timber. One flame births ten. Ten birth a hundred."

Thomas thought about the patterns in Brother Hamo's manuscripts. Families tracked across generations. Bloodlines carefully arranged.

"But here's what I've learned," Margarethe continued. "If you isolate the first case, the pattern stops. If you break the connections, the disease cannot spread. That's why they quarantine houses. Why they seal city gates. Break the connections, stop the flow."

She paused in the shadows, checking behind them.

"The Order doesn't fear plague," Thomas said slowly, understanding dawning. "They use it. They're connected—coordinating across Christendom, sharing information, positioning families. It's a network. Like the disease."

"Exactly. And to fight a network…" She didn't finish, but the implication hung between them.

You had to break the connections.

Finally, they stopped in a recessed doorway—some abandoned shop, its door boarded over. Margarethe checked the street behind them more carefully now, hand on her dagger.

"Did we lose him?"

"Perhaps. Or perhaps he knows where we're going and doesn't need to follow." She pulled out the prayer book Oskar had given her and opened it carefully.

Inside the front cover, written in tiny, cramped script barely legible, was a message.

Margarethe held it out to Thomas. "Read it. Quickly."

Thomas scanned the tiny script:

Cathedral. Tonight. Midnight. Library accessible through chapter house. Code: Psalm 117, verse 1. Brother Marcus is sympathetic. Will let you in. But leave before Lauds or Anselm will know. One hour. No more. —O

"Memorize it," Margarethe said urgently.

Thomas read it twice, fixing each word in his memory. Then Margarethe tore the page from his hands, balled it up, and put it in her mouth. Chewed.

Thomas stared. "You're eating—"

She swallowed. "Information that can't be stolen is information that survives." She closed the book, dropped it in the gutter where it landed in something foul. "We have our window. Midnight. That gives us eight hours to prepare."

"Prepare how?"

Margarethe's smile was thin and hard. "I'm going to teach you not to be completely useless. Come on."

They disappeared into the warren of Mainz's back streets, leaving the market and its hunters behind.

Back in the warehouse, Margarethe transformed from merchant to teacher.

Not the patient teacher from this morning. This was a harder kind of teaching. The kind that left bruises.

"First lesson," she said, bolting the door behind them. "Silence."

Thomas blinked. "What?"

"You move like a drunken cow. Every step announces you're coming." She pointed to the far end of the warehouse, where stacks of fabric bales created a makeshift maze. "In the cathedral tonight, you need to be a ghost. Walk from here to there without making a sound."

Thomas looked at the distance. Perhaps thirty feet. "That's all?"

"Try it."

Two hours of practice followed. Thomas failed repeatedly—sandals scuffing, robe catching, crates creaking under clumsy movements. But by the end, he could cross the warehouse with only occasional sounds. Not silent, but better.

"You learn fast when you stop fighting yourself," Margarethe said. "Next lesson."

She pulled out a simple door lock and two thin metal picks. "The cathedral library will be locked. If something happens to me, you need to get in."

She demonstrated, sliding the picks into the mechanism with practiced ease. "Feel for the pins. Let the lock tell you what it wants." She popped it open. "Your turn."

Thomas took the picks. He slid them in, felt nothing but metal scraping metal.

"You're not listening." Margarethe guided his hands. "The lock is a pattern. Pins in a sequence. Find the position each one wants. It's about understanding, not force."

Pattern.

The word shifted something in Thomas's mind. Not force—pattern-sense. Like the cipher. A puzzle waiting to be solved.

He tried again, focusing on the pattern.

Click. One pin set.

Click. Second pin.

Click. Third. Fourth.

The lock opened.

"How did you—" Margarethe took the lock back. "That took me three weeks to learn. You just did it in ten minutes."

"It's patterns," Thomas said, breathless. "Like the cipher. Once I stopped thinking of it as forcing something and started thinking of it as solving a puzzle…"

Margarethe sat back, studying him with new eyes. "Wilhelm really did see something in you. Third lesson: lying."

"You need to sell a story if we're caught." She crossed her arms. "Convince me you're a pilgrim on your way to Cologne. Go."

Thomas tried. Stammered through something about Saint Ursula, his sick mother. His face flushed, broadcasting every falsehood.

Margarethe held up a hand after his third attempt. "Stop. You're catastrophically hopeless at this. Your face gives away everything." She pinched the bridge of her nose. "New plan: you're a mute. Took a vow of silence. I'll do all the talking."

"I can try to get better—"

"No. Some people are born liars. You're born honest. In this life, that's a liability. Just don't talk unless absolutely necessary. Understood?"

"Understood."

"Last lesson: defense." She handed him a practice dagger. "I'm teaching you not to die immediately."

She came at him—slow, telegraphed.

Thomas stumbled backward, tripped, fell hard on his ass.

Margarethe laughed. Not bitter or dark—genuine. It transformed her entire face. "You looked exactly like a startled chicken."

Thomas grinned despite his embarrassment. "I warned you I was useless."

"Entertainingly incompetent," she said, still smiling.

After an hour of futile practice: "You're a scholar, not a warrior. Use your strengths—patterns, thinking three steps ahead. Leave the violence to me."

"What if something happens to you?"

"Then you run." Her expression softened—just a flicker before the mask returned. A pause, then: "You asked about my scar."

Not an answer. A deflection. But the closest thing to trust she'd offered.

Thomas looked at the thin line along her jaw.

"I got it trusting the wrong person," Margarethe said quietly. Her hand drifted unconsciously to her daggers. "A merchant who said he was part of the network. Said he could get me into a library the Order had seized. Turned out he was an informant. Led me straight into a trap."

"How did you escape?"

"Oskar got me out. Traded information for my release—valuable locations, names of safe houses." Her voice was tight with old grief. "Three people died because of what he gave up. The Order hunted them down one by one over six months. Good people. Part of the network. All dead because of my mistake. Because I trusted when I should have been suspicious."

Thomas's chest tightened. "I'm sorry."

Don't be. It taught me a lesson: trust is expensive, and betrayal is cheap. I'm telling you this because tonight, in that cathedral, we're going to be trusting a lot. Trusting Oskar's information. Trusting Brother Marcus to let us in. That's a dangerous amount of trust.

"Are you saying we shouldn't go?"

"No. I'm saying be ready for it to go wrong. Be ready to run." She pulled her cloak on, checked that her real daggers—sharp blades, killing blades—were secure. "And Thomas?"

"Aye?"

"If something goes wrong tonight—if I tell you to run—you actually do it this time. You're carrying your grandfather's legacy. That matters more than my life or yours."

"You matter to me," Thomas said before he could stop himself.

Margarethe froze. For a moment, something flickered across her face—surprise, maybe, or fear. Something vulnerable that she quickly hid.

"Don't," she said quietly. "Don't make me matter. Everyone who matters to me dies."

"Perhaps the pattern is wrong," Thomas said. "Perhaps you've just been unlucky."

"There's no such thing as luck. Just preparation and consequences." But there was something in her eyes now—not warmth, exactly. But perhaps the possibility of it. A crack in the wall. "Come on. It's almost nightfall. We need to eat something, rest if we can. Midnight comes faster than you think."

She walked past him toward the corner where they'd stored the food.

Thomas stood there a moment longer, feeling the weight of the coming night settle on his shoulders.

Tonight, they would break into the cathedral.

Tonight, they would face the Order on their own ground.

And tonight, he would discover if he was truly Wilhelm's grandson—or just another weak boy pretending to be brave.

But for now, in this moment, with Margarethe's rare laughter still echoing in the warehouse and the iron key heavy in his pocket, Thomas allowed himself to hope.

Perhaps they could do this.

Perhaps they could survive.

Perhaps he wasn't useless after all.

Midnight.

They crouched in the shadows across from Cathedral St. Martin, watching. Waiting.

The great church loomed against the night sky like a mountain of stone and faith, its spire a dark needle pointing toward uncaring stars. Plague bells rang somewhere in the city—another cart of bodies making its slow journey to the mass graves. The distant rumble of wooden wheels on cobblestones, the murmured prayers of the cart drivers, all of it muffled by November cold. Thomas pulled his cloak tighter, breath coming out in visible clouds.

"Remember the plan," Margarethe whispered. "Chapter house entrance on the south side. Psalm 117, verse 1—*Praise the Lord, all nations*. Brother Marcus should let us in. If he doesn't, if something's wrong, we run. No hesitation."

"And if he does?"

"Then we have one hour. Perhaps less. The Gray Robes change guard at Lauds—that's our deadline." She checked the street—empty, silent except for distant coughing from a plague house three doors down. "Stay close. Stay quiet. And for the love of God, don't trip over your own feet."

"I've been practicing."

"I know. You're almost competent now." But she was smiling in the darkness.

They crossed the square quickly, keeping to the shadows cast by the moon. The cathedral's side entrance was a small wooden door, unremarkable and easy to miss unless you knew it was there.

Margarethe knocked. Three soft raps.

Silence.

Thomas's heart hammered hard enough that he was sure it could be heard. This was it. If Oskar had been wrong, if Brother Marcus wasn't sympathetic, if the Order was waiting—

The door opened a crack.

A young monk peered out, his face pale and nervous in the candlelight he carried. "Yes?"

Margarethe leaned close, pitched her voice just loud enough to be heard. "*Praise the Lord, all nations*," she quoted softly.

The monk's eyes widened. Recognition and fear in equal measure. He glanced behind him into the darkness of the chapter house, then opened the door wider. "Quickly. Before someone sees."

They slipped inside.

The chapter house was dark except for the single candle the monk carried, its flame barely pushing back the shadows. The smell hit Thomas immediately—frankincense and myrrh, sweet and heavy, mixing with the musty scent of old stone and the clean bite of beeswax. Wood polish. Parchment dust. So different from the plague-stink of the streets that it almost made him dizzy.

"Brother Marcus?" Margarethe asked.

"Aye." The monk bolted the door behind them—three heavy bolts sliding home with solid clicks. He was young, Thomas realized. Perhaps twenty-five, with the kind of face that looked like it wanted to be kind but had learned not to be. "Oskar sent word you'd come. I've been watching for you since Compline."

"The library?"

Marcus gestured down a dark corridor with his candle. "Through the nave, past the high altar, behind the choir. The door is locked, but…" He looked at Margarethe's face, seemed to understand. "You'll manage, I imagine."

"Why are you helping us?" Thomas couldn't stop himself from asking.

Marcus's smile was sad, tinged with old grief. "Because Wilhelm of Eltville was kind to me when I was a novice and everyone else treated me like I was invisible. Because knowledge should serve God and humanity, not power and control. Because the Order has forgotten what mercy means." He handed Margarethe the candle. "One hour. No more. After that, I can't help you. I won't even be able to pretend I didn't know you were here."

"Thank you," Margarethe said quietly.

"Don't thank me until you're safely out." He opened the interior door. "Go. And may God protect you, because I can't."

They went.

The nave of the cathedral was vast and dark, their footsteps echoing despite Thomas's best efforts at silence. Each step seemed to announce itself to the vaulted ceiling, to the painted saints staring down from the walls. Moonlight filtered through stained glass windows, painting the floor in patches of deep red and blue—colors that looked like blood and bruises in the darkness.

They reached the high altar. Behind it, a smaller door—the entrance to the choir and, beyond that, the library.

Locked.

Margarethe pulled out her picks, but Thomas stopped her with a touch on her arm. "Let me try."

She hesitated for just a moment, then nodded. "Fast as you can. We're exposed here."

Thomas knelt before the lock. Inserted the picks with trembling hands. Felt for the pattern the way Margarethe had taught him.

This lock was more complex—six pins instead of four, the tolerances tighter, the springs stiffer. But the principle was the same. Pattern recognition. Understanding the sequence. Listening to what the lock wanted to tell him.

First pin.

Second pin.

Third—

The third pin stuck, resisting. Thomas adjusted the tension on his pick, probed more gently.

Come on. Show me where you want to be. Tell me the pattern.

Click.

Fourth pin.

Fifth pin.

Sixth pin.

The lock opened.

"Forty seconds," Margarethe breathed. Her eyes widened. "You did that in forty seconds."

Thomas stood, breathless. "The pattern was clear once I stopped trying to force it."

"You're going to be insufferable about this, aren't you?" But she was smiling.

They slipped into the library.

And Thomas forgot how to breathe.

The room was enormous—two full stories of manuscripts and knowledge, treasures beyond counting. Chained volumes lined the walls and filled standing desks. Latin, Greek, even some Arabic texts that must have cost a fortune. Theological works, natural philosophy, astronomy, medicine. The collected wisdom of centuries.

Or hoarded and controlled, depending on your perspective. Depending on whether you were Wilhelm, who believed knowledge should be free, or the Order, who believed it should be guarded.

"There," Margarethe pointed to a desk near the back. "The Boethius commentaries. That's where Hamo was working before they killed him."

Thomas crossed to the desk and found the commentary—the same volume from that terrible morning. Someone had cleaned it, but faint brown stains remained on the vellum.

Hamo's blood.

Later. Grieve later. Right now, finish what he started.

He pulled out the iron key, studied the manuscript margins. Colored dots—red, blue, yellow—encoding information that had cost so many lives.

"Which page?" Margarethe asked, watching the door.

Thomas flipped through carefully. The dots appeared on multiple pages, but one section had denser concentration. The commentary on *Consolation of Philosophy*, Book V—fate and free will.

He found the textual anchor—*"divine foreknowledge"* underlined in faded ink—and aligned the key.

Through the aperture, dots appeared in sharp focus. Thomas counted automatically.

"Five red, two blue, three yellow," he murmured. "Position five-two-three. That's…" He closed his eyes, searching his memory. "I don't know that code."

"Let me see." Margarethe leaned over his shoulder, close enough that he could smell rosemary and steel. She looked at the pattern and her face went pale. "That's not a location code."

"Then what is it?"

"A warning." She pointed to the specific arrangement. "See how the blue dots bracket the red ones in pairs? That's a danger pattern—it means the information itself is dangerous. And the count—five-two-three—that's a date marker."

"Date of what?"

"I don't know. The cipher usually marks places, not events." She stopped, staring at the page more closely. "Thomas. Look at the text itself. Not the dots. The actual words Hamo was copying."

Thomas read the Latin. Standard theological discussion of divine providence and whether God knew the future or whether free will existed.

Except.

In the margin, in tiny script barely visible even in the candlelight, was a notation in different ink. Fresher ink. Hamo's handwriting.

They know what's coming. They always have. The Order didn't predict the plague—they prepared for it. Dots placed fifty years before plague arrival. Impossible unless they planned it.

Check Constantinople records. Plague of Justinian, 541 CE. Do the patterns match?

If true, then Wilhelm was right. The Order is old. Older than the Church. Older than—

Thomas's hands went cold. The last entry stopped mid-sentence, ink trailing off. That must have been when the Gray Robes killed him.

"He figured it out," Margarethe whispered. "The cipher wasn't just recording plague survival patterns. It was expecting it."

"We need to copy this," Thomas said urgently. "All of it. If Hamo died to understand this—"

"No time." Margarethe had moved to the door, listening intently. "We've been here twenty minutes already. We need to find what we came for and leave before—"

Footsteps in the corridor outside.

Multiple sets. Heavy boots, not the soft sandals of monks.

Margarethe's hand went to her dagger in one smooth motion. "Gray Robes."

"Brother Marcus—"

"Either he betrayed us or they caught him. Doesn't matter which." Margarethe looked around the library with quick, desperate eyes. One entrance. No windows large enough for escape. Stone walls too thick to break through. "We're trapped."

The footsteps were getting closer. Calm voices, methodical:

"—check the library first—"

"—Brother Marcus confessed they entered through the chapter house—"

"—Brother Anselm wants them alive if possible, but dead is acceptable—"

"The key," Margarethe hissed. "Use it. Find the next location—now. If we're going to die here, at least understand what we're dying for."

Thomas turned back to the manuscript, hands shaking so badly he could barely hold the key steady. Forced himself to concentrate. *Breathe. Focus. See the pattern.*

Another page. Even denser concentration of dots, arranged in patterns he'd never seen before. He aligned the key, barely breathing.

Seven red, seven blue, seven yellow. Position seven-seven-seven.

"What does that mean?"

Margarethe's eyes widened as she looked at the pattern. "Seven. That's the sacred number. Seven days of creation, seven cardinal virtues, seven—"

"Seven keys," Thomas breathed, understanding hitting him like cold water. "This isn't encoding a location. It's encoding a revelation."

"What?"

Thomas stared at the pattern. Pattern recognition. See the whole, not just the parts.

He looked at the entire page—text, illuminations, structure.

And he saw it.

The dots formed lines. Connections. Not a map of places—a map of people. Of bloodlines. Families tracked across generations.

"They weren't recording who survived," Thomas said, voice shaking. "They were tracking bloodlines. Specific traits passed through generations. This manuscript is from 1200. They were tracking these families for 150 years before the plague arrived."

The footsteps were in the library now. Searching systematically. Getting closer.

"—check between the manuscript stacks—"

"—they have to be here somewhere—"

Margarethe grabbed Thomas's arm hard enough to hurt. "We need to go. Right now."

"There's no other way out—"

"Then we make one." She looked up at the library's second floor—a gallery with more manuscripts. And high on the wall, narrow windows. Too small for a grown man to fit through.

But perhaps not too small for a thin scribe.

"Up," Margarethe commanded. "Move!"

They ran for the spiral stairs to the gallery. The Gray Robes saw them—shouts echoed through the library:

"There! The upper level!"

"Cut them off at the stairs!"

Thomas and Margarethe reached the gallery, iron-shod boots pounding up the stairs behind them. The high windows were twenty feet above the ground outside.

Margarethe pulled out a dagger, used the pommel to smash the glass. The sound was deafeningly loud—glass shattering, shards falling. An alarm for anyone within a hundred yards.

Shouts below. Multiple voices. Footsteps thundering on the stairs.

"Go!" Margarethe boosted Thomas toward the broken window. Sharp glass edges tore at his clothes, cut his arms, but he was thin enough to fit. Barely. He squeezed through, emerged onto a narrow stone ledge running along the cathedral's exterior.

Two stories up. The cobblestone square far below, hard and unforgiving.

Margarethe followed him through the window with practiced grace. A Gray Robe behind her tried to squeeze through, got stuck halfway, cursed.

"Can you climb?" Margarethe asked, already scanning the wall.

Thomas looked up at the rough-cut stone, the carved decorations, the gargoyles leering from the eaves. "I have no choice, do I?"

"Not really."

Behind them, the Gray Robe was pulling himself back inside, shouting orders: "Get archers! Now!"

Thomas started climbing.

He jammed his fingers into carved grooves meant for gargoyle drainage. Stone bit into his palms. His arms screamed protest, muscles burning from shoulder to wrist. Sharp edges opened his fingertips, blood making every grip slick and uncertain.

One foot slipped.

For a terrible moment he hung by his fingers alone, two stories of empty air below him.

"Don't look down," Margarethe called. She climbed beside him with easy grace. "Focus on the next handhold. One at a time."

Thomas didn't feel fine. He felt like he was about to die.

But he climbed.

His world narrowed to stone and breath and burning muscles.

Reach.

Grip.

Pull.

Find the next hold.

Don't think about falling.

He reached the roof edge and pulled himself over with the last of his strength, lay gasping on the cold tiles. His arms felt like they were on fire.

Margarethe landed beside him, barely winded. "We need to keep moving. They'll have archers—"

An arrow struck the tiles three inches from Thomas's head, the impact sending chips of ceramic flying.

"—if they think to post them," Margarethe finished. "Move!"

They ran.

The cathedral roof was a landscape of slopes and spires, gargoyles and gutters, treacherous tiles that cracked and slid under their feet. Wind bit through Thomas's thin robes—November cold at rooftop height, sharp enough to steal breath. Below, more shouts. The Gray Robes were gathering, spreading around the building like wolves circling prey.

"There!" Margarethe pointed to an adjacent building—a wealthy merchant's house, its roof close enough that the gap between them was perhaps six feet.

She didn't hesitate. Ran and jumped the gap in one smooth motion, landing in a crouch on the other roof.

Thomas skidded to the edge. Six feet of empty air yawned between the buildings. The cobblestones below swam in his vision—three stories down, hard enough to shatter bone. His legs locked.

"Thomas!" Margarethe called. "Jump! Now!"

More arrows whistled past. Behind him, a Gray Robe was pulling himself onto the roof, sword in hand.

Thomas backed up three steps. Ran. Leaped into the void.

For a moment, he was flying. Suspended over empty space. The ground was so far below. Time stretched and slowed and he was certain he wouldn't make it—

Then Margarethe's hand caught his wrist, yanking him forward with strength he didn't know she had. He crashed onto the merchant's roof tiles hard enough to knock the wind out of him.

"I hate you," Thomas gasped.

"You love me," she shot back, grinning wildly despite everything. "Now move before they start shooting at us again!"

They ran across the merchant's roof, down to a lower level, through someone's rooftop garden with its winter-dead plants, finally dropping into a narrow alley. Margarethe landed in a perfect crouch. Thomas landed in an ungraceful heap that would definitely leave bruises.

"I really need to teach you how to fall properly," Margarethe said, pulling him to his feet.

They ran through the night-maze of Mainz's back streets, the alarm bells ringing behind them, the Order rousing to hunt them down with renewed fury.

But they were alive.

And they had the knowledge Hamo had died to protect.

The cipher wasn't just a map of hidden texts and secret knowledge.

It was a map of human bloodlines, tracked for generations before the plague. Before it should have been possible to know it was coming.

The Order had known. Had prepared. Had guided specific families to specific places.

The question was why.

And Thomas suspected—no, he *knew*—that the answer was going to be worse than he could possibly imagine.

They didn't make it back to the warehouse.

The streets were too watched now, too dangerous. The Order had turned out in full strength—Thomas could hear whistles in the distance, calling search parties together. They'd killed Brother Anselm's men yesterday. Now they'd broken into the cathedral itself. The Order wouldn't rest until they were captured or dead.

Margarethe led them instead to a different safe house—a tanner's shop in the tanners' quarter, abandoned since the plague had killed its owner two months ago.

The smell hit Thomas like a fist. Half-worked hides rotting in their lime baths. Tanning lye so caustic it burned the back of his throat. Underneath it all, the sweet corruption of flesh left too long in summer heat and never properly cleared away. His eyes watered. His stomach turned.

But it was shelter.

It was hidden.

They'd been there perhaps an hour, catching their breath, tending to Thomas's scraped hands and Margarethe's cut arm from the broken window glass, when the door opened.

No warning.

No sound of picking the lock.

Just the door swinging open silently, hinges moving without even a whisper of protest.

Brother Anselm walked in alone.

He moved like water flowing downhill—calm, inevitable, impossible to stop. The lamplight they'd lit caught his gray robes, made the silver key pendant at his throat gleam. His footsteps were soundless on the wooden floor. His face was gentle, sad, almost grandfatherly. Kind eyes in a weathered face. He looked like someone who would listen to your confession and offer comfort.

Thomas had never been more terrified in his life.

Margarethe's dagger was out instantly. "Don't move."

"I'm not here to fight, Heinrich's daughter." Anselm raised his hands slowly, showing they were empty. His voice was soft, reasonable—the voice of a patient teacher. "I'm here to talk. To offer you both a choice before this ends badly for everyone."

"The Order doesn't talk," Margarethe said, knuckles white around her dagger hilts. "It tortures and kills. Like it did to my father."

"Sometimes. When necessary. When there's no other option." Anselm's voice carried genuine regret. "Your father, for instance. I took no pleasure in his death, Margarethe. None. But he wouldn't listen. Wouldn't understand what was truly at stake."

Margarethe's hand shook with fury. "You *murdered* him."

"I gave him a chance to join us. To help preserve what matters most—human knowledge, human survival. He chose ideology over pragmatism." Anselm looked at Thomas, eyes genuinely sad. "Wilhelm made the same choice. Brilliant men, both of them. Gifted with intelligence and vision. Wasted on impossible ideals."

"Don't speak about my grandfather."

"Why not? I knew him well. We studied together in Paris, decades ago. Before he decided that knowledge should belong to everyone instead of being protected by those wise enough to guard it." Anselm moved further into the room with slow, non-threatening steps. "You found the Boethius manuscript. You saw what your friend Hamo discovered before we had to stop him."

"The bloodlines," Thomas said. "You're tracking families across generations."

"We're preserving families." Anselm's voice carried absolute conviction. "Do you know what happened before Rome fell? Before the Bronze Age collapsed? Before every great realm in history died?"

Neither of them answered.

"Knowledge was shared freely. Libraries open to anyone. Every fool with a question could access power they didn't understand—medicine that could kill, geometry that could destroy, philosophy that tore apart kingdoms. And every time, they destroyed themselves with tools they didn't respect."

"So you hoard knowledge to prevent catastrophe," Margarethe said bitterly.

"We preserve knowledge to ensure survival." Real pain in Anselm's eyes. "Your father's work, Wilhelm's cipher network—you think it was about spreading knowledge, universal enlightenment. It wasn't. It was about selection. Ensuring the right knowledge reached the right people at the right time."

"Who decides what's right?" Thomas demanded.

"Those who understand the patterns. Who can see the long arc of history." Anselm gestured to the iron key in Thomas's pocket. "That key is one of seven. Each unlocks part of the Genesis Protocol—accumulated knowledge of how kingdoms fall and how they might be saved. The Order compiled it after Rome fell, to ensure the next age would be better. More stable. Less prone to collapse."

"By controlling who survives?"

"By ensuring the people who can survive—who carry the right traits, the right knowledge, the right bloodlines—are positioned correctly when catastrophe comes." Anselm pulled out a manuscript from his robes—Thomas recognized it as another copy of the Boethius commentary. "The plague currently killing Europe isn't random chance or God's punishment. It follows specific patterns. Trade routes. Population centers. Specific family lineages. The cipher tracks who has natural resistance in their blood, who doesn't. We guide the resistant ones to safe locations. We… redirect the others to places where the plague will find them."

Margarethe made a strangled sound. "You're helping the plague kill people. You're not just allowing it—you're *directing* it."

"We're helping the right people survive while the wrong ones die." Anselm's voice was patient, like explaining simple mathematics to a slow child. "Without our intervention, the plague kills indiscriminately. With our guidance, it becomes selection. Painful, yes. Tragic, certainly. But necessary for what comes after."

"Madness," Thomas whispered.

"Survival." Anselm looked at him with something almost like pity. "Thomas, you have your grandfather's gift. Pattern sense. Uncanny memory. The ability to see connections others miss. Do you think that's coincidence? That you just happened to be born with those exact traits?"

Thomas's world tilted sideways.

"No," Anselm continued softly. "You're carrying traits the Order has been breeding for forty generations. Your family line was selected, guided, preserved to make someone like you. Your grandfather's marriage, your grandmother's bloodline, even your parents' union—all guided by the Order to create the perfect combination."

Thomas's world tilted. "No."

"Aye. Wilhelm realized what he was—their handiwork, built through generations. It horrified him. So he tried to rebel, to unmake the thing that had made him. And it killed him." Anselm stepped closer. "You can make a different choice, Thomas. Join us. Use your gift to select the next generation. Help humanity survive what's coming."

"What's coming?" Margarethe asked, voice deadly quiet.

"Worse than plague. Worse than Rome's fall. Worse than anything that's come before." Anselm's face was grave. "The cycles are accelerating. Bronze Age collapse, 1200 BCE. Rome, 400 CE. Now, 1347. Again and again, everything burns. The Genesis Protocol was meant to ensure that when it does, the right people are

positioned to raise the world again from ash. But only if we complete it. Only if we preserve the bloodlines and the knowledge through this collapse."

"And if we refuse?" Thomas asked, though he already knew the answer.

"Then you die tonight. Margarethe dies tonight. And the knowledge you're carrying dies with you." Anselm's voice hardened slightly, iron underneath the gentle surface. "I'm offering you a choice your grandfather didn't get, Thomas. Join us willingly, or die fighting us uselessly. But either way, the Protocol continues. It always continues."

Thomas looked at Margarethe. She was rigid with fury, her dagger still pointed at Anselm's heart, hand perfectly steady despite everything. But her eyes met Thomas's, and in them he saw a question:

What do we do?

Thomas thought about Hamo, dying in the scriptorium with a blade in his chest. About his grandfather Wilhelm, murdered for believing knowledge should be free. About all the people the Order had killed in the name of preservation and survival.

And he thought about the bloodlines in the manuscript. The families tracked for generations like breeding stock. The certainty that his entire existence had been shaped, bred, guided. That he wasn't a person so much as something made.

"No," he said quietly. The word felt like stepping off a cliff.

Anselm's expression didn't change. "You're certain? You understand what you're refusing?"

"Knowledge should be free," Thomas said, voice growing stronger. "Even dangerous knowledge. Especially dangerous knowledge. Because the only thing more dangerous than knowledge freely shared is knowledge hoarded by those who think they're wise enough to control it."

He pulled out the iron key, held it up. "My grandfather believed that. So do I."

"Then you're a fool, like he was." Anselm's hand moved—faster than seemed possible for a man his age—and suddenly there was a dagger in it. Long, thin, deadly. "And fools don't survive long in this world."

He lunged at Thomas.

Margarethe intercepted, her blade meeting his with a sound like breaking bells. Steel on steel, sharp and harsh in the small space.

They fought.

Anselm moved with brutal efficiency, every movement precise and economical. No wasted motion. No flourishes. Just practical, practiced violence from someone who'd killed more times than Thomas could imagine.

Margarethe fought with desperate skill, her father's blades extensions of her arms. But Thomas could see immediately that she was outmatched.

Anselm was better. Older, more experienced, utterly calm even in combat. He drove Margarethe back step by step, corraling her toward the corner, cutting off her angles of escape.

"You fight like your father," Anselm said, almost conversationally, not even breathing hard. "Brave. Skilled. But ultimately predictable."

Margarethe's response was a vicious slash that Anselm barely dodged, the blade close enough to cut a thin line across his cheek.

Thomas scrambled back, unable to help. He couldn't fight someone like Anselm.

But patterns. There had to be a pattern.

He looked around frantically. The room. Anselm's positioning. The way he was deliberately driving Margarethe toward the corner, cutting off her escape routes, controlling the space.

Which meant his back was to Thomas. Exposed.

On the table—a leather-working tool the previous owner had left behind. Heavy. Sharp. Meant for cutting thick hides.

Thomas grabbed it.

Margarethe saw him out of the corner of her eye, understood instantly what he was planning. She feinted left—Anselm moved to block—then dove right, throwing herself clear of the line between Thomas and Anselm.

Thomas threw the tool with everything he had.

It flew poorly—tumbling end over end, no accuracy, no power.

But it struck Anselm in the shoulder. Not lethal. Not even seriously damaging. But surprising.

The Brother spun, his dagger coming up to face this new threat—

Margarethe's blade found his exposed side, sliding between the ribs with the ease of someone who knew exactly where to strike.

Anselm made a small, surprised sound. Looked down at the blood spreading across his gray robes, dark and wet in the lamplight.

"Fools sometimes survive," Margarethe said coldly, breathing hard. "Because they're unpredictable. Because they work together instead of alone. Because they care about something more than just survival."

Anselm collapsed slowly, controlled even in falling. His breathing was shallow, wet. He looked at Thomas, and his expression was… sad. Not angry. Not hateful. Just profoundly, deeply sad.

"You don't understand what you've done," he whispered. Blood ran from the corner of his mouth. "The Protocol… someone has to complete it… or everything burns… again… always again…"

"Then we'll rebuild without controlling who gets to survive," Thomas said. He knelt beside the dying man, and found himself crying for reasons he didn't fully understand. "We'll find another way."

Anselm smiled—blood on his teeth, the light fading from his eyes. "Wilhelm… would be proud… and wrong… you'll see… when the burning comes… you'll understand…"

He died.

Thomas knelt there beside the body, shaking. He'd killed someone. Not with his own hand, but his action had led directly to this death. Two nights ago, he'd been a scribe, copying texts and praying with the brothers. Now he was a killer. Now there was blood on his hands, even if the blade had been Margarethe's.

"We need to go," Margarethe said. Her voice was steady, controlled, but she cleaned her blade twice before sheathing it. "The Order will find his body. They'll come for us with everything they have. We just killed their lead inquisitor."

"Where do we go?"

"Out of Mainz. Tonight. Before they seal the city gates." She looked at Anselm's body, and for a moment something flickered in her eyes—grief, maybe, or regret. "He was wrong. But he believed he was right. Believed it absolutely. That's almost worse than being evil. He thought he was saving the world."

Thomas nodded. Couldn't speak. His throat was too tight.

They gathered what little they had—the iron key, the manuscripts Margarethe had hidden in her cloak, a small purse of coins. Slipped out into the plague-haunted streets for what Thomas knew would be the last time.

Behind them, Mainz—the city of his grandfather's birth, the place where Brother Hamo had died, where Thomas had discovered both the cipher and Margarethe—slept on, unaware.

Ahead lay the river docks and whatever Margarethe had arranged there.

Thomas clutched the iron key in his pocket and tried not to think about Anselm's dying words:

Someone has to complete the Protocol, or everything burns.

What if the Order was right?

What if knowledge, freely shared, really did lead to catastrophe—to collapse—to the burning of everything they'd built?

What if he and Margarethe were wrong to fight them?

What if his grandfather had been wrong?

The questions followed him into the darkness toward the river.

But one thing was absolutely certain:

He was committed now. For better or worse, for right or wrong, there was no going back.

The path forward was set.

And soon Mainz would wake, and the hunt would begin.

CHAPTER 3 - THE FEVER

1347, Rhine River Docks, Mainz

The alarm bells started ringing at dawn.

Clanging. Urgent. Relentless.

Thomas heard them echo across Mainz—cathedral bells, church bells, even the plague bells repurposed for a different kind of death. The Order had found Anselm's body.

"Faster," Margarethe hissed, pulling him through the tanners' quarter. The stench of tanning chemicals was a wall. Thomas swallowed bile and forced himself forward.

The bells changed everything.

Now doors would be opening. Shutters would be thrown wide. Citizens stumbling into streets, asking questions, looking for the source of alarm.

And the Gray Robes would be hunting.

"Will he be there?" Thomas asked, breathing hard, lungs burning. "Your smuggler?"

"He'd better be. I paid him enough." Margarethe checked the street behind them, hand on the knife at her belt. Clear for now. "And if he's not, we steal a boat and hope we can outrun arrows better than guards."

The Rhine came into view between buildings—a dark ribbon reflecting the first gray light of dawn.

Water sounds reached them: the slap of small waves against pilings, the creak of wood straining against rope, the distant call of a boatman somewhere upriver. The smell changed—fish and wet wood replacing the tannery stench, morning mist carrying the scent of reeds and river mud.

The docks were mostly empty at this hour. A few fishermen were preparing their nets with the steady efficiency of decades. A merchant boat was being loaded with barrels, probably wine. And there, at the farthest dock, almost hidden in morning mist, a small river craft with a single figure waiting beside it.

Margarethe grabbed Thomas's arm, grip iron-strong. "That's him. Otto the Weasel. Don't let the name fool you—he's the best smuggler on the Rhine."

They crossed the open ground to the dock, exposed and vulnerable. Thomas kept expecting shouts, arrows, the sound of boots on cobblestones. His shoulders hunched involuntarily, anticipating the bite of steel. But they reached the boat without incident.

Otto the Weasel was aptly named—thin as a starving dog, nervous energy radiating from him, with quick eyes that never stopped moving. He looked at Margarethe and his expression shifted from relief to horror.

"You're late. And the whole city is—" He stopped, listening to the alarm bells echoing across the water. "Mother of God. What did you do?"

"Nothing that concerns you," Margarethe said, already climbing into the boat with practiced ease. "You're being paid to ask no questions and get us downriver. So get us downriver."

"I'm being paid to smuggle goods, not fugitives who've—" Otto's eyes went wide as he looked past them. "Robes. Gray Robes on the docks. They've seen us!"

Thomas spun. Three men in gray robes were running toward them, perhaps a hundred yards away and closing fast. Two had bows already strung, arrows nocked. Morning light caught on the metal arrowheads.

"Cast off!" Margarethe shouted. "Now!"

Otto fumbled with the mooring rope. "This is madness, this is—"

"Now!"

The rope came free. Otto shoved the boat away from the dock with a long pole, muscles straining. They drifted into the current, agonizingly slow.

Too slow.

"Down!" Margarethe yanked Thomas to the deck.

The first arrow whistled overhead—a sound like wind through reeds but sharper, angrier. It struck the mast with a solid *thunk* that vibrated through the entire boat, wood shuddering under the impact.

The second arrow—Thomas didn't see it coming. Just heard Margarethe's sharp intake of breath, saw her stumble.

"Margarethe!"

She was still standing, but an arrow protruded from her left shoulder, just below the collarbone. Her face had gone pale as parchment. Blood was already spreading through the fabric of her cloak, a dark stain growing with terrifying speed.

"I'm fine," she said through gritted teeth. "Stay down."

A third arrow hit the side of the boat, splintering the wooden hull. A fourth splashed into the water beside them, close enough that spray hit Thomas's face.

But they were in the current now, picking up speed. Otto worked the sail with frantic efficiency, catching the morning wind that came down the valley. The distance between them and the docks grew—fifty yards, seventy-five, a hundred.

The Gray Robes had stopped shooting. Too far now. But Thomas could see more figures gathering on the docks. Someone was shouting orders. They'd pursue, of course. On horseback along the river road, or in faster boats.

"Let me see," Thomas said, reaching for Margarethe.

"I said I'm fine." She swayed, catching herself against the mast. Her breathing had gone shallow.

Thomas ignored her protest and moved closer to examine the wound. The arrow had gone deep into the muscle, maybe touching bone. Blood soaked her cloak, dripped onto the deck. Too much blood.

"You're not fine. You're bleeding."

"It's just a—" She stopped, took a breath that caught in her throat. "Just a flesh wound."

"Deep in the muscle. Maybe touching bone." Thomas had seen enough injuries in the monastery infirmary to recognize a serious wound. "It needs to come out. Now."

Otto called from the tiller, voice high with panic: "There's a medical kit under the forward bench. Basic supplies. But if you're thinking of pulling that arrow, do it quick. We can't have her screaming when we pass the watchtowers downstream."

Margarethe's jaw tightened. "I don't scream."

"Everyone screams," Otto muttered.

Thomas found the kit—leather satchel containing bandages, a bottle that smelled like strong wine, needle and thread, a knife. He brought it back to where Margarethe sat, or rather half-collapsed.

"This is going to hurt."

"Everything hurts. Just do it." But he could see the fear in her eyes now, the way her good hand gripped the mast so hard her knuckles had gone white.

Thomas had never done this before. Had watched the infirmarian treat injuries, had helped hold patients still, had fetched supplies. But never actually extracted an arrow from flesh.

He examined the shaft. Smooth wood, well-made. At least it wasn't barbed—those were nightmares to remove. This should come clean if he pulled straight.

Should.

"On three," he said. "One—"

He pulled.

Margarethe's breath hissed between her teeth, a sound like steam escaping. Her body went rigid, every muscle locked tight. But she didn't scream. Didn't even cry out. Just went taut as a drawn bowstring, her good hand clenching the mast hard enough that her knuckles cracked.

The arrow came free. Blood followed, dark and thick.

Thomas grabbed a cloth from the kit, pressed it hard against the wound. "Hold this. Press as hard as you can."

Margarethe obeyed, her face gray now, eyes slightly unfocused.

Thomas opened the bottle—definitely wine, strong and cheap. "This is going to hurt worse than the arrow."

"Just—" Margarethe managed through clenched teeth. "Just do it."

He pulled the cloth away and poured wine directly into the wound.

This time she did cry out—a sharp, bitten-off sound that ended almost before it began. Her whole body went taut, back arching.

But she didn't pass out. Just breathed in ragged gasps while Thomas worked, packing the wound with clean cloth, wrapping bandages tight around her shoulder and under her arm.

"Done," he said finally. "It's… it's not good, but it's the best I can do."

Margarethe nodded, not speaking. Her eyes were closed, breathing shallow. Sweat beaded her forehead despite the cool morning air.

"You should lie down. Rest."

"Can't. Need to watch for—" She swayed.

Thomas caught her before she fell, eased her down onto a pile of canvas sailcloth that smelled of mildew and fish. "I'll watch. You rest."

"Thomas—"

"I'll watch," he repeated firmly. "You saved my life yesterday. Today I save yours. That's how this works."

Margarethe looked at him for a long moment. Then, finally, she nodded and closed her eyes.

Within minutes, her breathing had evened out into sleep. But Thomas could see the flush starting on her cheeks, the sweat beading despite the chill.

Fever. The wound was already infected.

Otto called softly from the stern: "She's tough, that one. Tougher than most men I've smuggled."

"How long to Cologne?"

"Three days if the wind holds and the weather cooperates. Perhaps four if we hit rain." Otto spat over the side. "She got family there? Someone who can care for her properly?"

"A contact. An alchemist."

"An alchemist?" Otto's eyebrows rose. "Well, they know about poisons and cures, I suppose. Let's hope he's the healing kind and not the other."

Thomas looked down at Margarethe. Her face was peaceful in sleep, but he could see the pain in the lines around her eyes, the tension in her jaw even unconscious. Three days. Perhaps four.

She had to survive that long.

Behind them, Mainz faded into the morning mist—cathedral spires disappearing, bells still ringing their alarm. Ahead, the Rhine stretched toward Cologne and whatever came next.

Thomas pulled out the iron key, turned it over. The eye symbol stared back, unblinking. They'd killed for this. Margarethe was wounded, maybe dying, because of this.

But sitting on a smuggler's boat with a wounded woman who trusted him, Thomas made a silent promise.

Whatever this key opened, whatever secrets the cipher held, he would see it through. Not for glory or power.

For Wilhelm, who'd built this network.

For Hamo, who'd died pressing this key into his palm.

For Margarethe, who'd given everything to protect knowledge she couldn't even read.

He would see it through to the end.

1347, Day Two on the Rhine

Margarethe's fever started that night.

Thomas tried to keep her comfortable—rigged a crude shelter from canvas to protect her from the wind, got her to drink water when she was lucid enough to swallow. But as the sun set on their first day on the river, painting the water blood-red and gold, her skin grew hot to the touch and her breathing turned ragged.

By the second morning, she was delirious.

"Father," she mumbled, eyes open but unseeing, pupils dilated and unfocused. "I remembered. All 217. I didn't forget a single one."

Thomas dampened a cloth with river water—cold, slightly muddy, probably not clean enough but better than nothing. He pressed it to her forehead, felt the fever burning through her skin. "Shhh. Rest. Save your strength."

"Can't rest. Have to remember. If I forget, they're lost." Her good hand clutched at Thomas's sleeve. "Promise me. Promise if I forget…"

"You won't forget," he said softly. "You've never forgotten. You won't start now."

"Everyone forgets eventually."

Otto glanced over from the tiller. "How is she?"

"Worse." The wound was angry and red, infection setting deep. Willow bark hadn't helped.

He stayed by her side as the boat drifted downstream. Riverbanks sliding past—villages, vineyards, watch-towers. Life continuing on, oblivious.

To keep himself from panic, to keep his mind from spiraling into useless fear, Thomas turned to the manuscripts they'd taken from the cathedral library. Spread them carefully on the deck, weighted down with stones from the ballast. Used the iron key to decode what he could.

And that's when he saw it.

The pattern that changed everything.

He'd been studying a merchant's ledger from 1290—nearly sixty years old, the vellum yellowed and brittle. The marginal cipher dots were faded but still visible. He aligned the key with the textual anchor point, counted the dots that appeared through the aperture.

Position marker: 4-2-7. That corresponded to a location—somewhere in Bavaria, if he was reading the system correctly.

But beside the position marker was something else. A different notation. Not colored dots but tiny scratched symbols that looked like Roman numerals, barely visible against the vellum.

DCCXL.

Thomas's education kicked in automatically. D = 500. CC = 200. XL = 40.

740.

A date? In what system? It couldn't be years since Christ's birth—this manuscript was from 1290, so 740 would be 550 years earlier.

His heart started beating faster. He pulled out another manuscript—a theological commentary from 1215. Found a similar notation in the cipher marks.

DCCC.

800.

He checked manuscript after manuscript. Every cipher entry had two components: the position marker (location) and a number scratched beside it (date?).

But the dates didn't make sense. The manuscript from 1290 referenced 740. The one from 1215 referenced 800. The dates were before the manuscripts were created, sometimes by centuries.

Unless…

Unless the cipher wasn't recording when the knowledge was hidden. It was recording when the knowledge was created. Or when the events the knowledge described had occurred.

Which meant the Order wasn't tracking current information. It was tracking ancient information—knowledge that predated the manuscripts by centuries, maybe longer.

He found the oldest manuscript they had—a fragment of text from what looked like the 9th century, barely legible, the vellum crumbling at the edges. The cipher marks were primitive compared to the later ones, cruder in execution but following the same basic structure.

And the date notation: CCCC.

400.

Four hundred CE. When Rome was falling. When the Western Empire was collapsing into the chaos that would become the Dark Ages.

"My God," Thomas whispered.

"What?" Otto called from the stern. "Find something?"

Thomas looked up. "The cipher. It's not medieval. It's… it's ancient. The Order has been operating since at least the fall of Rome. Perhaps longer."

Otto shrugged, unimpressed. "Means nothing to me. I just smuggle things and avoid customs men."

But it meant everything to Thomas.

A memory surfaced—Wilhelm in the scriptorium, eight years ago.

Young Thomas copying a genealogy, focused on perfect letters. Wilhelm had stopped, studying the pattern.

"When you copy manuscripts, do not see only the words before you. Look for patterns across pages, across years. The scribes before you left signs for those who can see."

Wilhelm had pulled out three manuscripts—different hands, different cities, different decades. Shown Thomas the similar patterns of dots in the margins. Not identical, but following the same structure.

"Someone is writing across time," Wilhelm had said. "Leaving messages that only become visible when you see many manuscripts together. This is how knowledge survives when power wants it destroyed—it hides in plain sight, scattered across years."

Then the lesson Thomas hadn't understood until now: "The Order builds across generations. Your grandfather's grandfather fought them. You fight them. Your grandson will fight them. Do not expect victory in your lifetime—expect to add your stone to the wall of resistance. Each generation adds its piece. Across time, the wall grows high enough to see over."

Thomas had thought it metaphor. Now, staring at dates stretching back nine centuries, he understood.

Wilhelm had been teaching him to think in generations. To see patterns operating across lifetimes. To understand that resistance, knowledge, truth—moved so slowly that a single human life could barely perceive the motion.

But across many lives, the motion became visible. The wall grew higher.

Sitting on this boat with ancient cipher marks proving his grandfather right, Thomas felt the weight of those words settle like a mantle.

Wilhelm hadn't been part of a recent conspiracy. He'd been part of something stretching back nearly a thousand years. Preserving knowledge from Rome's fall, from before Rome's fall, from the ancient world that had crumbled into darkness.

From what?

From the Order, obviously. But why did the Order want to destroy knowledge from the ancient world?

What could possibly be so dangerous about information that old?

"Thomas."

He looked down. Margarethe's eyes were open, lucid for the first time in hours.

"How long?" she asked, voice rough as sandpaper.

"Since yesterday morning. The fever started last night." He touched her forehead—still burning hot. "How do you feel?"

"Like I'm dying." But she tried to smile. It came out more like a grimace. "Which means I'll probably live. The dying ones don't feel anything."

Thomas wasn't sure that was true, but he didn't argue. "Can you drink?"

She nodded. He helped her sit up enough to take water from the skin. She drank greedily, then fell back, exhausted by the effort.

"Did I talk?" she asked after a moment. "In the fever?"

Thomas hesitated. He could lie. Should lie, probably. But he was terrible at lying and Margarethe would see through it anyway.

"Some."

"Did I say anything…" She looked away. "Anything you shouldn't know?"

He considered his answer carefully. "You talked about your father. About remembering 217 locations. About being the library that can't burn."

Margarethe closed her eyes. "So you know."

"Know what?"

"That I'm a fraud. That I can't actually read." The words came out bitter, self-loathing. "That everything I know is just… memory. Tricks."

Thomas was quiet for a moment. Then: "Margarethe, do you know how many locations I can remember without the key?"

"What?"

"Perhaps ten. Fifteen if I really concentrate and write them down immediately. And I can read, I can use the key, I have my grandfather's so-called 'gift.'" He leaned closer so she could see his face. "You've memorized 217 locations perfectly. Kept them in your head for years, navigated them without a single note. That's not fraud. That's brilliance."

"It's a party trick—"

"A trained animal doesn't understand what it's remembering. You do." Thomas gripped her good hand. "You navigate the network. You know which locations connect to which. You understand the structure, the relationships, the meaning behind the patterns. Your father didn't just teach you to memorize. He taught you to be a living index. To BE the network in human form. Do you understand how extraordinary that is?"

Margarethe's eyes were wet. She blinked, turned her face away. "You're just saying that because I'm dying."

"You're not dying. And I'm saying it because it's true." He squeezed her hand. "I've spent my life around scholars. Men who can read ten languages, who memorize entire books, who debate philosophy and theology for hours. And not one of them could do what you do. Not one."

She was quiet for a long time. Then, so softly he almost didn't hear: "Thank you."

They sat in silence as the boat drifted on. The sun climbed higher, warm despite the autumn chill. On the banks, farmers worked their fields, children played near the water. Life continuing on.

"Thomas," Margarethe said finally. "If I don't make it—"

"You'll make it."

"If I don't," she continued firmly, "the locations are in my head. All 217. I should tell you. In case the knowledge is lost."

"You'll tell me in Cologne. When you're recovered. When we have time to write them all down properly." Thomas smiled. "I'm not letting you off that easily. You're going to have to actually work to teach me. Proper lessons. No fever-induced shortcuts."

Despite everything, Margarethe laughed—a weak, breathy sound, but genuine. "You're more stubborn than you look."

"I learned from the best."

Her hand was still in his. Thomas realized he'd been holding it this entire time, and neither of them had pulled away.

She fell asleep again after that, more peacefully this time. The fever still burned, but something in her face had relaxed, the lines of pain easing slightly.

Thomas returned to the manuscripts, to the ancient dates hidden in cipher marks, to the revelation that the conspiracy he'd stumbled into was far older and stranger than he'd imagined.

But he didn't let go of her hand.

1347, Day Three, Dawn

Margarethe woke to the smell of fish and river water and her own stale sweat.

She was alive. Surprising.

The last coherent memory she had was Thomas pulling an arrow out of her shoulder, pain so bright and consuming it had whited out her vision. After that, fragments. Fever dreams. Her father's voice reciting locations like a prayer. The terror of forgetting, of failing.

Now the fever had broken. She could tell by the way her thoughts moved clearly again, sharp-edged instead of blurred.

She opened her eyes.

Thomas was asleep beside her, slumped against the mast with a manuscript open in his lap. Dark circles under his eyes like bruises, hair matted with dried sweat and river spray, robes stained with her blood. His hand was close to hers, like he'd been holding it before sleep took him.

He'd stayed with her. The entire time.

Margarethe tried to sit up. Her shoulder screamed in protest—the wound was still there, still angry, but no longer infected. Someone had changed the bandages, cleaned the wound with something herbal and medicinal. Thomas, obviously. Thomas who'd never treated an injury more serious than a paper cut.

She managed to lever herself up to sitting. The world swayed, then steadied.

They were still on the river. Otto the Weasel was at the tiller, watching her with cautious interest.

"You're awake," he said quietly. "Good. The boy's been half mad with worry. Hasn't slept more than an hour at a time since we left Mainz."

Margarethe looked at Thomas again. His hand was so close to hers. Had he been holding it while she fevered?

"How long?"

"Three days. We'll be in Cologne by evening if the wind holds." Otto spat over the side. "You should wake him. He needs to eat something that isn't stale bread and anxiety."

But Margarethe didn't wake Thomas yet. Just sat there, watching him sleep, trying to understand the strange feeling in her chest.

People didn't stay. That was the fundamental lesson life had taught her. Her mother had died before Margarethe could even form memories of her face. Her father had been tortured and killed by the Order. Every network contact who'd tried to help had eventually been killed or disappeared.

People left. That was what they did.

But Thomas had stayed.

Weak, naive, completely unprepared Thomas who couldn't lie to save his life and stumbled over his own feet.

He'd stayed.

He'd pulled an arrow from her shoulder. Had nursed her through three days of fever. Had changed her bandages and kept her hydrated and probably talked to her unconscious body about manuscripts and patterns.

He'd stayed when anyone sensible would have taken the manuscripts and the key and continued on alone.

Finally, she reached out and touched his shoulder. "Thomas."

He jerked awake, disoriented. Saw her sitting up and his face transformed—relief so profound it was almost painful to witness. “Margarethe! You’re—the fever, is it—”

“Broken.” She managed a smile. “You did well. For someone who’s never played nursemaid before.”

“I was terrified the entire time.” He rubbed his eyes. “I kept thinking I was doing everything wrong. That you’d die because I didn’t know what I was doing.”

“But I didn’t die.”

“No.” He smiled genuinely. “You didn’t.”

“Thank you.” She tested her shoulder—stiff, painful, but functional. “Thanks to you.”

“You saved my life first. On the river path from Mainz, remember? I was just repaying the debt.”

“Is that what we are now? Keeping accounts?”

Thomas looked at her directly, scholar’s eyes serious. “No. I don’t think it is.”

The moment stretched between them, something unspoken and complicated. Margarethe looked away first, uncomfortable with whatever was building.

“We should talk,” she said. “About what I said. In the fever.”

“You don’t have to—”

“I do.” She took a breath. “You know I can’t read. You know about the 217 locations, about being a living library. But there’s more.”

Thomas settled himself more comfortably, giving her his full attention. “I’m listening.”

So Margarethe told him.

About her mother—a brilliant scholar who could read Greek and Arabic, who’d translated ancient texts the Order wanted destroyed. Targeted while pregnant, forced into hiding. Dead hours after Margarethe was born, bleeding out despite the midwives’ efforts.

About her father Heinrich raising a daughter alone, teaching her everything he knew despite a world that didn’t value daughters.

“I was five when he realized I couldn’t learn to read,” Margarethe said, voice distant. “The letters would move, change places. I could never hold them still.”

“Some people are born that way,” Thomas said gently. “Your mind processes information differently.”

“That’s what my father said. So he found another way. If I couldn’t read, I could remember. And I was good at remembering.” She touched the scar on her jaw. “Hour after hour, he taught me to visualize, to create memory palaces. He’d show me cipher patterns—dots, colors, positions. And I’d remember. Perfectly. Every detail.”

“That’s extraordinary.”

“That’s survival. The network needed people who could carry information that couldn’t be written down safely. I became that person.” Margarethe looked at the river. “But if the Order discovers what I can do, they won’t kill me quickly. They’ll torture me for all 217 locations. And I’d break eventually. Everyone breaks.”

“You didn’t break when they killed your father.”

"I wasn't captured." She shook her head. "I'd like to think I'm strong enough to die before talking. But I don't know if that's true."

Otto called something about a watchtower ahead.

"Why tell me all this?" Thomas asked finally.

"Because you trusted me with your grandfather's key. Because you stayed with me through the fever when you could have continued alone. Because…" She stopped. "Because I need you to understand what I am. Not some warrior from a romance tale. Just a woman who can't read, who's been running her entire life, who's terrified every day that she'll forget one of the locations and betray everything her father died for."

"You won't forget."

"How can you know that?"

"Because forgetting isn't something you do. Remembering is who you are." He met her eyes. "And for what it's worth, I don't see you as a warrior from a tale or a scholar. I see you as Margarethe—brilliant and terrifying, and the person who matters. Deeply."

Margarethe felt her throat tighten. "You barely know me."

"I know enough."

She wanted to argue. Wanted to push him away the way she pushed everyone away.

But she was too worn down by fever and pain and three days of him caring for her without asking for anything in return.

"Thank you," she said finally. "For staying. For…" She gestured vaguely at the bandages, the water skin. "All of it."

"Thank you for not dying. It would have been very inconvenient."

Despite everything, Margarethe laughed. It hurt her shoulder but she didn't care.

Otto called from the stern: "Cologne ahead! We'll dock within the hour!"

Margarethe tried to stand. Her legs trembled but held.

Thomas was beside her instantly, offering support. She took it, leaning on him more than she'd ever leaned on anyone.

"We'll need to find Johannes the Alchemist," she said, forcing her mind back to the task. "He's our contact here. My father's friend. If anyone can help us understand the cipher better…"

"Then we find him." Thomas adjusted his grip, taking more of her weight. "Together."

"Together," Margarethe agreed.

And as Cologne appeared on the horizon—the cathedral's choir rising magnificent above the Rhine, its unfinished towers promising future glory, city walls offering refuge—she allowed herself to believe, just for a moment, that perhaps she didn't have to carry everything alone anymore.

Perhaps, impossibly, she'd found someone who would stay.

1347, Evening, Cologne

Johannes the Alchemist was not what Thomas expected.

The address led to a narrow building in the scholars' quarter, wedged between a bookbinder and a tavern. Three stories of timber and plaster, windows darkened with soot, a small sign showing a serpent eating its own tail—the ouroboros.

Thomas knocked twice before the door flew open.

The man was young—perhaps twenty-five—with wild dark hair, bright manic eyes, and robes stained with substances Thomas couldn't identify. Ink-stained, burned hands.

"Yes? What? I'm in the middle of—" He stopped, staring. "Wait. Margarethe?"

"Hello, Johannes."

"Margarethe! By all the saints!" He pulled her inside. "You look half dead. What happened? Never mind—inside. You're the boy? Wilhelm's grandson? Excellent! Come in!" He slammed the door, threw multiple bolts.

The interior was controlled chaos. Bookshelves crammed with volumes in multiple languages. Tables covered with alchemical apparatus—glass vessels, crucibles, distillation equipment bubbling with colored liquids. Jars labeled in code. A partial skeleton on a side table. Charts showing astrological symbols, anatomical drawings, geometric patterns.

The air smelled like sulfur and roses and something dangerous.

"Excuse the mess," Johannes said, shoving aside what looked like a skull. "Sit. Both of you."

Johannes examined Margarethe's shoulder with practiced efficiency. "Arrow wound. Three, four days old? Wine and hope?"

"Wine and clean bandages," Thomas said.

"Better than nothing. Barely." Johannes pulled down jars with practiced speed, mixing substances in a mortar. "I'm thirty-eight. Studied at Paris until my experiments set fire to my dormitory—three times. Now I translate ancient texts and occasionally blow things up by accident."

"He's one of the most brilliant natural philosophers in Europe," Margarethe said through gritted teeth as Johannes cleaned her wound. "And completely insane."

"The two often go together." Johannes applied thick paste to the wound. "This will hurt. But tomorrow it will hurt less."

Margarethe hissed but didn't pull away.

Within minutes, the wound was cleaned, treated, wrapped in fresh bandages.

"You're part of the network," Thomas said.

"Was. Am. Will be." Johannes washed his hands. "My father was Wilhelm's friend. Studied together in Paris. He taught me everything before he died. Where texts are hidden. How the cipher works. What we're protecting."

"Which is?"

"Everything. The accumulated learning of mankind going back two thousand years. Medical texts that could save thousands. Mathematical treatises that could transform trade. Philosophical works that could change how we understand the world." He gestured at his shelves. "The Church says this knowledge is dangerous. The Order says it must be controlled or destroyed. They're both right. Knowledge IS dangerous. But the alternative is worse."

"The alternative is ignorance," Margarethe said quietly.

"Exactly!" Johannes tied off the bandage with a final flourish. "There. Keep it clean, don't use that arm for a week, and you'll probably survive to annoy me again. Now—" He turned to Thomas. "You have the Iron Key, yes? Wilhelm's key?"

Thomas pulled it from his pocket. The eye symbol seemed to catch the lamplight.

Johannes took it with reverent hands. "My God. I've only seen this in drawings. Your grandfather guarded it with his life."

"He died for it."

"I know. I'm sorry." Johannes set the key on his workbench. "Do you understand what you're carrying?"

"A tool to decode the cipher. Margarethe showed me how."

"It's more than that." Johannes pulled out a manuscript from one of his shelves, opened it to a page covered in marginal cipher dots. "The cipher has layers. Surface layer—locations and basic information. Anyone with patience can decode that. Second layer—dates, connections, patterns. Requires skill. Third layer—the deep structure. The real knowledge. That requires a key."

He demonstrated, showing Thomas how the Iron Key revealed patterns invisible without it. Connections between locations. Hidden notations.

"Your grandfather helped build this web. The keys aren't just tools—they're proof you're trusted with the network's deepest secrets."

Thomas sat back, mind racing. He thought about the manuscripts on the boat. The dates going back to 400 CE, to Rome's fall. The cipher marks accumulating across nine centuries.

"They don't simply keep records," he said slowly. "They accumulate knowledge as power. Each monastery adds to the store across generations. Where families married. Which children survived plague. Which bloodlines show resilience. All of it encoded, preserved."

"A treasury," Johannes said quietly.

"Exactly. A treasury of observation across time." Thomas stood, pacing. "Any single monastery sees only its region, its generation. But the Order connects them all. Knowledge flows inward to coordinating centers. From that accumulated store, they can see patterns we cannot. Predict what's coming. Position their chosen families before catastrophe strikes. Not through sorcery—through accumulated observation across centuries."

"And the keys unlock the deepest layers," Johannes finished. "Patterns visible only when you see the complete picture. Connections spanning generations."

Thomas felt the Iron Key's weight. "That's why they're hunting us. We're draining their treasury. Breaking the flow of knowledge inward."

"Scattering it outward instead," Johannes said with a slight smile. "Making what was centralized into something distributed. That's what terrifies them most."

Thomas thought about Wilhelm's deathbed words. *Scattered knowledge distributes power. Centralized knowledge concentrates it.*

"How many keys are there?"

"Seven. One for each founding family. Wilhelm's held the Iron Key—the Eye that Sees." Johannes pulled out drawings of a cathedral. "The Silver Key is here in Cologne. In Bishop Vogel's treasury. The family line died out, the key passed to the Church. He thinks it's just an ornate artifact."

"So we steal it," Margarethe said flatly.

Johannes grinned. "Tomorrow night. The bishop hosts his annual feast—guards distracted, cathedral full of people. After tomorrow, he leaves for Rome for months. It's our only window."

He spread the drawings. "You go in as wealthy merchants from Mainz. Forged invitations. During the feast, you slip away, break into the treasury, take the Silver Key."

Thomas looked at Margarethe. She was pale, injured, had nearly died three days ago.

"I can do it," she said. "One night."

"You can barely walk."

"So you'll have to be charming enough for both of us."

Johannes was already pulling fine clothes from a chest. "We begin preparation immediately. You need to learn how to speak to bishops, how to navigate a formal feast, and—" he grinned at Thomas, "—how to pick a Bavarian lock."

Despite everything, Thomas found himself smiling.

For the first time since fleeing Mainz, he felt something other than fear.

And perhaps, just perhaps, the chance to actually succeed.

That evening, Johannes taught them everything—how to walk like merchants, speak to nobility, navigate a formal feast. And most importantly, how the Bavarian lock mechanism on the treasury door worked.

Late into the night, Thomas practiced the picking technique while Margarethe slept. Johannes watched, making corrections.

"What IS the Genesis Protocol?" Thomas asked between attempts. "Everyone mentions it, but no one explains."

Johannes pulled out an old manuscript. "I don't know fully—the knowledge was split across seven keys deliberately. But from fragments I've translated, it's instructions for surviving collapse. The founders believed civilization moves in cycles. Bronze Age collapse around 1200 BCE. Rome's fall around 400 CE. They experienced Rome's fall firsthand—watched libraries burn, knowledge lost in decades."

"So they created a system to preserve it."

"To transmit it. Through people, not just books. Books burn." Johannes tapped the manuscript. "Knowledge split across seven families. No single person can abuse it. You need collaboration."

"What happens if someone gets all seven keys?"

"You can read the complete Protocol. See what the founders actually intended." Johannes looked troubled. "Which is why tomorrow night matters. Get some sleep. You need to pick that lock in under two minutes."

"Two minutes?"

"Guard rotation timing. Any longer, we're caught." Johannes grinned. "No pressure."

Thomas went to his own sleeping space—a pile of blankets in what Johannes called the "storage room" but was actually more like a library that had achieved critical mass and exploded. He lay down, unable to sleep.

Tomorrow night they would steal from a bishop. Would break into a cathedral treasury during a feast. Would attempt to reunite two of the seven keys for the first time in generations.

And every step took them deeper into a conspiracy that stretched back a thousand years.

Thomas closed his eyes and tried not to think about all the ways this could go wrong.

Instead, he thought about the pattern. The beautiful, terrible pattern hidden in centuries of cipher marks.

Knowledge and catastrophe. Preservation and control. Truth and corruption all woven together so tightly that perhaps they couldn't be separated anymore.

Perhaps that was the real secret of the Genesis Protocol.

Not how to save civilization.

But how to understand that civilization might not be saveable. That the cycles would continue regardless. That the only choice was whether knowledge survived the burning or was lost forever.

Thomas opened his eyes in the darkness, staring at Johannes's ceiling covered in astronomical charts and alchemical symbols.

Wilhelm had understood this. Had spent his life building a network to preserve knowledge through the coming darkness. Had died to protect a key that might unlock the truth.

The least Thomas could do was see it through.

For Wilhelm. For Hamo. For Margarethe.

For the possibility that perhaps, just perhaps, the next collapse could be different if enough knowledge survived.

He closed his eyes again and this time, sleep came.

Tomorrow, they would steal a key.

Tomorrow, the real work would begin.

CHAPTER 4 - THE IMPOSTOR

1347, Johannes's Workshop, Cologne

"Stop fidgeting," Johannes said, adjusting Thomas's collar. The merchant's outfit he'd procured fit surprisingly well—deep blue wool doublet with silver buttons, clean linen shirt, leather boots that didn't pinch. "Merchants don't fidget. They appraise. They calculate value. They know their worth and expect others to recognize it."

"I look ridiculous."

"You look prosperous. There's a difference." Johannes stepped back, examined his work critically. "The key is in the posture. Shoulders back—aye, like that. Chin up slightly. Not arrogant, just confident. Like money flows through your hands the way prayer flows through a priest's."

Thomas tried. Pulled his shoulders back. Lifted his chin.

Failed. Slouched back into his natural posture of someone who'd spent years hunched over manuscripts.

"This is hopeless. I look like a monk playing dress-up."

"It's not hopeless. It's just unfamiliar." Margarethe's voice came from the stairs, amused. "You'll adapt. You always do."

Thomas turned.

His breath caught.

Margarethe descended the stairs transformed. Deep green dress with gold embroidery, the fabric expensive enough that it caught the light with a subtle sheen. Her hair was actually styled instead of roughly tied back—braided and coiled and pinned, with a delicate veil. Her wounded shoulder was carefully concealed under the dress's construction, no sign of the bandages beneath.

She moved differently too. Not the fighter's prowl Thomas knew. Something more measured, graceful. The walk of a woman who'd been raised with wealth and refinement.

Beautiful. Dangerous and beautiful and completely unlike the Margarethe who'd killed men without hesitation.

"Close your mouth," she said with the ghost of a smile. "Merchants don't gape at their own wives."

"Wives?"

"You didn't think we'd attend separately?" Johannes was grinning. "A wealthy merchant and his wife, fleeing the plague in Mainz, seeking the bishop's blessing for safe passage to their holdings in Italy. Perfect cover. Sympathetic. Believable."

Thomas forced himself to think practically. “What if someone questions our story?”

“Then you improvise using details you actually know.” Johannes handed him a leather purse heavy with coins. Real coins—Thomas could feel the weight, hear the clink of silver and gold. “You grew up near Mainz, you understand the wool trade, you’re educated enough to discuss theology if the bishop tests you. Use truth whenever possible. It’s easier to remember and harder to catch in lies.”

He demonstrated how to hold the purse. “Don’t flash this around, but let it show occasionally. Wealthy people are casual about their wealth. Poor people pretending to be wealthy are too careful. They count coins. They worry. You? You expect to have money. Always have. Always will.”

Margarethe took the purse from Thomas, secured it to her belt. “I’ll handle the money. Wives often do. And I can read people better than Thomas can.”

“I can read people,” Thomas protested.

“You can read manuscripts. You’re terrible with people. You think everyone is honest because you’re honest.” She touched his arm, softening the criticism. “It’s not a weakness. It’s just not useful tonight when we need to lie convincingly.”

Johannes cleared the table, spread out his cathedral drawings. “Review the plan. Everything must be perfect.”

Thomas studied the layout. The bishop’s residence adjoined Cologne Cathedral—the treasury was in the residence basement.

“The feast begins at sunset,” Johannes said. “Arrive fashionably late. Slip away during the third course when entertainment begins—maximum distraction.”

Margarethe leaned closer. “The route?”

“Servants’ corridors. Exit the great hall, turn left. Through the kitchen—chaos during the feast. Down to the basement. Treasury is third door on the left.”

“Guards?”

“Two. They rotate every hour. Three minutes during rotation when the hallway is empty.”

Thomas looked at the lock drawing—Bavarian design. Complex, supposedly unpickable.

“Two minutes to pick the lock,” Thomas said. “Two inside to find the Silver Key. One to lock it again before guards return.”

“Five minutes total,” Johannes confirmed. “Can you do it?”

“I don’t know.”

“Yes, you do. You picked my practice lock in ninety seconds this morning. Seventy-five seconds on your best attempt yesterday afternoon.” Johannes gripped Thomas’s shoulder with surprising strength. “You see patterns. Locks are just metal patterns that need to be understood. Trust your training.”

Margarethe caught Thomas’s eye, held his gaze. “I’ll watch the corridor. Keep you aware of timing. You focus only on the lock.”

“What about you?” Thomas asked Johannes.

“I’ll be at the feast. Separate from you—we can’t appear to know each other.” Johannes gestured to a pile of books. “I’ll be playing the eccentric scholar invited to discuss Greek medical texts. It gives me an excuse to wander, to create diversions if needed, and to signal if anything goes wrong.”

"What's the signal?"

"If I spill wine on myself—loudly, dramatically—abort immediately. Something's wrong. Get back to the feast through whatever route is safest. Don't worry about the lock or the key. Just survive." Johannes rolled up the drawings. "But it won't come to that. This plan is solid. I've been refining it for two years."

Thomas wasn't so sure. Plans sounded solid until they collided with reality.

But he didn't say that. Just nodded.

"One more thing," Johannes said, voice dropping, becoming serious. "If this goes wrong, if you're caught, you don't know me. You're just thieves who heard about the treasury. You don't mention the cipher, the network, the keys, Wilhelm, Margarethe's father—nothing. Nothing that puts the rest of us at risk."

"And if they torture us?" Margarethe asked bluntly.

"Then you resist as long as you can. Give us time to disappear, to hide evidence. But everyone breaks eventually given enough time and pain. So we make sure it doesn't come to that by not getting caught." Johannes looked at both of them, his young face suddenly old. "Are you ready?"

Thomas looked at Margarethe. She looked at him.

Neither were ready. But they were out of time. Out of options. Out of everywhere to run.

"Aye," Thomas lied.

"Good," Johannes said. "Then let's go steal from a bishop."

1347, Cologne Cathedral, Evening

The great hall was overwhelming. Hundreds of candles reflected off gold leaf vaulting, turning the vast space into something between cathedral and treasure vault. Tapestries covered the walls. Tables set with silver plates and crystal goblets. Roasted swan in its own feathers. Peacock re-dressed in plumage. Wine that tasted like liquid gold.

All this while plague ravaged the countryside outside. While bodies burned in mass graves. While the poor starved.

"Stop staring," Margarethe murmured beside him, hand light on his arm in a gesture that looked affectionate but felt like a warning. "Merchants are used to wealth."

Thomas forced himself to relax. Took a measured drink of wine—not gulping despite the fact that it was the best he'd ever tasted. Tried to appear bored by the opulence.

They'd been seated near the middle of the hall—not close enough to the bishop's high table to draw scrutiny, but not so far away as to seem unimportant. Perfect positioning. Johannes had clearly bribed someone.

Speaking of Johannes—Thomas spotted him three tables away, deep in animated conversation with an elderly priest. Wine glass in hand, expensive but not ostentatious clothes, the picture of a man comfortable in his own intelligence.

The bishop himself sat at the high table under a carved canopy, resplendent in purple robes. Heinrich Vogel was in his fifties, with a florid face that suggested he enjoyed feasts regularly. Soft hands, expensive rings, the satisfied look of a man who'd never gone hungry.

Somewhere beneath this building, beneath all this wealth and luxury, the Silver Key waited.

"Third course soon," Margarethe said quietly. "The entertainment will begin. That's when we move."

"I know the plan."

"I'm reminding you because you're nervous. When you're nervous, you forget things. You overthink." She took a delicate bite of venison. Perfect manners. "Just follow the plan. Trust your training. We'll be fine."

She was right. He was nervous. His hands were shaking slightly under the table. He hid them in his lap.

A merchant across from them—portly man named Dietrich who owned vineyards—was telling a story about escaping Mainz just before the plague took hold. "The plague bells were ringing day and night. Bodies in the streets, piled like cordwood. The Order's Gray Robes going house to house, burning buildings. No trials. No mercy. Just fire and death."

"Terrible times," Thomas agreed.

"And you escaped when?" Dietrich asked, suddenly focused on Thomas.

Thomas's mind went blank. When had they supposedly escaped? What date had Johannes told them to use?

"Three weeks ago," Margarethe said smoothly. "Just before the river crossings closed. My husband had already heard rumors from his trading contacts. We saw what was coming. Packed what we could carry. Lost half our goods in the rush—looters, fires, the Order confiscating entire warehouses. My husband's warehouse in the Mühlenstadt quarter—burned by the Order as a plague precaution. Everything gone. Forty years of inventory. Gone in an afternoon."

Perfect fabrication. Every detail crisp, specific. Her face showed exactly the right blend of bitterness and fear—practiced grief that looked utterly genuine.

Dietrich nodded sympathetically. "I heard the Mühlenstadt quarter was hit particularly hard. You were fortunate to escape with your lives."

"Fortune favors those who don't hesitate." Margarethe took a sip of wine. "We saw the signs, we acted immediately. Those who waited…" She shrugged eloquently.

The conversation moved on to other topics—trade routes disrupted by plague, whether it was safe to travel to Venice.

Thomas breathed again.

"That was close," he murmured when Dietrich's attention shifted.

"You froze. Don't freeze again when it matters." But Margarethe's hand found his under the table, squeezed once. Reassurance, not just criticism.

The third course arrived with ceremonial flourish—servants carrying the swan on a massive silver platter, the bird gilded and re-feathered. The crowd applauded. The bishop stood to say a blessing that was more about his own piety than gratitude to God.

And with the swan, the entertainment.

Musicians entered the hall—lute, viol, tambourine. A juggler in motley began tossing knives and torches. Two acrobats began performing impossible feats of balance and strength, drawing gasps and applause.

Everyone's attention shifted. Even the guards were watching.

"Now," Margarethe breathed.

They stood. Casual, unhurried. Thomas caught Johannes's eye across the hall. The alchemist gave the smallest nod.

Go. May God protect you.

They walked toward the side door. Slow, relaxed. No one paid attention. Everyone was watching acrobats flip through the air.

Through the door. Into the corridor beyond, sudden quiet after the noise.

Left instead of right.

And the real work began.

1347, Cathedral Basement, Treasury Corridor

The kitchen annex was controlled chaos.

Cooks shouting orders in German and French and kitchen Latin. Servants rushing between kitchens and great hall with platters and wine. Steam and heat rolling from ovens. The smell of roasting meat and bread and spices, overlaid with sweat and smoke.

No one gave Thomas and Margarethe a second glance. Servants assumed they were lost guests. Kitchen staff was too busy to care.

Down the stairs. Stone steps worn smooth from centuries of use. Temperature dropping with each step. Sound of the feast fading, replaced by silence and dripping moisture.

The basement corridor was quiet. Empty. Torches providing flickering yellow light.

And at the end, two guards stationed outside a heavy oak door reinforced with iron bands.

Thomas and Margarethe pressed themselves into a side alcove. Watched. Waited.

"Guard rotation?" Thomas whispered.

Margarethe was already counting. "Four minutes. Perhaps five."

They waited. Thomas's heart hammered. His palms were sweating. His mouth was dry.

Three minutes.

Four minutes.

At five minutes, footsteps on the stairs. The new guards arriving.

Brief conversation. "Anything?"

"Nothing. Dead quiet down here."

"The bishop's feast always is. Everyone's too busy stuffing their faces to think about stealing."

Laughter. Good-natured complaining about being stuck on guard duty while others enjoyed the feast.

Then the original guards headed up the stairs. The new guards settled into position, adjusting their sword belts.

"Damn," Thomas breathed. "We missed the window."

"Wait," Margarethe said.

One of the new guards pulled out a wineskin—leather, probably containing something stronger than the watered wine served at the feast. Shared it with his companion. Both laughed.

Then both guards walked down the corridor. Away from the treasury. Toward what looked like a servants' privy at the far end.

"They're abandoning their post?"

"Drinking on duty. Can't be seen right in front of the treasury door. They'll relieve themselves, pass the wine, complain. Be back in two, three minutes." Margarethe pushed him forward urgently. "Go. Now. This is the only chance we'll get."

Thomas ran. Light-footed, quiet. Stay on the balls of your feet. Don't let your heels strike. Roll your weight.

Reached the treasury door.

Heavy oak, iron reinforcements, and in the center: the lock.

Bavarian mechanism. Beautiful and deadly and supposedly unpickable.

Thomas pulled his picks from his sleeve—thin metal tools Johannes had forged specifically for this. Knelt before the lock. Inserted the first pick.

The Bavarian lock used multiple rotating cylinders, each with different pin configurations that had to be set in exact sequence. One mistake and everything reset.

Thomas closed his eyes. Shut out the corridor, the guards, the fear. Focused entirely on the lock.

This was just like the manuscripts. Patterns. Sequences. Each click was a letter. Each cylinder was a line. The entire lock was a page he had to decode.

First cylinder. He felt the pins—delicate pressure, listening with his fingers. Applied tension with his other pick. Rotated.

Click.

Second cylinder. More complex. Five pins instead of three. Different sizes. He worked carefully.

Click.

Behind him, Margarethe's urgent whisper: "One minute."

Third cylinder. Uneven pins, sweating hands. Careful pressure on each one.

"Thirty seconds."

The small pin aligned. Click.

The lock opened.

Thomas pulled the heavy door. It swung inward on recently oiled hinges, silent and smooth.

"I'm in."

"Twenty seconds. Hurry."

Thomas slipped inside, leaving the door ajar.

The treasury was smaller than he expected—perhaps ten feet square. Shelves lined the walls, covered with church valuables. Gold chalices encrusted with gems. Jeweled crosses. Illuminated manuscripts. Silver reliquaries holding fragments of saints' bones.

And there, on the center shelf at eye level: a key.

Not like the Iron Key. This one was silver, gleaming. Ornately carved with a level of detail that must have taken months. The symbol on the head was different—a hand reaching upward, fingers spread wide, palm inscribed with tiny markings.

The Hand that Guides.

Thomas grabbed it. Felt the weight—heavier than the Iron Key, denser metal. The craftsmanship was extraordinary.

Outside, Margarethe's voice sharp with controlled panic: "Guards coming back. Thirty seconds. Get out now."

Thomas ran to the door. Pulled it closed. His picks were still in the lock mechanism inside—no time to retrieve them.

The lock. He had to lock it again or they'd know immediately.

But Bavarian locks were designed to prevent exactly that. Couldn't be re-locked from the outside without the original key or specialized tools Johannes hadn't been able to make.

"Thomas!" Real fear now.

"I can't lock it from out here!"

"Leave it. Move now!"

Thomas dove into the alcove beside Margarethe just as voices echoed from the far end. The guards returning, laughing, the wineskin sloshing.

They settled back into position outside the treasury, adjusting their sword belts.

Without checking the door.

Thank God. They hadn't noticed.

But eventually someone would. The next rotation in an hour, or when the feast ended, or when the bishop showed a visitor his treasures. The unlocked door would be discovered. The missing key would be noticed.

They had hours at most.

Margarethe pulled Thomas deeper into the shadows, back toward the stairs. They climbed slowly, every step careful.

Up the stairs. Through the kitchen annex—still chaotic.

Into the corridor leading back toward the great hall—

A hand grabbed Thomas's shoulder from behind.

He spun, heart stopping, reaching for a knife he didn't have.

Johannes. The alchemist's face was pale, urgent, fear in his eyes for the first time.

"We have a problem," Johannes whispered, voice tight with controlled panic. "Don't go back to the feast. There are Gray Robes in the hall. Three of them. Asking questions about strangers from Mainz. Checking invitations against names."

Thomas felt cold wash through him. "How did they find us?"

"I don't know. Perhaps someone at my workshop. Perhaps the Order has infiltrated the bishop's household. Doesn't matter. We need to leave. Now. Before they start questioning guests one by one."

"The Silver Key—" Thomas started.

"Do you have it?"

Thomas nodded.

"Then we go. Forget the feast. Forget the cover story. Follow me. Servants' exit."

They followed Johannes through a maze of corridors, servants' passages winding through the cathedral like intestines. Behind them, shouts echoed. Running feet.

Someone had discovered the treasury.

"Run," Johannes said, abandoning stealth. And they ran.

1347, Cologne Streets, Night

They burst from the cathedral through a servants' entrance into a narrow alley reeking of kitchen refuse and waste. Rain was falling—cold autumn rain that soaked through Thomas's fine merchant clothes in seconds.

"This way!" Johannes led them through the maze of streets, his knowledge of Cologne proving invaluable. Behind them, cathedral bells started ringing. Alarm bells. The entire cathedral guard would be rousing.

"Where are we going?" Thomas gasped, lungs burning.

"Safe house. Tanner's quarter. Not far if we can avoid the patrols."

They ran through rain-slicked streets, water streaming from roofs. Around corners sharp enough that Thomas nearly fell. Through passages so narrow his shoulders brushed both sides.

Margarethe kept pace despite her wounded shoulder, face set in grim determination.

Behind them, torches bobbed. Shouts echoed. The pursuit was organized, coordinated.

"They're too close," Margarethe said, glancing back. "We need to split up. Draw them in different directions."

"No," Thomas and Johannes said simultaneously.

"Aye." Margarethe grabbed Thomas's arm, thrust him toward Johannes. "You have both keys. You're what matters. I'll draw them off, lose them in the tanners' quarter. I know this city better than they do."

"Margarethe—"

"Don't argue. We don't have time." She was already moving, shouting in German to draw attention. "Hey! Over here! Follow me if you want the thieves!"

The Gray Robes snapped toward her voice—three sets of eyes, three blades already half-drawn. They moved like pack hunters.

"No!" Thomas tried to go back.

Johannes grabbed him, pulled him in the opposite direction. "She gave us a chance. Don't waste it by getting captured trying to save her. She knows what she's doing. Trust her."

They ran. Thomas looked back once, saw Margarethe disappearing into shadows, the Gray Robes pursuing.

Then Johannes pulled him around a corner and she was gone.

They ran for ten more minutes. Through the tanners' quarter—the smell overwhelming even in the rain. Across a small plaza, empty except for a drunk sleeping in a doorway. Down an alley barely wide enough for one person.

Finally, Johannes stopped at a nondescript door. Knocked a specific pattern—three fast, pause, two slow, pause, one fast.

The door opened immediately. They tumbled inside, soaked.

A woman stood in the doorway—middle-aged, stern-looking, practical clothing. She locked the door behind them, threw multiple bolts. "Trouble?"

"Cathedral guards. Gray Robes. They'll search the quarter methodically but they won't find us here. This location isn't in any network records." Johannes was breathing hard, water streaming from his hair. "Are you hurt?" he asked Thomas.

"No. But Margarethe—"

"Margarethe knows how to disappear. She's better at this than either of us. She'll lose them and make her way here when it's safe." Johannes sounded confident, but Thomas heard the worry underneath.

They waited in the safe house—a modest building that felt more like a working-class home than a hiding place. The stern woman—she never gave her name—brought them dry clothes, towels, bread and cheese.

Thomas paced, unable to sit. Changed mechanically. Imagining Margarethe cornered, captured, interrogated. Tortured. Killed.

Johannes sat still, conserving energy, thinking through next steps.

An hour passed. Two hours.

No sign of Margarethe.

Thomas pulled out the Silver Key, turned it over. The Hand that Guides. Beautifully crafted. Heavy. Valuable.

Was this worth Margarethe's life?

At three hours, there was a knock. The same pattern Johannes had used—three fast, pause, two slow, pause, one fast.

The stern woman opened cautiously.

Margarethe stumbled in, soaked, bleeding from a cut on her forehead that had already started to clot, but alive. Gloriously alive.

"Lost them," she gasped, leaning against the doorframe. "Doubled back four times through the tanneries. They gave up after the second hour."

Thomas caught her before she fell. "You're hurt."

"I'm alive. That's what counts. Head wounds bleed more than they hurt." She looked past him to Johannes. "Did we get it? Tell me we got the damned key."

Thomas held up the Silver Key.

Margarethe smiled despite the blood. "Then it was worth it."

But before anyone could celebrate, there was another knock. Different pattern. Urgent and random, just desperate pounding.

The stern woman opened the door a crack. A young man stood outside, rain-soaked, terrified.

"Message for Johannes the Alchemist. Urgent. The Gray Robes raided your workshop an hour ago. They're looking for you specifically. They know you were at the feast."

Johannes's face went pale. "My work. Everything—"

"Burned," the young man said, apologetic. "I'm sorry. I tried to warn you sooner but they had the street blocked. They torched everything. Your books, your equipment, your notes. All of it. Gone."

For a moment, Johannes looked lost. Devastated. His life's work destroyed.

Then he straightened, visibly gathering himself. "Doesn't matter. The knowledge is here." He tapped his head. "They can burn buildings and books but they can't burn what I've already learned. The network taught us that generations ago—knowledge in the mind survives when everything else burns."

"There's more," the young man said, reluctant. "They have the guest lists from the feast. The bishop's steward is going through them methodically, looking for discrepancies. The couple from Mainz who disappeared during the third course. They're asking questions. Checking names against city records."

Thomas's stomach dropped. "They'll figure out our names were false."

"Not immediately. I forged those invitations perfectly. But eventually, aye. Within a day, perhaps two at most." Johannes looked at the Silver Key Thomas still held. "We need to leave Cologne. Tonight. But first, we use what we risked everything to obtain."

He spread a manuscript on the table—one from his workshop, saved because he'd brought it to the safe house days ago. Marginal cipher dots covered the pages.

"The Iron Key alone showed us locations," Johannes said, alchemist's mind already working despite the disaster. "Single points of information scattered across Europe. Let's see what two keys together reveal that one alone couldn't."

Thomas placed the Iron Key on the manuscript first. The eye symbol aligned with the text. Cipher dots appeared through the aperture, exactly as they had countless times before.

Then Johannes placed the Silver Key beside it, positioning the hand symbol to overlap slightly with the eye.

And the pattern changed.

The dots didn't just show locations anymore. They showed connections—lines between locations, visible only when both keys were present. A web spread across the page.

"My God," Johannes breathed. "It's not just marking where knowledge is hidden. It's showing how it's connected. How information moves through the Order's network. How knowledge passes from hand to hand, generation to generation."

Thomas saw it with the clarity that came from years of reading manuscripts. Each location was a knot in a vast web. Each connection a path for knowledge.

"And look here." Johannes pointed to a cluster of connections. "These aren't just knowledge repositories. These are families. Bloodlines. See—this mark indicates a family line. This one indicates a strategic marriage. This one indicates offspring who carry specific traits."

Margarethe leaned closer despite her exhaustion. "They're tracking genealogies? Like breeding horses?"

"Not just tracking. Guiding. Orchestrating." Johannes traced the connections with growing horror. "Look—this family in Cologne produces children with pattern recognition. That family in Vienna has children who remember entire pages. The Order arranges a marriage between the bloodlines. Three generations later, their descendants have both gifts combined."

Thomas felt cold understanding spreading through him. "They're not just preserving knowledge in books. They're breeding people to carry it. Creating living libraries who can hold information that can't be safely written down."

"For forty generations," Johannes confirmed, pointing to date markers that showed tracking back centuries. "Creating living vessels for knowledge. People who can remember perfectly. People who can see patterns. People who can survive with the information humanity needs to rebuild after the next collapse."

The room was silent except for rain drumming on the roof. The magnitude slowly settling over them.

"That's what Wilhelm was part of," Thomas said quietly, voice hollow. "Not just hiding manuscripts. Creating people who could BE manuscripts. Who could carry the knowledge in their blood and pass it to their children."

"And the Order knows," Margarethe said, voice hard. "That's why they hunt us so viciously. We're not just carrying forbidden knowledge in bags. We are forbidden knowledge. Our existence is the crime. Our breeding is the heresy."

Before anyone could respond, there was pounding on the door. Not a polite knock. A demand.

"Open! In the name of the bishop and the Holy Church! Open or we break this door down!"

The stern woman looked at Johannes with terror. "The Gray Robes found us. How?"

"Doesn't matter how. Back exit. Now." Johannes grabbed the manuscripts, thrust them at Thomas with desperate urgency. "Take these. Both keys. Run. Don't stop until you're miles outside the city walls."

"What about you?" Thomas asked, though he already knew.

"I'll delay them. Buy you time." Johannes was already moving to the front of the house, positioning himself between the door and Thomas. "Go. Now."

Margarethe pulled Thomas toward the back of the house, grip iron-strong. "He's right. We have to go. The keys matter more than any of us."

"I'm not leaving him to die!"

"You don't have a choice! The knowledge dies if we're all captured!"

The front door shattered inward, wood splintering. Gray Robes poured in—six of them, armed, disciplined. Thomas caught a final glimpse of Johannes facing them, unarmed but unbowed.

Then Margarethe dragged Thomas out the back exit into the rain-soaked night, and they were running again, and Johannes was behind them—captured or dead or worse—and all Thomas could think was: *This is my fault. All of this. My fault.*

They ran until dawn, until their lungs burned and their legs gave out and they collapsed in an abandoned woodcutter's cottage five miles outside Cologne's walls.

Behind them, the city bells continued their iron clamor—relentless, accusing.

They never stopped.

1347, Abandoned Cottage Outside Cologne, Morning

They found refuge in a woodcutter's abandoned cottage five miles from the city, deep enough in the forest that smoke from their small fire wouldn't be visible. Collapsed on the dirt floor that smelled of old leaves and mouse droppings. Too shocked to speak, to process what they'd discovered.

Thomas stared at the ceiling beams, watching spiders build webs with patient, methodical precision. Intricate geometric patterns. Everything was patterns. The cipher. The bloodlines. The web of connections spreading across Europe.

And he was one of them. A man shaped by patterns laid generations before he was born.

He pulled the manuscript closer. Johannes had grabbed this from his workshop—calling it essential. Thomas understood why. Beneath the breeding records, tucked into the binding, were older manuscripts. Yellowed parchment, shaky hand, faded brown ink.

And in the margins, strange drawings.

Not illuminations of saints. Circles. Arrows. Diagrams mapping something Thomas couldn't quite name.

He unfolded the first carefully. The text was orthodox theology—Augustine's City of God. But the margins…

The margins were filled with circles and arrows, mapping something else entirely.

One diagram showed a circle with four points:

They control who may marry → Strong children result → These survive plague → Justifying more control

The arrow looped back to the beginning.

Beside it, tiny script: *"This is the wheel that turns itself. I have watched it turn for thirty years, growing stronger."*

At the bottom: *Brother Edmund of Oxford, Anno Domini 1275.*

Seventy-two years ago. Two generations before Thomas was born.

He turned the page.

More notes. Hidden in plain sight:

"They accumulate knowledge as a treasury accumulates gold. Each monastery records which families married, which children survived plague, which bloodlines show resilience. Year after year, the store grows. From this treasury, they can predict what is coming, position chosen families, ensure survival. Not sorcery. Observation across time."

Wilhelm's words echoed: *Look for patterns, Thomas. The scribes before you left signs for those who can see.*

Wilhelm had known. Wilhelm had seen Edmund's work.

Edmund had drawn "The Wheel"—four points feeding itself. A pattern that repeated, a cycle that reinforced itself.

More notes:

"They think in grandchildren's time. This is why they cannot be stopped by killing leaders. The design outlives the designers. I have found margin notes in medical texts predicting this plague. Not prophecy—calculation. They positioned families of proven resilience in trade cities decades ago, knowing plague comes from the East every few generations. They do not react to catastrophe. They prepare for it."

Thomas sat back, stunned. The manuscript felt heavy with decades of hidden truth.

"Thomas?" Margarethe's voice from across the room. "You've gone pale."

"They knew the plague was coming. Positioned families to observe who survived. Written seventy years ago."

"Keep reading."

In the final pages, Edmund's hand grew shakier—the writing of a dying man:

"The Order knows I have seen too much. But I have hidden this knowledge in plain sight. To you, seeker: The Order is not men. It is architecture that outlasts its builders. The wheel turns by its own motion. To fight men is futile. You must fight the pattern itself. How? They depend on secrecy to coordinate. Break the secrecy—scatter their knowledge like grain on wind—and the wheel loses its grip. My grandson Wilhelm will carry this understanding. The pattern can be broken. Not through force. Through flow. Knowledge concentrated gives them power. Knowledge scattered starves the pattern."

Wilhelm. Edmund's grandson.

Thomas's throat tightened. His grandfather had carried this his entire life. Had taught Thomas to see patterns, to look across time, to understand that fighting men was futile but fighting the pattern itself…

"What is it?" Margarethe asked.

He couldn't speak. Couldn't find words. Just stared at Edmund's final words, vision blurring.

"Thomas." Sharper now. She moved closer, wincing as her wounded shoulder protested. "What did you find?"

He had to force the words out. "My grandfather Wilhelm. He… he was Edmund's grandson."

"Who is Edmund?"

"A scholar. Seventy years ago." Thomas's voice was hoarse. "He saw what the Order was doing. Drew diagrams in manuscript margins—wheels, circles, patterns. He understood they weren't just evil men. They'd built something that outlives any man. A pattern that feeds on catastrophe."

Margarethe's eyes narrowed. "Like what you've been saying. About breeding programs across generations."

"Edmund saw it first. Mapped it out. Realized you can't fight men—you have to fight the pattern itself." Thomas touched the manuscript with trembling fingers. "He wrote that the Order depends on secrecy to

coordinate across Christendom. Break the secrecy—scatter their knowledge like grain on wind—and the pattern loses its grip."

"And your grandfather knew this?"

"Carried it his whole life. All those lessons he taught me about seeing patterns, looking across time…" Thomas's throat tightened. "He was teaching me Edmund's strategy without saying it outright. Preparing me for this."

Margarethe was silent a moment, watching him. Then: "What does it say? The strategy?"

Thomas traced Edmund's words with one finger, translating as he read:

" 'Knowledge concentrated gives them power. Knowledge scattered starves the pattern.' If their control comes from centralized archives—from coordinating in secret across Europe—then the counter is distribution. Make the knowledge flow outward instead of inward."

"Like you were already planning," Margarethe said slowly. "Take the cipher to multiple cities. Give it to many people."

"Not one person knowing. Many." Thomas looked at the two keys lying beside the manuscript. The Iron Key. The Silver Key. Edmund's strategy made terrible sense now. "Not one archive. Many archives. Not centralized control. Scattered seeds that can't all be burned."

"Strong roots from many small roots," Margarethe murmured. "Wilhelm's words."

"Edmund's words first." Thomas's voice cracked. "Passed down through Wilhelm. To me."

Thomas nodded, unable to speak. His throat was tight.

Wilhelm had died protecting this. Had chosen Thomas to carry it forward. Had known his grandson had the gifts—bred into him across forty generations—to see the pattern and break it.

Not through strength. Through understanding.

"Johannes is captured," Thomas said finally, the words coming out flat now, emptied of everything but fact and new purpose.

"Or dead," Margarethe said with brutal honesty. She was checking her shoulder wound—reopened during the night's running, bleeding fresh. "The Order doesn't take prisoners unless they want information. If they think he doesn't know anything useful, they'll just kill him. If they think he does…" She didn't finish.

"He knows everything. The network. The keys. Our names."

"He'll resist as long as he can. Give us time."

"And then he'll break. Everyone breaks." Thomas was using Margarethe's own words, thrown back like weapons. "We have days at most before they know everything."

"So we waste those days on guilt?" Margarethe's voice cut sharp. "That what you want? Sit here feeling sorry until the Gray Robes find us?"

She didn't wait for an answer. "Or we move. Learn what we came for. Make his pain count for something."

She was right. Thomas knew she was right.

Margarethe finished bandaging her shoulder with strips torn from her ruined merchant's dress. They looked like what they were: fugitives barely surviving.

Thomas pulled out the two keys. Iron and Silver. The Eye that Sees and the Hand that Guides.

And the manuscript Johannes had given him—the one showing the bloodline connections revealed only when both keys were used together.

"Forty generations," Thomas said, unrolling the manuscript. "Almost a thousand years of controlled breeding."

"Since Rome fell," Margarethe confirmed. "They've been creating people who could survive the next collapse with the right traits bred into their bloodlines."

Thomas studied the patterns. Families in Cologne wed to families in Paris. Their children into Rome, Vienna. Each match chosen like a stitch in a tapestry.

"Wilhelm. His family line must be in here."

He searched, using both keys together. Found it.

Wilhelm von Eltville. Father: Friedrich. Grandfather: Conrad. Back through generations.

All the way to Adalbert von Eltville in the 4th century. Forty-one generations. Over a thousand years tracked.

Beside each name, cold notations:

Wilhelm von Eltville (1287-1347): Eye for patterns: rare. Memory: keen. Marked for cipher-work.

Friedrich von Eltville (1261-1312): Eye for patterns: good. Gifts pass true to children.

Generation after generation, evaluated like livestock.

"They bred him," Thomas whispered. "Bred his entire line to produce someone who could read the cipher naturally. Who had the exact combination of traits needed."

"And you," Margarethe said. "You have his gift. Which means—"

"I'm not an accident. I'm their handiwork." Everything about him—his ability with patterns, his memory—it wasn't natural talent. It was wrought. Planned. Bred into him by people who died centuries ago.

Panic pulled him down into darkness.

Margarethe gripped his shoulders hard. "Listen. I can't read. Never could. My father made me a living library because the bloodlines needed one and I was the daughter he had. I spent my life wondering if I was a person or a tool."

"And what did you decide?"

"That I'm both. And that's fine." Her eyes were fierce. "You can be their handiwork and still make your own choices. What you do with your gifts matters more than how you got them. Wilhelm chose to preserve knowledge instead of hoarding it. That choice was his."

Thomas needed to believe that.

"Show me your family," he said. "Let me see what they did to you."

Margarethe hesitated. "Find it for me. I can't read what they wrote."

Thomas used both keys together. Searched. Found it.

"Margarethe of Mainz. Father: Heinrich the Scholar. Mother: Anna the Translator."

He went silent, reading ahead. His face went pale.

"What does it say?"

Thomas's voice shook: "Your mother. Born 1319. Died in childbirth, 1343. Marked for 'Fit for breeding.' Match approved."

"And then?"

" 'Died in childbirth 1343. Cause: made. Killed for refusing the next command to bear again. Example set to keep the line obedient.' "

The words hung like poison.

Margarethe went very still.

"They killed her," she said finally, voice flat and terrible. "My mother. She refused an order about having more children, and they killed her. Made it look like complications. Left me motherless as punishment."

"She refused them. Your mother stood against them." He met her eyes. "You have her defiance in your blood."

"Don't be. I'm angry. And anger is useful." Margarethe's hands were shaking. "Anger can be directed. Controlled. Used as a weapon. Find my father's entry. I need to know what they did to him."

Thomas turned pages with trembling fingers. Found Heinrich's name. Read the notation, his face going pale.

"What?" Margarethe demanded when he hesitated.

Thomas forced himself to read it aloud:

"Heinrich the Scholar. Born 1315. Died 1347." He swallowed hard. "They marked him for 'eye for patterns: strong. Tongues: many. Gift for teaching: rare. Memory: keen.' "

"And then?"

"He became a risk after Anna's killing. Resisted their commands. Refused a new match they tried to arrange for him. Began to pry into Anna's death."

Margarethe's jaw clenched. "They killed him for asking questions about my mother."

Thomas nodded, reading the final notation: " 'Killed by Order hands 1347. Put to the question; spoke little. Bloodline continues through daughter.' " He looked up. "You. They note you as 'living library.' "

"They used the Order to kill him," Margarethe said, voice steady but eyes burning with rage. "Let the Gray Robes torture him to death because he'd figured out they killed my mother. Made it look like the enemy killed him when it was really the Order cleaning up their own mistake. Using their supposed opponents as tools for murder."

She was shaking. With rage or grief or both, Thomas couldn't tell.

Finally, Margarethe rolled up the manuscript with careful, controlled movements. "We need to find the other keys. All seven. Understand the complete Genesis Protocol."

"Why?" Thomas asked. "What will that accomplish?"

"Because if we don't, my parents died for nothing. Johannes was captured for nothing. Your grandfather's murder was meaningless. All the people killed by the Order across forty generations—all for nothing." She met Thomas's eyes with fierce determination. "But if we complete it. If we understand what the Order is

actually trying to do, what the Protocol truly says when all seven keys are brought together… then perhaps we can stop them. Or expose them. Or at least make all those deaths mean something."

Thomas thought about it. About the choice in front of them, stark and unforgiving.

They could run. Disappear. Live quiet lives, have children who would carry what had been bred into them.

Or they could continue. Seek the remaining five keys scattered across plague-ravaged Europe. Unlock the full truth. Risk everything to understand everything.

"Johannes said the third key is a person," Thomas said slowly, making his decision even as he spoke. "A living descendant who carries cipher knowledge in their blood memory. Not a physical object like the Iron and Silver Keys, but a human being whose blood carries the knowledge. He mentioned Prague as the location."

"That's weeks of travel. Through plague country. With the Order hunting us specifically. With Johannes likely breaking under torture and revealing where we're headed." Margarethe didn't sound opposed. Just realistic.

"I know."

"We could die. Probably will die before we reach the seventh key."

"I know that too."

Margarethe looked at him—really looked at him. "You've changed, Thomas. Three weeks ago you were a monk who'd never left the monastery. Never killed anyone. Never stolen anything. Now you're talking about traveling across Europe through plague and war, chasing keys to unlock a thousand-year-old conspiracy. Like it's not insane."

"We killed a man," Thomas said quietly, remembering Anselm's surprised face as he fell, Margarethe's blade finding its mark. "Stole from a bishop's treasury. Ran from the Order. Discovered I'm bred to serve a purpose I never chose. I'm already damned by every measure that matters. Might as well finish what we started and at least make the damnation meaningful."

Despite everything, Margarethe laughed. Dark, bitter, but genuine. "Very well. We go to Prague. Find the human key, whatever that means. Unlock the next layer of this nightmare. See how much worse it can get before it kills us."

"Together?"

"Together." Margarethe held out her hand.

Thomas took it. Shook once. A pact sealed between two people bred for purposes they'd never consented to, choosing their own path.

Thomas felt a hard steadiness take root. Not peace—that was too much to ask. But purpose. Direction. A path forward that was his choice.

They had two of seven keys. A manuscript showing bloodline patterns going back forty generations. The knowledge that the Order had been playing God with humanity for a thousand years.

And now they knew the truth about their own families. The calculated murders. The breeding. The casual cruelty disguised as preservation.

Outside the abandoned cottage, dawn light was strengthening. A new day. A new chapter in a quest that would probably kill them but felt necessary anyway.

Thomas packed the keys and manuscript carefully, wrapping them in oiled cloth. Margarethe checked her weapons—knife still sharp, small crossbow still functional.

They should leave. Head east immediately. Every hour they delayed was an hour the net could tighten.

But first, they needed rest. Real rest. Their bodies were reaching their limits—Margarethe's arrow wound still healing, Thomas's hands scraped raw, both of them running on fear and determination alone.

"We rest here today," Margarethe said. "Move tonight under cover of darkness. Travel is slower but safer."

Thomas nodded, grateful. He spread blankets on the cleanest section of floor.

They took turns sleeping, one always on watch. The autumn sun climbed higher. Birds sang in the forest beyond, oblivious to human concerns.

Thomas woke to footsteps approaching—boots on frost-brittle grass, deliberate and unhurried. Not trying to hide.

He grabbed the knife Margarethe had insisted he keep within reach, heart hammering.

Margarethe was already awake, positioned by the window with her crossbow aimed at the door.

The footsteps stopped outside. A pause. Then a voice, young and uncertain:

"I have a message. For Thomas of Mainz. From… from someone who says you'll understand the name Wilhelm."

Thomas and Margarethe exchanged glances. A trap? Or genuine?

"Leave it by the door," Margarethe called out, voice hard. "Then step back twenty paces. We'll retrieve it when you're clear."

"I can't. It's not written down. Too dangerous." The voice was definitely young—perhaps sixteen, seventeen at most. Male. Scared but determined. "The message is in my head. I was told to speak it directly to Thomas, no one else."

Margarethe's jaw tightened. Messages carried in memory—classic network tradecraft. Safer. But also potentially a way to lure them.

Thomas made the decision quickly. "I'm opening the door. If you're armed, if there are others, we'll kill you before you can call for help. Understand?"

"I understand. I'm alone. Unarmed. Just a runner for the network. Please—I need to deliver this message and get back before I'm missed."

Thomas cracked the door open, knife ready.

A boy stood there—sixteen at most, dressed in apprentice's clothes, with nervous energy. His hands were visible, empty, trembling slightly.

"Quickly," Thomas said. "Your message."

The boy took a breath, reciting with careful precision: "Johannes the Alchemist lives. Captured during the raid on the safe house two nights past. Currently held in the cathedral's prison—beneath the bishop's residence, same complex where you stole the Silver Key. The Order is interrogating him for information about the network, about you, about the theft. He's being tortured but hasn't broken yet—my contact says he's been asking for specific herbs the guards think are for pain relief but which might be something else entirely. This is day two of captivity. The Order typically executes prisoners after five days of questioning

if they haven't extracted useful information. You have three days, perhaps four at most, before they either kill him or transfer him to a more secure location."

The boy paused, then added in his own voice: "My master—the one who sent me—says it's suicide to try a rescue. That you should run east while you still can. That Johannes would want you to complete the quest rather than die trying to save him. But the master also said you'd want to know Johannes is alive. That you'd want the choice."

Thomas felt ice and fire warring in his chest. Johannes was alive. Being tortured. Three days, perhaps four.

"Who's your master?" Margarethe asked, crossbow still steady.

"I can't say. Network security—you understand. But someone who knew Wilhelm. Who knew Heinrich. Who remembers when the Order was about preserving knowledge instead of…" He trailed off.

"Instead of breeding people like livestock and killing those who resist," Margarethe finished coldly.

The boy nodded, miserable. "I should go. I've delivered the message. What you do with it is your choice." He turned to leave, then paused. "For what it's worth—I hope you run. I hope you survive. Someone needs to understand what the Protocol really says. What it was before they corrupted it."

He disappeared into the autumn forest.

Margarethe lowered the crossbow slowly, expression unreadable. "It could be a trap."

"I know."

"The Order could have forced someone to send that message. Could be using Johannes as bait to lure us back where they have every advantage."

"I know that too."

"We should run. East toward Prague like we planned. Every hour we waste is an hour they have to find us." Her hand drifted to her weapon, then fell away—uncertainty she never showed.

Thomas looked at the manuscript spread on the floor—bloodline patterns tracked across forty generations. His family. Margarethe's family. Johannes's family. All of them shaped and guided and bred like animals.

And Johannes, who'd helped them understand that horror, who'd taught them what the keys meant, who'd given them everything they needed to steal the Silver Key—he was being tortured right now. Suffering because he'd helped them.

Thomas took one last look at Cologne in the distance, smoke rising from the cathedral quarter.

Not east.

Not yet.

First, they had a rescue to attempt.

Two people bred for someone else's purpose, choosing their own path.

The pattern broken. The design rejected.

Even if it killed them.

CHAPTER 5 - THE RESCUE

1347, Forest Outside Cologne

The abandoned shepherd's hut stank.

Rot and mouse droppings, yes, but also the particular decay that came from human structures surrendering to nature—moldering thatch, wood gone soft with fungus, the musty sweetness of decomposing straw. Thomas sat on a collapsed beam that had once been part of the roof, studying the manuscript by pale morning light that filtered through gaps in the walls where the wattle and daub had crumbled away entirely. Outside, autumn wind rattled dead leaves. A crow called, harsh and mocking.

The bloodline patterns were clearer now. Families tracked across generations like breeding stock. His own line—forty-one generations—bred deliberately to produce someone with Wilhelm's gifts.

A man made on purpose.

"We should keep moving."

Margarethe stood in the doorway, sharpening her knife. "East toward Prague, like Johannes said. Every hour we stay near Cologne is an hour they can find us."

"I know." Thomas didn't look up from the manuscript.

The scraping stopped. "You've been staring at that same page for twenty minutes. That's not reading. That's avoiding making a decision you've already made."

Thomas looked up. "Johannes."

The name hung in the cold morning air between them like smoke from a funeral pyre.

Margarethe's hand froze mid-stroke on the whetstone, the blade at the exact angle of sharpening. "Johannes is captured. Probably dead by now—the Order doesn't waste resources feeding prisoners who can't give them useful information."

"We don't know that. Two days isn't long enough to—" Thomas stopped, forced himself to be honest instead of hopeful. "If he's alive, they're torturing him. For information about us. About the network. Every hour he doesn't break is an hour of agony we're causing by not being far enough away to make his information useless."

"Which is why we need to leave. Put distance between us and whatever he tells them under torture." Margarethe set down the knife and whetstone with deliberate care. "Running is the smart play. The practical play. The play that keeps the keys safe and the quest alive."

"Or we rescue him," Thomas said quietly.

The words hung there. Absurd. Impossible. Suicidal.

Margarethe stared at him like he'd suggested they fly to the moon by flapping their arms very hard. "That's suicide. The bishop's prison is in the cathedral complex—the same cathedral we just stole from two nights ago. They'll have the highest watch. Guards everywhere, patrols doubled, every door eyed, every stranger weighed."

"Probably," Thomas agreed. His hands shook despite his steady voice.

"Then why are you suggesting it?" But there was something in Margarethe's voice that wasn't quite dismissal. More like she was testing him, seeing if he'd thought this through or was just reacting emotionally to guilt.

"Because I'm tired of leaving people behind to die. Hamo. Wilhelm. Your parents. Johannes helped us despite the risk, and now he's being tortured because of it."

"He chose to help us." Margarethe's voice had softened.

"And we chose to accept that help knowing it might get him killed." Thomas stood. "I know it's suicide. But I can't keep running while people who helped me suffer and die. I can't keep prioritizing the quest over the people who make the quest possible."

Margarethe studied him for a long moment.

"You've changed," she said finally, testing her knife's edge. "The Thomas I met two weeks ago would have chosen pragmatism. Now you're talking about throwing away everything for a rescue that probably won't work."

"I know."

"Good. Because I agree with you."

Thomas blinked. "What?"

"Johannes saved my life when I was sixteen. After my father died, I had nothing. Johannes took me in. Taught me to navigate the network. Gave me contacts, training, helped me understand that being unable to read didn't make me useless." Margarethe began checking her weapons. "I've been trying to convince myself to leave him behind because it's logical. Because I've learned to shut down emotions that could get me killed. But logic isn't everything. Sometimes you have to do the stupid, dangerous thing because it's right. Because leaving people to die after they helped you makes you exactly like the Order—viewing humans as tools to be discarded when no longer useful."

Relief washed through Thomas like cold water, sharp and clean. "So we try?"

"We try. And we probably die trying. But we try anyway because the alternative is becoming what we're fighting against." Margarethe's expression was grim but determined. "We'll need a plan, though. The cathedral will be heavily guarded after the theft. This needs to be clean. Precise. In and out before they even realize we were there."

"I have an idea," Thomas said slowly, the plan already forming with the clarity of his mind for patterns—a gift bred into him. "But you're not going to like it."

"Most good plans are ones nobody likes," Margarethe said. "Tell me anyway."

1347, Cologne Cathedral, Evening of the Third Day

Thomas walked through the cathedral's main entrance wearing monk's robes he'd stolen from a traveling friar's cart that morning while the friar was inside a tavern getting drunk on cheap wine and cheaper company.

His heart hammered.

So hard he was sure everyone could hear it—the guards flanking the massive wooden doors carved with scenes of judgment and damnation, the priests moving through the nave with practiced purpose, the handful of wealthy petitioners waiting to see the bishop about this favor or that dispensation. Every person who looked at him was a potential threat. Every glance could be recognition. Every moment could be exposure.

Incense hung thick in the air, cloying and sweet. Somewhere in the vaulted heights above, a choir practiced evening psalms, their voices echoing off stone like the sound of angels trapped in a cave.

But he kept his head down in the proper monastic posture of humility, moved with the shuffling gait of someone old and tired from travel, and headed toward the side chapel dedicated to Saint Catherine.

People didn't look closely at monks. Especially not in plague times when holy men were everywhere like crows at a battlefield—praying for the sick, administering last rites to the dying, begging for alms to support their monasteries. Just another brown robe in a sea of brown robes, invisible through sheer ubiquity.

Thomas found the side chapel he'd scouted that morning while pretending to pray—small, dark, tucked into the north transept where almost nobody went. Knelt as if in prayer before the altar with its slightly dusty statue of Saint Catherine holding her wheel of martyrdom. Waited.

Margarethe should be in position now. The plan was insane—they'd both agreed on that while hastily preparing over the past few hours—but it was all they had.

Thomas pulled out a small vial from his sleeve, the glass warm from his body heat. Oil of vitriol—Johannes had taught him to make it during their brief time together, demonstrating the chemical's properties with the enthusiasm of someone who genuinely loved the natural philosophy others called alchemy. Dangerous stuff. Burned through almost anything organic given enough time and concentration.

He poured three careful drops on the lock mechanism of the side door leading to the cathedral's interior passages. The acid hissed quietly, eating through the bronze with patient chemical hunger. Forty-five seconds until the lock would be destroyed—long enough that he wouldn't be waiting there obviously doing nothing, short enough that the metal wouldn't drip or smoke or otherwise draw attention.

Behind him, footsteps on stone. Slow, measured, purposeful.

Thomas froze mid-prayer, head bowed, hands clasped, every muscle tense.

"Brother," a voice said. Male, older, with the particular authority of someone used to being obeyed in religious spaces. "The chapel is closing for evening prayers. You'll need to—"

An explosion. Distant but loud enough to shake the cathedral stones, to rattle the leaded glass windows, to send dust drifting down from the vaulted ceiling high overhead. From the direction of the bishop's residence on the other side of the complex.

The priest—Thomas hadn't dared look up to confirm but the voice suggested someone senior, perhaps a canon or archdeacon—ran toward the sound immediately, robes flapping, calling out questions to other clergy who were also running to see what had happened.

Margarethe's diversion. She'd promised to make it spectacular, and apparently she'd delivered.

Thomas stood, tested the door lock with gentle pressure. The mechanism crumbled, the acid having done its work perfectly. The door swung open on hinges that had been oiled recently—the cathedral staff main-

tained their spaces well, which was fortunate since squeaking hinges would have announced his presence to everyone in the transept.

He slipped into the interior passages, pulling the broken lock free and taking it with him. No point leaving obvious evidence of sabotage where anyone could find it in the next few minutes.

The cathedral was chaos in the specific way any great house became when something unexpected happened. Guards running toward the explosion, their boots loud on stone floors. Priests shouting orders to each other, trying to organize a response. Somewhere, bells were ringing—not the normal call to prayer but the sharp, irregular clanging of alarm bells that meant danger or fire or both.

Thomas moved against the flow of traffic, heading down instead of up. Toward the dungeons beneath the bishop's residence where prisoners were kept when the bishop wanted them close for questioning.

He passed three guards running upstairs toward the chaos. None spared him a glance—just another monk seeking shelter from whatever catastrophe was happening above.

Down stone stairs worn smooth by centuries of feet. The temperature dropped with each step, the air growing colder and damper, acquiring that particular underground quality of spaces that never saw sunlight. The sounds of chaos above faded, replaced by the drip of moisture on stone and the scurrying of rats in the walls and his own breathing that seemed too loud in the confined space.

The dungeon corridor stretched ahead, lit by torches in wall brackets that created more shadows than illumination. And at the far end, two guards stood outside the heavy wooden door that led to the cells where Johannes was being held.

Young men, both of them. Nervous energy visible even from this distance. Clearly wanting to go see what the explosion was about, to be part of the action instead of stuck down here guarding one barely-conscious alchemist who'd been tortured for two days and wasn't going anywhere.

Thomas took a breath, steadied himself, and walked toward them with the confidence of someone who absolutely belonged here.

"Brothers," he said in Latin, keeping his voice gentle and old-sounding. "I've been sent to pray with the prisoner. The bishop wants his soul saved before the execution at dawn."

The guards exchanged glances. The younger one—perhaps nineteen, with the sparse beard of someone who desperately wanted to look older—spoke first: "No one's allowed down here. Bishop's orders. The prisoner is being questioned and—"

"The bishop himself sent me," Thomas interrupted, pulling out the forged document he and Margarethe had hastily created—crude work, but with a wax seal that looked official enough in torchlight. "To offer last rites before the execution. The prisoner is connected to the theft from the treasury. The bishop wants him shriven before death so his soul can confess properly without the burden of mortal sin preventing honest testimony."

It was theological nonsense—confession didn't work that way—but it sounded official and religious and these were guards, not priests. They wouldn't know the theological details.

The older guard squinted at the document, trying to read wax seal impressions in dim torchlight. "We weren't told about any execution."

"That's because it's secret. Quiet. The prisoner is connected to important people the bishop doesn't want to embarrass publicly. Better to deal with him quietly and avoid scandal." Thomas let impatience enter his voice—the irritation of a monk who'd walked all the way down here only to be delayed by guards questioning clear authority. "Look, you can send someone to verify with the bishop's steward if you want. I'll wait. But

when the steward tells you I'm here on the bishop's direct orders and you've wasted his time making him confirm it, don't be surprised if you're both assigned to midnight guard duty in the plague quarter for the next month."

The threat was specific enough to sound real. Guard duty in the plague quarter was everyone's nightmare—constant exposure to disease, constant risk of infection, constant presence of death.

The guards looked at each other. Youth and inexperience warring with the desire to avoid making a mistake that would result in punishment. The explosion above was still audible—distant shouts, running feet, the continued chaos of Margarethe's diversion keeping everyone's attention focused elsewhere.

"Five minutes," the older guard finally said, unlocking the heavy door with a key from his belt. "That's all. And we'll be right outside listening, so don't try anything suspicious."

"I'm here to pray, not to fight," Thomas said mildly, which was technically true even if the prayer would be very brief and focused on *please God let this work*.

He entered the cell corridor, and the door closed behind him with the particular sound heavy wood makes when designed to contain people who don't want to be contained.

Three cells, all occupied. Thomas could see figures in the first two—prisoners from other crimes, other problems the bishop wanted to deal with quietly. He found Johannes in the farthest cell.

The alchemist was barely recognizable. His face had been beaten into pulp—purple-black bruising, one eye swollen shut, the other a slit leaking red from burst vessels. Chains suspended him by the wrists, forcing him half-upright in a position that screamed shoulder dislocation. His scholar's robes hung in tatters, stiff with dried blood and worse.

"Johannes," Thomas whispered urgently.

The alchemist's good eye opened—or tried to, the swelling made it difficult. Focused. Recognition dawned, followed immediately by horror.

"Thomas?" His voice was rough, damaged from screaming. "You idiot. You absolute idiot. You shouldn't be—"

"Shut up. I'm getting you out." Thomas pulled out his lock picks, started working on the cell door. His hands shook—from fear or adrenaline or the horror of seeing what they'd done to Johannes in just two days—but his fingers remembered the training. The lock was simpler than the Bavarian mechanism from the treasury. Basic church-quality security, meant to keep peasants and drunks contained, not sophisticated thieves with specialized tools.

"You'll be captured," Johannes said, his voice gaining strength despite the damage. "Both keys will be lost. Everything we've worked for will—"

"I said shut up." The first pin aligned. Click. "Margarethe's creating a diversion. Ten minutes. Maybe less. Save your breath for walking."

"Margarethe's here too?" Johannes sounded caught between gratitude and horror. "You're both—"

"Insane. Yes. You mentioned." The second pin aligned. Third pin. Fourth. The lock clicked open. "Did you think we'd leave you?"

A beat of silence. Johannes didn't answer the question. Didn't need to—they both knew the smart move was abandonment.

"I thought you'd do the smart thing. The logical thing." But Johannes was trying to smile despite the split lips and broken teeth and blood crusting his mouth.

"We tried. Turns out we're both terrible at logic when it involves leaving people to die." Thomas entered the cell, started working on the chains. These locks were even simpler—basic restraint mechanisms designed for security rather than sophistication. "How badly are you hurt?"

"Ribs broken. Internal bleeding, I think—I keep coughing blood and it tastes like copper and rot. Left leg twisted when they dropped me—might be fractured, might just be badly sprained." Johannes listed his injuries with the cold precision of someone trained in natural philosophy. "They tortured me for information. Asking about the network, about you, about where you'd go. What you knew. Who else was involved."

"What did you tell them?" Thomas got the first chain open, supporting Johannes's weight as the alchemist's arm dropped, unable to hold itself up.

"Nothing useful. Lies. Misdirection. Sent them chasing shadows in the wrong directions." Johannes coughed, and blood appeared on his lips—bright red, which was bad. Internal bleeding. "But everyone breaks eventually, Thomas. You know that. Another day, perhaps two, and I would have told them everything. Would have given them your names, your descriptions, where you planned to go, what you were looking for."

"But you didn't. That's what matters." Thomas got the second chain open. Johannes collapsed against him, unable to stand on his own, all his weight suddenly transferred to Thomas's shoulders. "Can you walk?"

"I can barely stand. Walking might be optimistic." Johannes tried to put weight on his injured leg, gasped in pain, nearly fell. "You need to leave me. Take the keys. Run while you still can. I'm just dead weight that will get you captured."

"Stop talking and lean on me." Thomas wrapped Johannes's arm around his shoulders, took most of the alchemist's weight. They stumbled toward the cell door together, moving with painful slowness.

Outside the cells, shouts. The guards had figured out something was wrong. Perhaps the explosion hadn't been as long a diversion as they'd hoped. Perhaps someone had sent word about a suspicious monk. Perhaps the guards' instincts had kicked in and they'd decided to check on the prisoner.

Thomas and Johannes stumbled into the corridor. The two guards were drawing swords, their young faces shifting from confusion to alarm to determination.

"Sorry about this," Thomas said.

Then Margarethe dropped from the ventilation shaft above—a narrow access tunnel for air circulation that she'd somehow squeezed through, her body contorting in ways Thomas hadn't thought possible—and landed between Thomas and the guards like a cat falling four stories and landing on its feet.

She was a blur of motion. Knife flashing in torchlight. One guard down, clutching a bleeding arm—cut precisely to disable without killing, exactly where the major tendons would sever and make sword-holding impossible. The other guard backing away, his sword raised but his eyes showing fear.

"Go!" Margarethe shouted. "Get him out! I'll handle this!"

Thomas half-carried Johannes toward the stairs, the alchemist's breathing labored and wet-sounding. Behind them, sounds of fighting. Margarethe was good—better than good, trained by her father and survival and necessity into something dangerous and precise—but she was fighting trained soldiers in an enclosed space where her mobility advantage was limited.

They made it to the stairs. Started climbing, every step an agony for Johannes who couldn't put weight on his injured leg.

More guards above, coming down to investigate the sounds of fighting. Three of them, armored, with swords drawn and that trained readiness that meant cathedral guards, not city watch. These were men who'd fought in wars, who knew what they were doing, who wouldn't hesitate.

Thomas looked around desperately, searching for options in a stone stairwell that offered none. Nowhere to hide. Nowhere to run. Trapped between guards above and below, with a wounded alchemist who could barely stand and no weapons except his lock picks that were absolutely useless in a fight.

Then a door opened to the side—Thomas hadn't even noticed it in the stone wall, so well did it blend with the masonry. A priest stood there, old, wrinkled, with kind eyes that nevertheless showed sharp intelligence.

"This way. Quickly."

Thomas didn't question. Didn't hesitate. Just pulled Johannes through the door while the old priest held it open.

The priest led them through a hidden passage, moving with surprising speed for his age, his footsteps sure on stone floors he'd obviously walked many times before. "I'm Father Marcus," he said quietly as they moved. "I knew Wilhelm—your grandfather. Good man. Brilliant mind. We studied together in Paris, decades ago. This network he was part of… it's not what it used to be. Not what it was meant to be when it was founded."

They emerged in a storage room filled with cleaning supplies and church vestments and the accumulated debris of centuries of cathedral life. Father Marcus handed Thomas a key, his gnarled fingers pressing it into Thomas's palm with gentle insistence. Then he pulled a scroll from within his robes—old vellum, carefully preserved. "Wilhelm's notes. He left them with me for safekeeping years ago, said if anything happened to him, I should give them to his successor. I think that's you."

Thomas took the scroll.

"Side exit. Through the garden on the north side," Father Marcus continued urgently. "Guards are all dealing with the fire and the fight. You have minutes—perhaps less—but it's your only chance."

"Thank you." Thomas tucked the scroll inside his robe.

"Don't thank me. Just survive. Understand what the Protocol really means, not what they've corrupted it into. And stop them if you can. Stop what the Order has become." Father Marcus disappeared back into the passage, the door closing behind him so smoothly Thomas could barely see where it had been in the wall.

Thomas and Johannes stumbled through the storage room, out into a garden that smelled of late autumn and decay and the particular sweetness of roses going to winter sleep. The cold night air hit them after the stuffy interior—shocking and sharp, frost crackling underfoot, the smell of woodsmoke from distant hearths mixing with frozen earth.

"Where's Margarethe?" Johannes whispered.

As if summoned by her name, she appeared from another direction, breathing hard, blood on her knife and a cut on her cheek that hadn't been there before. "Guards down. Not dead but they won't follow for a while. We need to—"

An arrow struck the ground between them, its iron point burying three inches into the frozen earth.

Gray Robes. Four of them, emerging from the shadows of the garden like manifestations of death itself. Bows drawn. More arrows nocked and aimed.

"Run," Margarethe said. Her face had gone blank—the warrior's mask.

They ran.

1347, Safe House, Cologne Outskirts, Deep Night

They made it to the safe house—a different one from before, further from the city, a half-collapsed barn that smelled of old hay and animal waste and abandonment—just as Johannes collapsed completely.

Thomas caught him, tried to ease him down gently onto the straw-covered floor, but the alchemist's weight was dead weight and they both went down in a tangle of limbs and blood and broken bodies.

"He's dying," Margarethe said bluntly, kneeling beside them to check Johannes's injuries with hands that knew such wounds from bitter experience. "Blood inside. Look at his belly—swollen, tight. Probably broken ribs driven inward during the torture. And his breathing is too shallow, too fast. A lung pierced, perhaps, or just too much damage to his chest."

"Can we—" Thomas started.

"No. Not without a physician, and we can't risk bringing one here. Even if we could, he's too far gone." Margarethe shook her head. "He'll be dead by morning. Perhaps sooner."

Johannes coughed, and blood bubbled from his lips—frothy, bright red, the color of arterial bleeding. "Not… dead yet. Just… resting. Taking a brief pause to appreciate… the absurdity of being rescued only to die anyway."

"Save your strength," Thomas said. His throat tightened, eyes burning.

Another person dying for knowledge he carried. Another debt he'd never repay.

"For what? More bleeding? More dying?" Johannes grabbed Thomas's hand with surprising strength considering how broken he was. "No. Stop pretending and listen. I need to tell you about the third key before I run out of time and breath."

Margarethe leaned closer.

"The third key is a person," Johannes interrupted urgently. "A living descendant with cipher knowledge in their blood memory. Woman named Adela—bred to carry the third Protocol fragment. But the plague took her three weeks ago."

"Then the third key is lost," Margarethe said.

"No. She had a daughter. Maria, perhaps fourteen. The key passed to her through bloodline. All the knowledge, forty generations back, waiting to be woken." Johannes fixed Thomas with desperate intensity. "You need to find her. She's the third key. Without her, you're operating blind."

"Where?"

"St. Catherine's Convent. Eastern road. The nuns took her in." Johannes coughed violently, blood covering his hand. "Find her before the Order does. Before they realize she inherited the key."

"We'll find her," Thomas promised, gripping Johannes's bloody hand. "We'll protect her. We'll use her knowledge to unlock the Protocol and understand what the Order is really doing."

"Good. Good." Johannes's breathing was becoming shallower, more irregular, the pauses between breaths growing longer. "The Protocol… it's not what they think. The Order… they corrupted it. Changed it. Turned preservation into something else. Something darker."

"What was the original purpose?" Margarethe asked, leaning close to hear Johannes's weakening voice.

"To prevent collapse. Not make it. But they twisted it over centuries. Turned saving humanity into playing God." Johannes's eye was losing focus. "The seven keys unlock locations. Seven places across Europe where Protocol fragments are hidden. Each shows part of the truth. Together they show what it was meant to be before corruption."

"Where?" Thomas asked urgently.

"Cologne—I memorized it before the Order destroyed the manuscript. Prague—Maria can access it using blood memory. Constantinople. Cairo. England, somewhere. Two others I never discovered. Lost to time or fire."

His breathing was slowing.

"The complete Protocol shows the truth about kingdoms falling. The Order was created to guide recovery. But guiding recovery became making collapse. Preserving knowledge became controlling who survives."

"We'll find all seven fragments."

"You have to." Johannes's eye closed. "Because they're planning something. Centuries from now. Breeding programs extending for generations. Plans to shape populations. Steer collapse. They're not trying to prevent catastrophe anymore. They're trying to cause it in a way they can control."

His hand went limp in Thomas's grip.

For a moment, Thomas hoped he was just unconscious, just too weak to maintain consciousness but still alive, still breathing, still savable.

But when Margarethe checked for a pulse in Johannes's neck, her expression told Thomas everything he needed to know.

"He's gone," she said quietly.

Thomas sat back, numb. Another death. Hamo. The guards. Now Johannes. How many more?

"We should bury him."

They buried Johannes in the forest behind the barn, digging in cold earth. No marker. No ceremony. Just two people committing a good man to the ground.

When it was done, Thomas stood over the unmarked grave in silence.

"We need to find Maria," Margarethe said finally. "The third key. St. Catherine's Convent. Before the Order figures out she exists."

"She's a girl who just lost her mother. We can't just tell her she's a key bred for a thousand-year conspiracy."

"We tell her the truth. Show her the cipher. Let her see what she carries." Margarethe started walking back. "And we give her a choice. Come with us or stay hidden. It's more choice than most in the Order's breeding programs ever got."

Thomas looked back at the unmarked grave. "Will this ever be worth it? All these deaths?"

"I don't know. But we're too far in to stop. Too many have died for us to give up now. So we keep going. Find Maria. Unlock the third fragment. Make all these deaths mean something."

She was right. They were committed now.

Only forward.

1347, St. Catherine's Convent, Next Morning

The convent sat on a hillside north of Cologne like a watchful stone sentinel, far enough from the city to avoid the worst of the plague's ravages but close enough to take in refugees and orphans and women fleeing domestic situations that had become dangerous in desperate times.

Thomas and Margarethe approached at midmorning, when the nuns would be finished with prime prayers but not yet deep into the day's work. They'd cleaned themselves as best they could in a stream, changed into the least bloodstained of their remaining clothes, tried to look like travelers seeking legitimate shelter rather than fugitives seeking access to a human key bred for someone else's purpose.

The abbess who met them at the gate was a severe woman in her fifties, with the kind of face that suggested she'd seen every form of human suffering and deception and wasn't impressed by new variations. "We have little to spare for wayfarers," she said without preamble, her eyes cataloging Thomas's monk's robes—stolen and ill-fitting—and Margarethe's practical traveling clothes that suggested a woman who'd learned to move through the world without male protection. "The plague has brought many to our door. We do what we can but our resources are limited. If you're seeking food or shelter—"

"We're seeking someone specific," Margarethe interrupted gently. "A girl named Maria. Her mother was Adela."

The abbess's expression shifted—not quite suspicion but definitely wariness. "What business do you have with Maria?"

Thomas pulled out the pendant Johannes had saved from his workshop before it was raided and burned—small silver piece with cipher marks worked into the decorative elements so subtly they looked like ornamentation to anyone who didn't know what to look for. "Her mother was… connected to our family. Distant connections through scholarly networks. We promised to look after her daughter if anything happened to Adela. To make sure Maria was cared for and protected."

It was half truth and half calculated deception. The best kind of lie, built on enough reality to be convincing.

The abbess took the pendant, examined it with careful scrutiny. Turned it over in her weathered hands, studying the cipher marks without appearing to recognize them as anything more than pretty geometric patterns. "This was Adela's. I saw her wear it many times during her visits here over the years. She came to pray when the plague fears first started spreading, seeking divine protection for her daughter."

She looked up at them, her gaze sharp and assessing. "You're not pilgrims, are you? You're not travelers seeking shelter. You're from the network."

Thomas and Margarethe tensed simultaneously, ready to run if this was betrayal, ready to fight if necessary, though fighting nuns seemed like a fast track to damnation even in their current situation.

But the abbess continued: "Adela told me some of it before she died. Not everything—she was careful even fevered and knowing she had days left at most—but enough. About the cipher. About what Maria carries. About the knowledge encoded in bloodlines and passed through generations like original sin. She made me

promise to protect the girl from the Order—from the Gray Robes who hunt your people, who burn your knowledge, who view the network as heresy incarnate."

The abbess handed the pendant back to Thomas. "But she also said someone from the network might come eventually. Someone who needed what Maria has. Someone who would try to use the girl's gift for their purposes. So before I take you to her, tell me honestly: Are you here to use her? Or to help her?"

Thomas thought about Johannes dying in a barn, about Wilhelm murdered by poison for his knowledge, about Margarethe's parents murdered by the same Order that had created them through generations of breeding. About how easy it would be to view Maria as a tool—a living key to unlock information they needed—rather than a person with her own fears and desires and the right to choose her own path.

"Both," he said honestly, because lying to an abbess seemed worse than admitting uncomfortable truths. "We need her help to access knowledge we can't reach without her. But we also want to protect her from people who would use her without her consent, who would breed her for the next generation, who would see her as breeding stock rather than a human being. We're offering her a choice—come with us and learn what she carries, or stay here hidden and hope the Order never realizes she exists."

The abbess studied him for a long moment, searching his face for deception or malice or the particular manipulation that characterized people who'd learned to use pretty words to disguise ugly intentions.

Finally, she nodded. "That's more honest than most people in your position would be. And more choice than Adela ever had—she was born into the Order's breeding program, married to a man the Order chose because their bloodlines suited its purposes, became pregnant because the Order decided her bloodline needed continuation. The only choice she ever truly made was refusing to have more children after Maria. That defiance cost her dearly even before the plague took her."

She gestured for them to follow. "Come. I'll take you to her. But if you hurt that girl, if you use her purely as a tool, if you betray the trust she's about to give you, I will personally ensure the Order finds you. Do we understand each other?"

"Aye, Mother Superior," Thomas said, using the respectful form of address automatically.

They followed the abbess through quiet stone corridors. Past the chapel where nuns were singing Sext. Past the kitchen where lay sisters prepared the midday meal.

To a small room where a girl sat by the window, reading by gray autumn light.

"Maria," the abbess said gently. "These people knew your mother. They need to speak with you about… family matters."

The girl looked up from her book—Latin text, Thomas noticed, something theological or philosophical. She was perhaps fourteen, with her mother's dark hair worn in two long braids, fine thoughtful features that suggested Adela's scholarly gifts had passed to the daughter, and eyes that were red-rimmed from recent crying but currently clear and focused.

"About what?" she asked, her voice wary.

"About what you are," Thomas said carefully, stepping forward slowly so as not to startle her. "About what your mother was. About the knowledge you carry without fully knowing it."

Maria set down the book—carefully, marking her place with a strip of cloth, the gesture of someone who respected written words. "I don't understand."

"Your mother was part of a group that preserves knowledge in bloodlines," Margarethe said. "Blood memory passed from parent to child. You have the same ability she had."

Maria's voice lacked conviction. "That's not possible."

Thomas placed both keys on the manuscript in the specific alignment that revealed the cipher. "Touch the page where the cipher marks appear."

Maria hesitated, her hand hovering over the manuscript, intelligent enough to recognize this was a threshold moment—that touching would change something fundamental about how she understood herself and her place in the world.

Then she reached out. Her fingers brushed the manuscript where the cipher marks glowed with the light of both keys working together.

And gasped.

Her eyes went wide, unfocused, seeing something beyond the room. Her pupils dilated. Her breathing changed, becoming rapid and shallow like someone experiencing intense emotion or shock or both simultaneously.

"What's happening to her?" the abbess demanded, moving to intervene.

"Blood memory—activating," Margarethe said, restraining the abbess. "Don't interrupt. Needs to complete."

Maria's hand moved across the page. She began speaking—Latin, then Greek, then Arabic. Languages flowing from inherited knowledge.

"She's reciting the third Protocol fragment," Margarethe whispered. "The part her bloodline was bred to carry."

Maria spoke for ten minutes, her voice steady, accessing memories that weren't hers but somehow were. She drew symbols in the air, traced patterns, spoke words in languages that sounded ancient and powerful.

Then she collapsed.

Margarethe caught her, eased her into the chair. "It's all right. The first activation is overwhelming. Just breathe."

Maria's eyes focused again—not immediately, but gradually, like someone surfacing from deep water into light. Normal brown eyes instead of the distant unfocused stare of blood memory access. But changed somehow, like she was seeing the world through different perspectives, understanding it through the accumulated wisdom of forty generations.

"I remember," she whispered, her voice hoarse. "Not my memories. Theirs. My mother. My grandmother. Back and back and back. Forty generations of women carrying this knowledge. Memorizing it. Encoding it in their blood and bones so it could survive when everything else burned."

She looked at her hands like they belonged to someone else, like they were vessels containing more than just flesh and blood and bone. "They made us into living books. Didn't they? The Order. They bred us specifically to carry information that couldn't be safely written down. Made blood memory into a library that can't burn."

"Aye," Thomas said, because lying seemed pointless when she could literally access her ancestors' memories and learn the truth herself.

"And my mother died protecting this?" Maria's voice was steady but her eyes were filling with tears. "This curse? This burden of carrying knowledge I never asked for?"

"Your mother died of plague," the abbess said firmly, moving to put her hands on Maria's shoulders in a gesture of comfort and grounding. "Not because of the Order. The plague takes everyone—rich and poor, chosen bloodlines and random peasants. It doesn't care about bloodline schemes or secret plots."

"But the plague came because the Order let it come," Maria said with the eerie certainty of someone accessing ancestral memories. "I can see it now in the fragments. The pattern. They've done this before—made it happen, or at least stood aside while it spread—because it served their purposes. Thinning the weak. Testing the bloodlines. Leaving fewer mouths when stores ran low. This plague isn't an accident to them. It's part of their design."

She stood abruptly, suddenly decisive despite having just experienced something that should have left her shattered. "You're going to Prague. To find the fourth fragment. To continue unlocking the Protocol piece by piece across Europe. And you need me to access memories you can't reach, to interpret knowledge written in blood rather than ink."

"We're giving you a choice," Thomas said, echoing what he'd told the abbess. "You can stay here. Safe. Hidden. The Order doesn't know you're the third key yet—doesn't know your mother's death passed the blood memory to you. You could live a quiet life, take vows and become a nun, or eventually leave the convent and marry someone of your choosing and have children who might or might not inherit your gift."

"A normal life?" Maria laughed, and the sound was bitter and sharp and far too old for a fourteen-year-old's throat. "I just felt forty generations of memories flow through me like a river. I know things no one my age should know. I dream in languages I've never consciously learned. I can see patterns in history and blood and the ways of men that took scholars lifetimes to understand."

She looked at her hands as though they belonged to someone else. "Normal died the moment I touched that manuscript and woke something that's been sleeping in me since birth."

She looked at the abbess with eyes that seemed to contain more than one person's perspective. "Mother Superior, I need to go with them."

"Maria—" the abbess started.

"I need to understand what I am. What my mother was. What forty generations of my family died to protect or were murdered for refusing to cooperate with." Maria's voice was steady, resolved in the way that suggested she'd already made the decision and was just informing everyone else. "And I can help stop whatever the Order is planning. Use this curse for something good instead of just carrying it forward to burden the next generation."

She picked up a small bag—already packed, Thomas noticed, like she'd been waiting for this moment or something like it. "Where's Prague?"

"East," Thomas said, making his own decision in that moment to accept her help despite knowing they were leading a fourteen-year-old girl into danger. "Weeks of travel through plague country. Past territories controlled by nobles who might be network members or Order supporters or just bandits exploiting the chaos. The Order is hunting us specifically—they captured and tortured our friend for information about where we're going and what we know. This will be dangerous. Probably fatal. We might all die before reaching the seventh fragment."

"Then we should start walking," Maria said with the practical determination of someone who'd just accessed forty generations of human experience and decided that fear was less important than purpose. "I can tell you

what I saw in the memories. About the fourth fragment's location. About what the Protocol actually says when you combine all the pieces instead of working from corrupted fragments."

She turned to the abbess, her young face showing both gratitude and sorrow. "Thank you for taking me in when mother died. For protecting me when I had nowhere else to go. For keeping me safe these weeks while the world fell apart outside these walls."

"Child—" the abbess's voice was thick with emotion she was clearly trying to control.

Maria hugged her quickly, fiercely, the embrace of someone who knew they might never see this person again. "I'll remember you. You'll be part of my memories now, written into my blood, passed to my children if I live long enough to have any. That's how our gift works—we remember everything important, preserve it in our very being, carry it forward through generations."

She pulled back, adjusted the bag across her shoulder with the practical efficiency of someone much older than fourteen. "I'm ready."

They left the convent as the sun climbed toward noon, three people carrying two metal keys and one human key whose blood carried knowledge shaped across forty generations of careful breeding.

Behind them, the abbess watched from the gate until they disappeared into the forest that lined the eastern road.

Then she went inside and began burning records—any mention of Maria's name, her mother's name, the family connection to the Order. Erasing what she could of the girl's past to protect her future, even though that future was heading directly into danger the abbess could neither prevent nor protect against.

The third key had been found.

The quest was continuing.

And somewhere in Cologne and beyond, the network and the Order both realized that the bloodlines were gathering, the keys were uniting, and the Genesis Protocol might actually be read in its entirety for the first time in centuries.

The race was accelerating.

1347, Forest Road East of Cologne, Late Afternoon

They walked in silence for the first hour, giving Maria time to take in what had happened, giving themselves time to adjust to the reality of traveling with a fourteen-year-old girl who carried forty generations of memory in her head and seemed simultaneously ancient and achingly young.

The forest was quiet except for their footsteps and the occasional bird call and the rustle of wind through bare branches. Autumn was deepening toward winter, the cold becoming sharper, the days growing shorter, the signs of coming hardship visible in everything from the angle of sunlight to the behavior of animals gathering food for lean months ahead.

"They bred my mother specifically to create me," Maria said suddenly, breaking the silence. "I can see it in the memories. Not her choice—their choice. The Order's. My father was chosen from the lines they approved. Go-betweens arranged the match and called it chance, romance, fate. They said my parents' blood would suit. I wasn't conceived through love or desire or even accident. I was made."

Thomas and Margarethe exchanged glances but said nothing, letting her talk until the words ran thin.

"My mother tried to resist after I was born," Maria continued, her voice steady but her eyes distant, accessing memories that weren't quite hers. "The Order wanted more children—wanted to spread her bloodline traits wider, create more carriers of the third key in case something happened to me. But she refused. Said one child was enough. Said she wanted to focus on raising me properly rather than bearing more children for the Order's purposes. They… didn't take that refusal well."

"We know," Margarethe said quietly. "We found the records in the bloodline manuscripts. The notation about your mother's 'complications' during your birth. How it was listed as deliberate. An example to enforce compliance."

Maria looked at her sharply. "You've seen the bloodline tracking? The breeding records?"

Thomas pulled out one of the manuscripts, showed her the pages they'd decoded. The generations mapped like merchant inventories. Families tracked across centuries. Traits noted, bloodlines merged, children evaluated for gifts.

Maria studied it with the focused intensity of a scholar. Her hands moved across the page, not reading the Latin—she was too young to have learned all of it yet—but tracing the patterns, seeing the structure.

"I have seen this before," she said quietly. "In Toledo, before the mobs came. Before my family fled to Germany."

"The Order operates there too?" Margarethe asked.

"They operate everywhere. But in Toledo I saw something else." Maria's voice took on the distant quality of someone accessing ancestral memory. "The Order does not hate Jews. They use persecution as a tool. They pressure Jewish families to convert, marry them into Christian bloodlines, harvest the knowledge our physicians carry."

Thomas leaned forward. "What do you mean?"

"My great-grandmother was a physician. My grandmother translated Arabic medical texts. My mother could read Hebrew, Greek, Arabic, Latin—all the languages of learning." Maria's finger traced the bloodline notation. "They didn't marry into Christian families by chance. The Order arranged it. Forced conversions, strategic marriages, threats that made compliance the only option."

"To steal knowledge," Margarethe said slowly.

"To accumulate it. Like a merchant accumulates gold." Maria looked up, and her eyes held the understanding of women who'd seen this pattern for generations. "Your Edmund was right—they accumulate knowledge as others accumulate treasure. And like gold, concentrated knowledge becomes power."

She set down the manuscript. "Jewish scholars preserved Greek philosophy when Christendom burned it. Arabic physicians advanced medicine while Europe bled patients. When the Order wants that knowledge, they don't ask. They don't buy. They take—through forced marriages, through pressure, through making survival conditional on cooperation."

"And your family?" Thomas asked gently.

"We cooperated for three generations because the alternative was death. My great-grandmother married a Christian scholar the Order chose. My grandmother bore children to spread the bloodline traits. My mother…" Maria's voice caught. "My mother refused to bear more children after me. Said one child carrying this burden was enough. They killed her for that refusal. Made it look like plague complications, but I can see it in the blood memory—how they arranged it, how they justified it as 'enforcement of compliance.' "

Margarethe's hand found Maria's shoulder. "I'm sorry."

"Don't be sorry. Be angry. Because they're still doing it." Maria's young face was hard with resolve. "And we're going to stop them."

"But you can be a tool and a person," Maria said, and her voice held the accumulated wisdom of women who'd struggled with this same question for forty generations. "My grandmother said that. And her grandmother before her. They knew they were bred for purpose, knew they carried knowledge that made them valuable to the Order, but they chose what to do with that knowledge. Some cooperated. Some resisted. Some tried to ignore it and live normal lives until the Order forced the issue. The breeding makes us valuable. Our choices make us human."

Margarethe smiled grimly. "You sound like someone much older."

"I am someone much older. I'm fourteen years old and also every woman in my bloodline simultaneously. Their memories are my memories now. Their knowledge is my knowledge. Their struggles are mine to inherit, along with the blood they gave me." Maria adjusted her bag, kept walking with determination. "The fourth fragment is in Prague. Hidden in a location my family has protected for nineteen generations since it was first encoded into our bloodline. The scholar's library in the Jewish quarter—a place that's burned and been rebuilt three times, but the knowledge survived because we carried it in our minds rather than trusting only paper and ink."

"What does the fragment say?" Thomas asked, curious despite knowing that fragmentary knowledge was dangerous, that understanding pieces without the whole often led to worse misunderstanding than ignorance.

"It's part of a warning," Maria said, her voice taking on a distant quality that suggested she was accessing deep memory rather than speaking from conscious knowledge. "The original Genesis Protocol wasn't written to bring ruin. It was meant to fend it off—to teach the signs of a coming fall. How kingdoms grow rich and tangled until they cannot bend. How pride and plenty make them brittle. How one hard blow can topple what seemed unshakable."

She walked in silence for a moment, her young face showing concentration as she pulled more information from blood memory. "The Bronze Age collapse. The fall of Rome. The current plague that's killing a third of Europe. Same pattern. Same cycle. Same ending—when people chase ease and power and forget to keep stores and spare ways."

"So the Protocol was meant to break the cycle?" Margarethe asked.

"It was meant to shepherd the cycle. Accept that falls come—at least until humanity learns to build differently—but make sure knowledge survives the dark ages that follow. Preserve the hard-won wisdom of the last world so the next can rebuild faster, better, with fewer mistakes repeated." Maria's voice was certain, speaking knowledge her ancestors had memorized and encoded. "But somewhere over the centuries, shepherding the cycle became hastening the fall. Preserving knowledge became controlling who gets to use that knowledge. The Order corrupted the original purpose. Turned a defensive safeguard into an offensive weapon."

Thomas thought about the bloodline manuscripts, the breeding programs, the casual way the Order discussed arranging marriages and shaping whole families. "They're not trying to prevent catastrophe anymore. They're trying to control it. Make sure the 'right people' survive."

"Exactly. And if the pattern continues into future centuries, they'll take it even further. Loose plagues or poisons, break trade and coin, starve cities—anything to thin the world to a number they can rule, while keeping protected bloodlines safe to rebuild on their terms."

Maria stopped walking, turned to face Thomas and Margarethe directly. “That’s what we’re trying to stop. Not just some cloistered plot. A thousand-year plan that reaches beyond our lifetimes. A corruption so deep that the people carrying it out honestly believe they’re saving humanity when they’re actually committing the greatest atrocity in history.”

The forest seemed very quiet around them. Very cold. Very empty of hope.

“Can we stop it?” Thomas asked, almost afraid to hear the answer.

“I don’t know,” Maria said honestly. “The complete Protocol might contain the answer—might show how the original founders intended to prevent collapse without making it, how to preserve knowledge without breeding people like livestock, how to break the cycle instead of perpetuating it. But we need all seven fragments. All seven keys. The complete picture instead of these pieces we’re working from.”

She started walking again, her young shoulders squared with determination that came from forty generations of women who’d carried this burden before her. “So we go to Prague. Find the fourth fragment. Continue gathering keys and knowledge across Europe. And we hope that somewhere in the complete Protocol is the information we need to stop what the Order has become.”

“Even if it kills us,” Margarethe added.

“Even if it kills us,” Maria agreed. “Because the alternative is letting them win. Letting the corruption continue. Letting a thousand years of knowledge preservation become centuries of bloodline manipulation and made calamity. My mother died of plague. My grandmother died in childbirth after refusing another pregnancy. My great-grandmother was murdered for trying to leave the Order. I won’t let their suffering be for nothing.”

They walked on through the autumn forest, three people carrying impossible knowledge toward an uncertain destination, knowing they were probably going to die but choosing to continue anyway because the alternative was surrender.

Thomas felt the weight of both keys in his pack—Iron and Silver, the Eye that Sees and the Hand that Guides. And walking beside him, the third key—not metal but human, a fourteen-year-old girl who contained forty generations of memory and seemed simultaneously too young for this burden and older than all of them combined.

Somewhere ahead, Prague waited. And the fourth fragment. And more danger than they could probably survive.

But they walked anyway.

Because sometimes the only choice was between surrendering to the inevitable and fighting against it even when fighting seemed hopeless.

And they’d all already made that choice.

Together.

CHAPTER 6 - THE SEVEN

1347, Forest Road East of Cologne

Thomas's feet hurt. Three days of walking had reduced them to blistered, aching reminders that monastery life hadn't prepared him for fifteen-mile days through November cold. The smell of leaf-rot rose from the forest floor with every step, mixing with the sharper scent of wood smoke from distant farmsteads—traces of human habitation in the vast emptiness plague had carved from the countryside.

"Where's the next key?" Thomas asked, partly to distract himself from his blistered feet.

"Prague," Maria said. "The fourth key—the Voice that Speaks—is hidden in the Jewish quarter's scholar's library. My blood memory includes the exact location, the countersigns needed to identify ourselves to the guardians."

"And after that?"

"Constantinople for the fifth. Then England for the sixth—Johannes spent twenty years researching that one." Maria's voice faltered. "But he died before he could tell us everything."

They walked in silence. Each carrying grief differently.

Thomas remembered Johannes's death—the brilliant, eccentric alchemist reduced to barely breathing wreckage. Coughing blood and broken pieces of information. Dying despite their rescue.

"He told us about you," Thomas said quietly to Maria. "Used his last conscious moments to ensure we knew about the third key, knew where to find you." He paused. "He could have saved his strength. Tried to survive. Focused on his own life. But he chose to do his duty instead."

A beat. "That matters, Maria. His death wasn't meaningless."

"Doesn't make it hurt less," Maria said, her voice very young. "They bred my mother like livestock. Killed her when she refused to produce more children. And I'm supposed to be grateful they gave me this gift?"

Her hands clenched. "Some gift."

Margarethe stopped walking abruptly, her hand moving to her knife with reflexive speed. "Decision point. We can keep heading east toward Prague—three weeks of travel through increasingly dangerous territory, with winter coming and the Order hunting us. Or we can find somewhere to hide for the winter, wait for spring when travel is easier and pursuit might have cooled. What's our choice?"

Thomas looked at both his companions, uncertain. The weight of the decision felt crushing—lives depending on his choice, paths diverging.

Before he could speak, Maria stopped walking. Her eyes cleared from the distant unfocus of blood memory, becoming sharp and present and entirely her own.

"We keep going," she said, her young voice carrying unexpected steel. "East to Prague. No hiding. No waiting for spring."

Thomas blinked, surprised by her certainty.

"My whole life," Maria continued, "every choice was made for me. Who my mother married. What bloodline I'd carry. What purpose I'd serve. Even my birth was calculated—timed to align with Order breeding schedules I never consented to. And when Johannes died, when you found me in Mainz, I could have run. Hidden. Tried to disappear into some village where the Order might not find me."

She met Thomas's eyes, then Margarethe's. "But I chose this. Chose to help you gather the keys. And I'm choosing now—not from blood memory or inherited duty, but because I want to. We don't stop. We don't hide. We finish what we started."

Thomas felt something shift—not quite relief, but recognition. Maria wasn't just a tool they were using, a key that walked and spoke. She was making her own choices, claiming agency the Order had tried to deny her.

"We keep going," he agreed, echoing her decision rather than making it himself. "Prague for the fourth key. Constantinople for the fifth. And we search for the sixth and seventh while we're traveling. We don't stop. Don't pause. Don't give the Order time to catch us or recapture us."

"That could take years," Margarethe pointed out with brutal practicality. "Years of traveling through plague country where a third of Europe is dying or dead. Through territories controlled by the Order or just warlords and bandits. Through winter cold that kills as surely as any Gray Robe's sword."

"We could," Thomas agreed. He stopped walking, turned to face both of them directly. The late afternoon sun painted everything in shades of gold and shadow, making the abandoned farmland look almost beautiful despite the decay. "Or we could run. Find somewhere remote—a mountain village or isolated monastery or forest deep enough that no one would find us. Hide with the two keys we have and the knowledge Maria carries. Live quiet lives, survive to old age, die peacefully in our beds having accomplished nothing except personal survival."

He met Margarethe's eyes first, then Maria's. "But I'm done running. Done letting other people die for this while I just try to stay alive. Hamo. Wilhelm. Your parents. Johannes. All of them died for fragments of this Protocol, for knowledge they believed was worth dying to preserve."

His voice grew stronger. "I won't let their deaths be meaningless. They died believing this mattered. I owe them the effort to find out if they were right."

Margarethe watched him closely, her expression revealing nothing—yet somehow reading everything. The tremor in his hands. The fear he was trying very hard to hide behind determination. But she also saw, he thought, that he meant it. That he'd made a choice and intended to follow through regardless of cost.

"You've really changed," she said finally. "The monk I met three weeks ago—that frightened scholar who'd never left the monastery, who thought copying manuscripts was the most dangerous thing he'd ever do—would have chosen survival without hesitation. Now you're talking about throwing yourself at a quest that will probably kill you. When did you become someone who makes decisions like that?"

"When we killed Brother Anselm," Thomas said quietly, remembering the weight of the leather-working tool in his hand, Margarethe's blade finding its mark. "That was the moment I stopped being someone who could just walk away. Murder changes you. Makes you responsible for consequences in ways you can never step back from. If I'm going to carry that sin, at least let it be for something more than just personal survival."

Maria spoke up quietly: “My mother tried to run. The Order killed her for it. My father asked questions. The Order found him. Running didn’t save them.” She met their eyes with the weight of forty generations. “Fighting back is the only rebellion available to people bred to be tools.”

Margarethe was quiet for a long moment, her hand resting on her knife hilt more from habit than perceived threat. The wind picked up again, carrying early evening cold. Finally she spoke:

“All right then. We’re doing this. Seeking instead of just surviving. Hunting all seven keys instead of running with the two we have and the one we’ve become.” She started walking again, her pace determined and steady. “Prague is three weeks away if we avoid main roads and move carefully. Perhaps four weeks with winter conditions and the need to stay ahead of pursuit. Longer if we encounter serious problems—which we will, because problems are inevitable when you’re fugitives carrying knowledge that multiple powerful organizations want to destroy or control or reclaim.”

“What kind of problems?” Maria asked with practical curiosity.

“Gray Robes hunting us—they’re probably three or four days behind, moving faster than we can because they travel openly on main roads and have horses. Order hunters trying to drag back what they bred—that’s you and Thomas; you’re both too valuable for them to simply write off as losses. Plague-ravaged villages where survivors might see strangers as plague-bearers to be driven away or killed on suspicion. Bandits and deserters exploiting the chaos. Nobles whose territories we’ll cross who might be network members or Order supporters or just paranoid enough to arrest anyone who can’t prove they belong. Winter cold that makes sleeping rough dangerous, that makes rivers harder to cross, that reduces available food and increases the chances of sickness.”

Margarethe listed threats with casual competence. “But we knew this would be hard when we started. At least now we’re making active choices rather than just reacting to what’s being done to us. That’s worth something, even if it gets us killed.”

She glanced at Thomas, and for just a moment her expression softened—something that might have been approval, might have been respect. “You surprised me today, monk. That speech about not letting their deaths be meaningless—I didn’t expect that from you.”

Thomas felt warmth rise in his face despite the November cold, the flush reaching places the weak autumn sun couldn’t touch. “I surprise myself sometimes.”

“Good.” Margarethe’s lips quirked in something almost like a smile—the first he’d seen that reached her eyes. “Keep doing that. Predictable people don’t survive long on quests like ours.”

Her hand brushed his as they walked—brief as a heartbeat, but deliberate enough that her calloused fingertips caught against his knuckles. The touch stayed with him longer than it should have, a small ember of warmth against the approaching night and the cold certainty of the road ahead.

Thomas felt the knot in his chest tighten into something harder. Not peace—that was too much to ask. But resolve. Direction. The difference between being a leaf blown by autumn wind and an arrow loosed toward a mark, even if the mark was far and the odds were bad.

They were no longer fugitives just trying to survive. They were seekers now.

It felt good. Terrifying, but good.

“Tell me about Prague,” Thomas said to Maria as they continued walking. “What do you know from your family’s memories?”

Maria's eyes went distant, accessing inherited memory. "The Jewish quarter in Prague—the scholar's library there holds the fourth key. The golem manuscript. Kabbalistic teachings hiding Genesis Protocol fragments within Hebrew text. The Order worked across religious boundaries—Christian monasteries, Islamic libraries, Jewish scholarship. Knowledge preservation mattered more than theology."

Thomas thought about the elegant simplicity of it. Hide knowledge of collapse inside mystical teachings Christians wouldn't study closely.

"What does the fourth fragment say?" he asked.

"Temporal patterns," Maria said, her voice distant. "The fourth key is called the Voice that Speaks because it reveals when things happen. Not just what collapses or how knowledge is preserved, but the timing. The centuries-long cycle of kingdoms failing. The certainty of it—how kingdoms grow mighty, then brittle, and fall in patterns you can learn to recognize. The warning signs that collapse is approaching: the poor crushed, the powerful grasping, roads and bridges failing, cities grown too tangled to endure a hard blow."

She focused again, meeting Thomas's eyes with disturbing intensity. "And it shows the corruption points. Two transformations that broke the Order's purpose. First, after Rome's fall in the fifth century—the shift from prevention to acceptance. The Order had failed to prevent collapse, so they decided perhaps it was inevitable. Then, in the eleventh century, a deeper corruption—the shift from acceptance to exploitation. If collapse was inevitable, the Order should actively control when it happened, choosing the timing to benefit chosen bloodlines positioned to survive and rebuild."

"So the corruption is documented in the Protocol itself?" Margarethe asked.

"Aye. That's what makes it potentially powerful. If we can access all seven fragments, we'll see not just what the Protocol originally said but where and how and when it was corrupted. A complete record of the Order's betrayal of its own founding principles. That's a blade, if we can figure out how to turn it against them."

They walked in silence for a while. The sun was getting lower, shadows lengthening across the abandoned farmland. They'd need to find shelter soon.

Margarethe pointed ahead to smoke rising from a village perhaps two miles distant. "We need supplies before we can continue to Prague. Food, warmer clothes if we can afford them, information about road conditions and Order activity in the region. Should we risk entering a village or bypass it and try to survive on foraging?"

Thomas thought about their remaining resources—limited money, even more limited food, clothes adequate for autumn but inadequate for deep winter. "We risk it. We can't walk to Prague and beyond eating only what we can forage. Winter is coming."

"Then we need a cover story that explains why three people are traveling together during plague times," Margarethe said. "A monk traveling with a woman and a young girl will raise questions."

Maria spoke up immediately: "Pilgrims. We're heading to Prague to seek healing at the shrine of Saint Vitus. I survived plague but was left weakened, and my mother"—she gestured to Margarethe—"is seeking miraculous healing since medicine failed. Brother Thomas is our religious guide, hired to ensure our spiritual safety during the dangerous journey."

"Good," Margarethe said with approval. "That's plausible. Desperate plague survivors make pilgrimages all the time. I'm a widow—recently bereaved, which is sadly common enough to be completely believable. You're my only surviving child. Thomas is earning modest payment for spiritual guidance. Simple story. Fits expectations. Easy to maintain."

Thomas nodded agreement. Simple lies worked better than complex ones.

They approached the village as afternoon transitioned toward evening, long shadows painting the landscape in dramatic contrasts.

Thomas felt the weight of their choice settling more firmly onto his shoulders.

They were committed now. No more running blindly. No more just reacting.

They were actively seeking all seven keys. Deliberately pursuing a quest that would probably kill them.

But at least they'd chosen it. At least they were dying—if they died—for something they'd decided mattered rather than something that had been decided for them by people dead for centuries.

It wasn't much agency. But it was more than most people bred as tools ever got.

And Thomas intended to make it count.

1347, Village of Sankt Peter, Eastern Road

Sankt Peter looked like every other plague-ravaged village—smaller, quieter, haunted by absence. Perhaps twenty survivors where a hundred had lived. Houses abandoned, fields half-harvested, a fresh mass grave at the eastern edge.

The hollow-eyed living moved like ghosts themselves. Children were notably absent.

A priest met them at the village entrance—young man, perhaps mid-twenties but looking forty from exhaustion and grief. His robes were stained and rumpled, his face unshaven, his eyes gone distant from too many last rites in too short a time.

"Pilgrims?" he asked in German accented with the local Alemannic dialect.

"Aye, Father," Thomas confirmed, falling easily into the religious role. "Heading to Prague. To the shrine of Saint Vitus. Seeking healing for the girl." He gestured to Maria, who looked genuinely exhausted and pale enough to seem convincingly ill. "She survived the plague but was left weakened. We're hoping the saint's intercession might restore her strength where medicine has failed."

The priest's eyes softened with sympathy that looked both genuine and bone-deep weary. "Many are making such journeys. Faith is all we have when medicine fails and death surrounds us like wolves circling a campfire." He made the sign of the cross with automatic precision. "I'm Father Andreas. Come—I can offer you shelter in the church tonight and a meal if our stores permit. Though I confess I'm no longer certain what God provides versus what we simply manage to scrape together through desperate effort while God watches silently."

The bitter theology in that last sentence spoke to deep crisis of faith. Thomas recognized the tone—he'd felt it himself.

They followed Father Andreas into the church—small stone building that probably predated the village itself. Plain wooden benches instead of ornate pews. Simple altar with a painted wooden crucifix showing more wear than artistry. The smell of incense couldn't quite cover the underlying odor of death—that sweet-sick scent of decay that clung to places where too many bodies had lingered too long.

"How bad was it here?" Margarethe asked gently.

Father Andreas slumped against the altar. “Two-thirds of the village dead in three weeks. I performed last rites until my voice gave out. Blessed mass graves because we couldn’t dig fast enough.” His voice dropped. “And I still don’t understand why God allowed this. Why the faithful died alongside sinners. It feels random. Arbitrary.”

Thomas had no answer. “We carry what faith we can,” he said finally.

Father Andreas nodded wearily. “Have there been strangers through here recently?” Margarethe asked, shifting to practical concerns. “We heard rumors that Gray Robes were active in this region.”

Father Andreas’s expression darkened with anger that cut through his exhaustion. “Aye. Three days ago. Four Gray Robes on horseback, moving with purpose. They were asking about travelers. Specifically asking about a monk traveling with a woman and possibly others. Said they were hunting heretics who’d stolen from a bishop.”

Thomas felt cold wash through him despite the church’s relative warmth. The Order was hunting them. Had their descriptions. Was questioning every village along the eastern roads. And they were only three days behind.

“Did you tell them anything?” he asked, trying to keep his voice casually curious.

Father Andreas met Thomas’s eyes with surprising directness, intelligence showing through his grief-exhaustion. “I told them we’d seen many travelers but no one matching that specific description. I explained that the plague has driven hundreds of pilgrims through this region, that distinguishing one monk and woman from another would be impossible.”

He stood straighter, anger giving him temporary strength. “I don’t trust the Order anymore. They’ve become cruel during these plague times. They see heresy everywhere, use the chaos as excuse to persecute anyone who doesn’t conform. Last month they burned an entire family in the next village for what they called ‘heresy.’ The family’s only crime was speaking German instead of Latin during prayers because they couldn’t afford Latin schooling. Five people burned alive for linguistic poverty disguised as religious error.”

Father Andreas’s voice filled with rare certainty. “The Order doesn’t represent God’s mercy. They represent fear and control and the particular cruelty that comes from men who are convinced they’re doing righteousness while committing atrocity. So even if I had seen a monk traveling with a woman, I wouldn’t have told them. Whoever they’re hunting probably deserves protection more than persecution.”

Thomas’s shoulders dropped, the tension draining from muscles he hadn’t realized were locked tight. “Thank you, Father Andreas. That… that means more than you know.”

“Don’t thank me yet. The Order is systematic and patient. They’ll question every village along every eastern road. Eventually they’ll find someone who saw you clearly. Three days behind becomes two days becomes one day becomes…” He didn’t need to finish the sentence.

Margarethe asked the crucial question: “How far to Prague from here? And what route would you recommend for travelers who need to avoid… official attention?”

Father Andreas pulled out a rough map sketched on parchment. “Three weeks on foot if you take the main roads and don’t encounter serious problems. Four to five weeks if you avoid main roads and move carefully through forests and back paths.”

He traced routes with his finger. “The main eastern road goes through Regensburg—large city, well-defended, plenty of resources. But also well-watched. If the Order is looking for you specifically, they’ll have men there checking pilgrims and refugees.”

"Alternative routes?" Margarethe asked.

"North route goes through smaller villages but crosses territories controlled by nobility who actively support the Order. Dangerous if you're trying to avoid official notice."

Father Andreas traced a different path. "South route is longer—adds perhaps a week to your journey—but passes through lands where local lords are too busy dealing with plague and peasant revolts to care much about religious fugitives. Forests along the Danube, then north through Bohemia toward Prague. Harder travel, more time, less comfortable conditions. But also less likely to encounter organized pursuit."

"That's the route we'll take," Margarethe decided immediately. "Thank you, Father. This information is invaluable."

"Then stay tonight. Rest. Eat what little we can provide. Leave before dawn while it's still dark, before anyone in the village can get a clear enough look at you to provide detailed descriptions if the Order returns." Father Andreas pressed a small bundle into Margarethe's hands—bread, cheese, dried meat wrapped in cloth. "Not much, but enough to get you to the next village. And I'll pray for your safety, though I'm no longer certain my prayers reach anyone who cares to listen."

That night they slept in the church, taking turns on watch even though Father Andreas had offered that they were safe. Thomas couldn't fully relax, kept expecting Gray Robes to burst through the doors. But the night passed quietly except for the ambient sounds of a plague-ravaged village—occasional coughs from the sick, crying from those who'd lost family.

In the morning, before dawn, Father Andreas provided them with the promised supplies and one more piece of advice:

"One more thing," he said as they prepared to leave, his voice dropping to a whisper despite no one else being present. "There are rumors. Probably nothing, conspiracy thinking born from desperation to explain the unexplainable. But people are saying the plague isn't entirely natural. That it was sent deliberately or at least allowed to spread by those who benefit when kingdoms fall. That there are organizations—secret societies older than crowns—who set such calamities loose for their own purposes."

He met Thomas's eyes with uncomfortable penetration. "I dismissed it as the kind of fantasy people create when reality is too horrible to accept without explanation. But you—you're running from something. The Order hunts you specifically. You carry yourselves like people who know dangerous secrets. And that girl looks at the world like someone much older than fourteen, like she sees patterns others miss."

Father Andreas's voice grew even quieter. "Is there truth to the rumors? Is the plague more than just God's judgment or natural disaster?"

Thomas thought about lying, about protecting Father Andreas from knowledge that might get him killed. But this priest had helped them, had lied to the Order to protect them, deserved some measure of truth.

"I don't know if this specific plague was deliberately set loose," he said carefully. "But I know there are organizations that understand patterns of how civilizations collapse. That have knowledge of how to guide—or steer—such falls to serve their purposes. Whether they caused this plague or simply allowed it to happen or are just taking advantage of it… I'm still learning. Still gathering pieces of a puzzle that's been assembled over centuries."

Father Andreas nodded slowly, resignation rather than surprise on his exhausted face. "Then may God guide your quest. And may whatever you learn help prevent future catastrophes rather than enabling them. The world has enough suffering without human hands deliberately adding more."

They left Sankt Peter as dawn broke, following the southern route Father Andreas had recommended. Through forests slowly shedding their last autumn leaves. Along the Danube's northern banks where the river ran cold and gray under November skies.

And behind them, three days back but closing the distance with systematic persistence, Gray Robes followed their trail.

The lead hunter was Inquisitor Christoph of Cologne—veteran heretic hunter, absolutely convinced of the Order's divine mandate.

He'd been tracking them since Mainz, methodically following the trail Thomas had left through clumsy early flight: witnesses who remembered a frightened monk, a warrior woman, a young girl. Inn-keepers who'd seen their faces. Merchants who'd sold them food. Each small carelessness adding to a pattern Christoph read with practiced ease.

Three days behind now. But gaining ground with every careful mile.

On the evening of their fourth day from Sankt Peter, Margarethe spotted the campfire smoke.

"Half a mile back," she said quietly, returning from her scouting circuit. "Six men. Gray cloaks. Armed. Making camp for the night."

Thomas's stomach tightened. "The Order."

"Most likely." Margarethe was already packing their meager supplies. "We move now. Put more distance between us while they sleep."

They traveled through the night—a march through darkness broken only by occasional moonlight through bare branches. Maria stumbled with fatigue. Thomas's feet screamed protest. But they kept moving, because stopping meant capture.

At dawn, Margarethe scouted again. "Still there. But no closer. We gained maybe an hour."

"It's not enough," Thomas said. "They'll catch us before Prague if we can't move faster."

"Then we split up," Margarethe suggested. "Make them choose which trail to follow."

"No." Maria's voice was firm. "We stay together. Three of us have a chance. Alone, we're just targets."

They pushed on.

The quest had truly begun. The choice had been made. The path forward was set.

Now they just had to survive long enough to complete it.

With Inquisitor Christoph closing in behind them—patient, methodical, absolutely convinced that heretics deserved no quarter—survival was becoming increasingly uncertain.

1347, Bohemian Forest, Three Days From Prague

Marcus the Physician found them on a gray afternoon when frost painted the bare trees silver and the cold bit through even Margarethe's practical traveling clothes.

Thomas was gathering firewood, his hands numb despite gloves, when he heard footsteps behind him—too quiet to be Margarethe's purposeful stride, too careful to be Maria's youthful carelessness.

He spun, hand reaching for the knife he'd started carrying, his heart hammering with immediate terror.

A man stood ten feet away. Middle-aged, scholar's robes of good quality but not ostentatious wealth, observant gaze fixed on Thomas with analytical focus. Hands raised, showing he carried no visible weapon.

"Thomas of Eltville," the man said calmly. "Wilhelm's grandson. Carrier of the Iron Key. I've been looking for you."

Thomas kept his knife raised despite trembling hands. "Who are you and how did you find us?"

"Someone who knew your grandfather. Worked with him. Shared his belief that the Order has strayed catastrophically from its original purpose." The man took one slow step forward, movements deliberately non-threatening. "My name is Marcus the Physician. I serve the Order—or served it, before I understood fully what it had become."

"Stay back," Thomas warned, hearing Margarethe approaching silently through the forest behind him.

"I'm not here to capture you or return you to Order control," Marcus said patiently. "I'm here to help. To give you information that might save your life. And to ask for your help in return."

Margarethe appeared with crossbow raised and aimed at Marcus's chest. "Speak quickly and convincingly."

Marcus smiled slightly. "I believe you. You're Heinrich's daughter. The living library trained by your father before the Order tortured and killed him in what everyone thought was standard heretic prosecution but was actually the Order silencing someone who asked too many questions."

Margarethe's expression didn't change, but Thomas saw her finger tighten slightly on the crossbow trigger. "You know things you shouldn't."

"I know many things the Order wishes I didn't. Including how to find you—reports from sympathetic men in villages you've passed through, watchers who track bloodlines, and the pattern that says you're heading to Prague for the fourth key."

"So the Order knows where we're going," Thomas said, feeling dread settle into his stomach.

"The Order suspects. But they haven't yet set the full hunt on you—you're still something they want to reclaim quietly. That will change when you reach Prague. When you attempt to access the fourth key. Then they'll intervene directly."

Marcus lowered his hands slowly. "Which is why I'm here. To warn you. And to give you information Wilhelm died before he could pass to you."

He pulled out a scroll sealed with wax bearing cipher marks worked into decorative patterns. "This is everything Wilhelm discovered about the sixth key—the Heart that Feels. Its location, access methods, countersigns. He spent twenty years researching it, died before he could retrieve it himself. I memorized his findings before his journals were destroyed."

Thomas felt suspicious hope warring with trained paranoia. "Why help us?"

"Hope," Marcus said simply. "Hope that someone will finally understand the complete Protocol. Will see both what it originally said and what the Order corrupted it into. Will expose that corruption publicly enough that Order members who still believe in the original purpose will rebel."

He held out the scroll. "I'm old, Thomas. Tired. I've spent my life serving something I thought was noble, only to slowly realize it had become evil without me noticing exactly when the transformation happened. I don't have courage to rebel openly—they'd kill me and my family. But I can help you. Give you tools to complete what I'm too frightened to attempt myself."

Thomas took the scroll cautiously, examined the seal, opened it carefully. Read cipher marks and location details written in handwriting he recognized from Wilhelm's manuscripts.

"This looks genuine."

"It is. Wilhelm trusted me with his notes. I'm trying to honor that trust by helping his grandson complete what he started." Marcus stood, prepared to leave. "But I need to warn you—the Order is watching Prague. They'll be watching for anyone attempting to access the scholar's library. Be careful. Be clever. Get the key and leave before they can move to stop you."

"Why are you helping if it puts you at risk?" Margarethe asked, crossbow still aimed but finger relaxing slightly.

"Because doing nothing puts me more at risk," Marcus said quietly. "Risk to my conscience. Risk of dying knowing I served evil when I could have chosen differently. This is my small refusal. Perhaps it matters. Perhaps it doesn't. But at least I tried."

He turned to leave, then paused. "One more thing. The seventh key—the Mind that Knows—is in Constantinople with the fifth key. Both hidden in the Great Library's surviving sections. If you can reach Constantinople, you can potentially get two keys in one journey."

Then Marcus walked into the forest and disappeared between frost-silvered trees.

Thomas stood holding the scroll, uncertain whether to trust it.

"Trap?" Margarethe asked.

"Perhaps. Or genuine help from someone who still remembers what the Order was supposed to be." Thomas secured the scroll carefully in his pack. "Either way, we were already going to Prague. This just gives us information about what comes after. And the warning about the Order's eyes is probably accurate regardless of Marcus's true intentions."

Maria emerged from camp, having heard most of the conversation. "He was telling the truth. I could sense it—blood memory teaches you how to read people, how to hear the lie in a voice. He genuinely believes he's helping, genuinely regrets what the Order has become."

"Then we stay careful," Thomas decided. "Three days to Prague. We access the fourth key, learn what it reveals, and decide next steps. Constantinople for two more keys. England for the sixth. We keep moving forward because stopping means capture or death."

They broke camp and continued east with even greater caution.

The quest was accelerating. The Order was stirring. Time was running out.

1347, Prague, The Jewish Quarter, Three Days Later

Prague was magnificent and terrifying in equal measure—sprawling across both banks of the Vltava River under gray November sky, church spires and castle towers rising like stone prayers.

The Jewish quarter occupied a walled area near the river, physically and culturally separated from the Christian majority. Guards at the gates examined their forged pilgrim papers with suspicious thoroughness that plague times had intensified.

After tense questioning and small bribes, they entered the Jewish quarter just as the afternoon sun angled toward evening.

The quarter felt like a different world—buildings pressed close together, streets narrow and winding, languages mixing in ways Thomas had never heard. The residents watched them with wariness.

Maria guided them through the maze of streets with blood memory's confidence, leading them to a modest building marked with a nearly invisible symbol worked into the stonework—a hand holding seven keys.

She knocked in a specific pattern. Three quick, two slow, three quick.

The door opened, revealing an old man with a long white beard and penetrating dark eyes that seemed to see through their pilgrim disguise immediately.

"The three from the west," he said in German. "Monk, warrior woman, and blood memory carrier. We've been expecting you. I'm Rabbi Ezra. Come inside quickly. The Order is watching."

He led them down hidden stairs to a library that took Thomas's breath away—thousands of manuscripts carefully preserved, knowledge from across the known world.

"The golem manuscript," Rabbi Ezra said, pulling out an ancient text with reverence. "Kabbalistic teachings on creating life from clay. But also a container for the fourth fragment of the Genesis Protocol. Your keys will reveal what's hidden within the mystical text."

Thomas and Maria worked together, placing both metal keys on the manuscript in precise alignment. Maria touched the page, activating blood memory.

She gasped.

"I can see it," she whispered. "The fourth fragment. Temporal patterns—why civilizations collapse in recurring waves. How kingdoms grow mighty, then brittle. How ties between cities spread ruin faster."

She traced invisible patterns. "And the corruption points. Fifth century—the shift from prevention to acceptance after Rome's fall. Then eleventh century—the shift to actively controlling collapse. Two betrayals documented in the Protocol itself."

They spent an hour copying information, Maria committing crucial details to blood memory for preservation even if physical notes were lost.

Finally, Rabbi Ezra provided them with letters of introduction to network sympathizers along routes to Constantinople.

"Thank you," Thomas said. "This is dangerous for you."

"My family has protected this library for nineteen generations," Rabbi Ezra said. "Waiting for someone who would use the knowledge correctly rather than turn it into a weapon for control. You're trying to understand, not control. That makes you worth helping, even at risk."

They left the Jewish quarter as dusk fell, carrying the fourth fragment's knowledge.

CHAPTER 7 - THE HUNTER

1347, Eastern Road, Four Weeks East of Prague

December cold bit through every gap. Three weeks since Prague with the fourth key's knowledge. Margarethe walked ahead, favoring her Cologne wound. Maria followed, fourteen and struggling.

"How much farther?" Maria asked.

"Constantinople is still eight weeks away," Margarethe said. "Twelve if we're realistic about winter."

"The Great Library's hidden chambers hold the fifth and seventh keys," Maria said, accessing blood memory. "Underground sections the Order preserved when the Fourth Crusade burned the visible library. Heavily guarded."

"Do you have contacts there?" Thomas asked.

"Countersigns and locations. Whether those people are still alive after plague…" Maria shrugged. "Unknown."

"Then we adapt," Margarethe said. "We've managed this far."

Something in Thomas steadied—not quite confidence, but purpose. Direction. The sense that they weren't just running blindly but moving toward something meaningful.

They were three people against a nine-hundred-year conspiracy. Three fugitives carrying stolen keys and forbidden knowledge. Three tools bred by others choosing to rebel anyway.

The odds were terrible. The likelihood of success was minimal.

So they walked on.

Because stopping meant being taken.

That night they camped in a half-collapsed barn that still had enough roof to keep out the worst of the December snow. Maria fell asleep almost immediately, exhausted from accessing blood memory throughout the day's march.

Thomas kept watch, though his eyes kept drifting closed despite his best efforts. A hand on his shoulder made him jolt awake.

"Sleep," Margarethe said quietly. "I'll take watch."

"You've been walking all day too—"

"I've slept in worse conditions. And you kept nodding off." She settled beside him with her back against the barn wall, crossbow within easy reach. "Besides, I wanted to tell you something."

Thomas waited, heart inexplicably quickening.

"You've gotten stronger," Margarethe said quietly. "Not just physically. The fear hasn't gone away, but you push through it now instead of letting it stop you."

"I learned from watching you," Thomas admitted.

"No. That's you. I've seen men try to force courage through pride or anger. It never lasts. You've found something else. Something that holds."

She was close enough that he could feel her warmth despite the December cold. Her shoulder pressed against his—solid, real, grounding him.

When Thomas let his eyes close, her presence made the dangerous world feel slightly less impossible.

But sleep brought dreams.

Thomas saw Brother Hamo bleeding in the scriptorium. Wilhelm poisoned, dying slowly. Johannes captured. The Gray Robes closing in. And in the dream, he was running—always running—but his feet wouldn't move fast enough. The monastery walls closed in. The torture chamber's walls pressed closer. He tried to scream but couldn't draw breath.

He woke with a gasp, heart hammering, Margarethe's hand gentle on his shoulder.

"Nightmare?" she asked quietly.

Thomas nodded, not trusting his voice. The fear was still there—would always be.

"I'm terrified," he admitted in a whisper. "Every day. I've just learned to keep walking anyway."

Margarethe's hand squeezed his shoulder. "That's what courage is. Not the absence of fear—doing what needs to be done despite it. Sleep. You're safe for a few more hours at least."

And somehow, that promise—limited as it was—helped him find rest again.

1347, Four Weeks East of Prague, Deep Winter

The sickness took Maria on a gray afternoon when they were three days from a village that Marcus's scroll indicated should have network contacts willing to help. The air tasted of iron and approaching snow, heavy and oppressive.

She'd been coughing for two days—they all had, the harsh dry cough that came from breathing cold air and sleeping in insufficient shelter. But Maria's cough developed a wet quality that made Thomas's medical instincts scream warnings. Then she started running a fever despite the cold.

By evening, she was barely walking. By the time they made camp in a half-collapsed barn, she was shaking with fever-chills and coughing up blood.

"Plague?" Margarethe asked quietly while Maria slept fitfully.

"Perhaps," Thomas said, pressing a hand to Maria's burning forehead. "Or pneumonia from exposure and exhaustion. Or some other illness that's killing her just as effectively."

He'd been trained in monastery medicine—the basic herbalism and prayer-based healing that medieval monks practiced. Enough to know that fever this high in winter conditions usually meant death. Enough to know that coughing blood was a terrible sign.

"What can we do?" Margarethe asked, and Thomas heard the grief already in her voice.

"Keep her warm," Thomas said helplessly. "Give her water when she's conscious enough to drink. Pray, if you believe it helps. And prepare for the likelihood that she dies in the next day or two."

But Maria didn't die that night. Or the next day. She burned with fever, coughed blood, sometimes became delirious and spoke in languages Thomas didn't recognize. But she kept breathing through sheer stubborn will.

On the third night, the fever broke.

Thomas woke to find Maria sitting up, pale and weak but conscious and clear-eyed.

"I saw something," she said hoarsely, her voice barely above a whisper. "During the fever. Accessed blood memory deeper than I've ever gone before. Saw things from before the Order was founded. Saw the original conspiracy's actual beginning."

"Save your strength," Thomas said, offering water that she drank gratefully.

"No," Maria insisted with surprising force. "I need to tell you now while the memory is fresh. Before my conscious mind starts editing what I saw."

Margarethe had woken at the commotion, moved closer. "What did you see?"

Maria took another sip of water. "The Order is older than we thought. Bronze Age collapse—1200 BCE. Founded by survivors trying to understand the pattern. But Rome's fall broke them. The shift from prevention to acceptance—collapse was inevitable. Centuries later, deeper corruption—if inevitable, actively steer it to benefit chosen bloodlines."

Her expression grew troubled. "I also saw what happens when all seven keys are used together. Complete understanding of whether the Order causes the collapses they claim to prevent. Whether their meddling creates the instability they track."

Thomas felt ice settle into his stomach. "They're causing it?"

"Maybe. The vision was fragmented. That's why we need all seven keys—to know if they're evil or just deluded."

They sat in silence in the cold barn.

"Constantinople," Thomas said finally. "We still need the fifth and seventh keys. Whether the Order is evil or deluded, we need complete understanding to have any chance of stopping them. When you're strong enough to travel—"

"Three days," Maria interrupted, her voice hoarse but firm. "The fever broke, but pushing now risks relapse. My blood memory includes healers from forty generations. I know my limits. If we leave tomorrow, I'll collapse within a week. Give me three days, and I can maintain pace."

She met his eyes with unexpected steel. "It's tactical sense, not martyrdom."

Margarethe looked impressed. "Practical."

"Three days," Thomas agreed.

They spent three days in the half-collapsed barn. Thomas foraged for food and firewood. Margarethe maintained watch and repaired equipment. Maria slept and slowly recovered.

On the second evening, Thomas returned from foraging to find Margarethe stitching a tear in his cloak.

"You don't have to do that," he said, surprised.

"It'll be colder further east." She didn't look up. "Can't have you freezing."

Thomas sat beside her, watching her careful stitches. "You've been taking care of me since Mainz."

"Someone has to." But her lips quirked. "You're getting better, though. This morning you moved through that forest without sounding like a herd of cattle."

"High praise from you."

She tied off the thread, looked at him directly. "You're not the fumbling scholar I met anymore. You're someone I trust to have my back. That's not something I give lightly."

She handed him the mended cloak, their fingers touching briefly before she pulled away to sharpen her knives.

Thomas saw the faint color in her cheeks, understood: Margarethe showed care through actions, not words.

On the morning of the fourth day, they continued east.

Maria walked on her own power now, though clearly still weak. The fever had passed but left her thinner and more fragile-looking.

But she'd also accessed memories deeper than anyone had reached before. Had seen the Order's true age and founding purpose. Had glimpsed what might happen when all seven keys came together.

The quest had become more urgent. More complex. More uncertain.

1347, Constantinople, February 1348

Constantinople.

After months in smaller cities, the scale of it hit Thomas like a physical force. Massive walls, church domes, palace towers rising against cold February sky. Salt air and spices mixing with the usual medieval stink.

But everywhere, visible plague damage. Abandoned neighborhoods. Mass graves in public squares. Hollow-eyed survivors moving with wariness.

"How do we find Helena?" Margarethe asked as they entered through the main gates, showing forged travel documents.

"Marcus said she runs a boarding house near the Augustaion," Thomas recalled. "The great square with old Roman statues. We find that landmark first."

Finding the Augustaion proved straightforward—the massive column and plaza were visible from multiple approach angles. Finding Helena's boarding house required another hour of wandering, asking merchants in Thomas's limited Greek until someone pointed them to a three-story building with a sign showing a ship and anchor.

As they approached the boarding house, Margarethe suddenly grabbed Thomas's arm, pulled him and Maria into a narrow alley between buildings.

"What—" Thomas started.

"Gray Robes," Margarethe breathed, barely audible. "Three of them. Just entered the square from the eastern gate."

Thomas's heart hammered. They'd maintained distance since Prague, kept ahead through careful route selection and forced marches. How had the Order caught up?

He risked a glance around the corner. Three men in gray cloaks, moving with disciplined purpose. And at their center—tall, lean, mid-forties with a face that showed both intelligence and absolute conviction—a man Thomas hadn't seen before but somehow knew was dangerous.

"The leader," Maria whispered, accessing blood memory. "Inquisitor Christoph of Cologne. My ancestors' memories include warnings about him. Twenty years of hunting heretics. Never gives up. Never shows mercy. Believes God personally commands him to purge corruption from the church."

"He's questioning merchants," Margarethe observed. "Showing something—descriptions? Probably asking if anyone's seen us."

They watched Christoph work the square with methodical efficiency. Merchant to merchant, showing papers, asking questions in fluent Greek. His companions fanned out, covering more ground, creating a search pattern that would eventually sweep past the boarding house.

"We can't stay here," Thomas said. "If they search buildings systematically—"

"We go now," Margarethe decided. "To Helena's. Get inside before they expand their search."

They moved quickly but not running—running attracted attention. Three travelers crossing the square toward a boarding house, nothing unusual, just pilgrims seeking shelter.

Behind them, Christoph turned to speak with another merchant. Forty yards away. Close enough that if he looked in their direction, if the merchant pointed, if any small chance betrayed them—

They reached the boarding house door. Margarethe knocked urgently.

The woman who answered looked to be in her fifties, with silver-streaked dark hair and a measuring look. She spoke Greek first, switched to Latin when Thomas responded, then finally settled on German.

"Pilgrims?" she asked skeptically.

"Seekers," Thomas said, using the countersign Marcus had provided. "Seven keys open seven doors but only truth opens minds."

Helena's expression shifted—not to welcome exactly, but to understanding mixed with resignation.

"Come inside quickly." Her voice dropped to barely above a whisper. "If you're using that phrase, you're either genuine network business or an elaborate Order trick. Either way, discussing it openly on the street is stupidity."

She led them into the boarding house—clean if sparse, showing signs of recent prosperity before plague reduced the traveler population. Up stairs to a private room on the third floor.

"Who sent you?" Helena asked once the door was secured.

"Marcus the Physician," Thomas said. "From the western side. He gave your name and the countersign."

"Marcus is still alive? I heard he'd died during plague." Helena's expression showed genuine pleasure. "That old fox. What does he want?"

"He wants us to access the hidden library chambers beneath the burned sections of the Great Library," Margarethe said bluntly. "We're seeking the fifth and seventh keys of the Genesis Protocol."

Helena's face went very still. "You're seeking the complete Protocol? Do you understand what you're asking? The Order guards those fragments more carefully than gold. Trying for them without proper leave means death if you're caught. And I could be killed just for helping you attempt it."

"We understand," Maria said quietly. "But we have the first four keys already. We've seen what they reveal—the temporal patterns, the Order's corruption from defensive purpose to offensive plotting. We need the complete Protocol to expose the full scope."

"You're Order fugitives," Helena said, understanding dawning. "Not sanctioned seekers. You're rebels gathering evidence to challenge the conspiracy itself."

"Aye," Thomas confirmed. "And Marcus believed you might help because you knew the Order's history before you joined. Because you believed the preserved founding purpose about helping all humanity rather than selecting survivors."

Helena was silent for a long moment. Finally she spoke:

"I joined forty years ago because my father believed in their stated mission—preserve knowledge, prevent collapse. He died believing that lie. I didn't learn about the Order's corruption until twenty years in. By then I had family, position. So I stayed, told myself I could reform from inside. Typical rationalizations." She met Thomas's eyes. "But I never stopped feeling guilty."

"Will you help us?" Margarethe asked directly.

"If I do, and you're caught, the Order will know I assisted. Will trace the access back to me. Will kill me and possibly my family." Helena's voice was steady despite discussing her own potential death. "But if I don't, and you somehow succeed without my help, I'll die knowing I had a chance to honor my father's actual values and chose cowardice instead."

She stood, moved to a locked chest, pulled out a key. "I'll help. But you need to understand the reality. The underground chambers are guarded. The Order doesn't trust a countersign alone—they verify bloodlines, demand seals and letters. You'll be walking into defended ground with stolen keys and no official leave."

"We've managed similar situations before," Margarethe said.

"In backwater cities with thin guards," Helena countered. "This is Constantinople—the Order's eastern seat. You three—a German monk, a warrior woman, and a sick-looking girl—will look suspicious the moment you approach the underground entrance."

"Then we need disguises," Thomas said. "Sealed papers if possible."

Helena thought for a moment. "I can provide Byzantine Order papers that might pass at first glance. Claim you're western scholars granted temporary leave. But the fifth and seventh keys are in the most restricted sections. Even with papers, you'll face more gates and guards."

"How long do we have once we access the chambers before the guards realize something is wrong?" Margarethe asked.

"Minutes," Helena said. "Perhaps fifteen or twenty if you're lucky. Less than five if they're on high alert. You'll need to find the keys, take whatever knowledge they hold, and get out before the response overwhelms you."

Maria spoke up: "I can access blood memory faster now. Since the fever, since reaching deeper than I ever have before, the process is quicker. If we can get me to the keys, I can read them in under ten minutes even for complex fragments."

"Then your plan is: Use papers to access the underground chambers, move quickly to the most restricted sections, locate the fifth and seventh keys, Maria reads them as fast as possible, you get out before the guards kill you." Helena's tone made it clear she thought this plan was barely better than suicide. "And if it works, you'll have six of seven keys and need to somehow survive fleeing Constantinople while the Order rouses to hunt you."

"We've fled hostile cities before," Thomas said.

"Not like this," Helena warned. "Constantinople isn't Cologne or Prague. If they decide to bar the gates and comb the city street by street, they will find you. Your only chance is getting out immediately after accessing the chambers—within hours."

"Can you arrange ship passage?" Margarethe asked practically.

Helena considered. "Perhaps. I have contacts among merchants who owe me favors. But moving you out in haste will cost hard coin and spend favors I've saved for decades."

"We can pay," Thomas said, though their funds were nearly exhausted.

"It's not about money," Helena said. "It's about risk. Every person I contact creates more connections that Order investigators can trace back to me if you're caught. I'm betting my life on you three fugitives somehow accomplishing what centuries of scattered opposition has failed to achieve."

"Others have bet on us before," Maria said quietly. "Marcus the Physician. Johannes the Alchemist. Brother Hamo. Wilhelm. Rabbi Ezra in Prague. All of them risked or sacrificed everything to help us. Not because our success is likely, but because it's possible. Because giving up means the Order's corruption continues unchallenged for another thousand years."

Helena looked at the fourteen-year-old girl with ancient eyes.

"My father would have helped you," she said finally. "Would have risked everything to support people fighting for the Order's original purpose. I won't dishonor his memory by being less brave than he would have been."

She pulled out more papers—seals, maps, names. "I'll arrange ship passage leaving two days from now. Merchant vessel heading to Italy, willing to take passengers who pay well and don't attract official attention. You have two days to access the underground chambers, read the keys, and get to the docks."

"Two days," Margarethe said, already planning.

"Or enough time to get discovered during reconnaissance and killed before you ever reach the keys," Helena countered. "But aye, two days is what you have. Use it wisely."

The underground entrance waited. They'd memorized guard rotations, prepared countersigns, studied the maps Helena had drawn from memory.

The day before the heist, Thomas walked Constantinople's streets with Margarethe, memorizing escape routes.

The city was unlike anything he'd seen—marble columns, mosaics, the great dome of Hagia Sophia dominating the skyline.

"It's beautiful," Thomas said.

"It's dying," Margarethe corrected. "Look closer."

Thomas saw gaps where monuments had been stripped. Abandoned neighborhoods. Byzantine empire crumbling at the edges.

"The Order has been preparing for this collapse," Maria said. "The way they prepared for Rome's fall."

"Preparing or engineering?" Thomas asked.

"Both," Maria said. "That's the horror."

"Tomorrow we go below," Margarethe said. "Take what they've guarded for centuries. Then run."

They weren't here to admire architecture. They were here to steal secrets from the depths.

But nothing could have prepared them for what they'd actually find in those depths.

CHAPTER 8 - THE CATACOMBS

1348, Constantinople

The underground entrance was exactly where Helena said it would be—a maintenance door in the rubble of the Great Library's burned sections, marked with a stone carving weathered to look like natural erosion unless you knew to recognize the cipher symbol for "knowledge preserved."

Thomas stood in pre-dawn darkness with Margarethe and Maria, carrying Byzantine papers Helena had forged. Their packs held the Iron and Silver Keys. Constantinople slept, pre-dawn quiet broken only by distant roosters.

"Remember," Thomas whispered. "We're western scholars with temporary leave. Helena's papers should get us past the first gate. But once we're in the restricted sections, guards will become suspicious quickly. Maria needs to read both keys in under ten minutes, then we leave."

"And if guards challenge us before we reach the keys?" Margarethe asked, her hand resting on the concealed knife she'd sharpened to razor edge.

"Talk first. Fight only if necessary." Thomas pulled out the countersign Helena had provided. "Our goal is knowledge, not combat."

Maria looked pale in the dim light, still weak from her illness weeks earlier. "I can read fast. Since the fever, the process is quicker. Get me to the keys and I'll extract everything in under ten minutes."

Thomas knocked on the weathered door in the specific pattern—three quick, two slow, one final.

Silence.

Then bolts sliding, locks disengaging. The door opened slowly, revealing a guard in Byzantine Order livery—disciplined, alert, hand resting casually near his weapon.

"Purpose?" the guard asked in Greek.

"Study," Thomas responded, holding up their forged papers. "Western scholars, granted leave by the Order. We seek knowledge preserved in the archives."

The guard examined their papers carefully. Thomas's heart hammered. Helena's forgeries were excellent, but any discrepancy could end this.

"Western scholars," the guard said slowly. "Few visitors lately. Plague has thinned the roads."

"Which makes our work urgent," Margarethe said in accented Greek. "Preserved knowledge matters more now."

The guard studied them, clearly suspicious but finding no fault.

"Proceed," he said at last, stepping aside. "But hear me—some shelves are closed without special leave. Do not set foot beyond doors marked with red cipher signs. Those places are warded, and the watch is quick to spill blood."

"Understood," Thomas said, moving past before he could reconsider.

They descended stairs cut from bedrock. Down into chambers that smelled of stone and preserved parchment.

The archives were vast—rooms extending in multiple directions, shelves holding thousands of manuscripts, scribes working at copying stations.

"The Order has been preserving knowledge for two thousand years," Thomas said quietly. "This is what defense looked like—before corruption."

They moved deeper, following Helena's map toward the restricted sections. Passed other scholars working quietly at manuscript tables. Passed guards stationed at regular intervals, watching everyone with hard-eyed vigilance.

The red cipher symbols appeared on doors deeper in—warning markers indicating restricted access.

"This is it," Margarethe said, consulting Helena's notes. "Fifth key in the chamber marked 'foot that walks.' Seventh key in 'mind that knows.' Both behind these doors."

"We need to slip past the guards," Thomas said, studying the doors and watchmen stationed nearby. "Distraction or countersigns?"

Maria's eyes cleared from blood memory, becoming sharp and tactical. "Distraction. And I know how."

She turned to Margarethe before Thomas could object. "You're the fighter. You need to create noise in the eastern archives—knock over shelves, make it look like an accident or break-in. Pull the guards away from these doors. Thomas and I access the restricted chambers while you keep them busy."

"That means you'll be caught," Thomas protested.

"Maybe." Margarethe's expression showed grudging respect for the plan even as she calculated the risk. "Or I escape in the chaos. Either way, it's the fastest path to the keys."

"No," Thomas started, but Maria cut him off.

"She's right, and you know it." Maria's voice carried the same steel she'd shown when choosing to continue the quest, when demanding her recovery time. "We don't have time for cautious. The Order will already have noticed our papers being used. Within an hour, maybe less, they'll know we're fugitives with forged documents. This is our only window."

She met Margarethe's eyes. "Can you do it?"

"I can make enough noise to wake Constantinople," Margarethe said. She turned to Thomas. "The quest matters more than individual survival. Get the keys. Understand the Protocol. That's what matters."

She disappeared toward the eastern archives before Thomas could argue further, moving with the practiced silence of someone who'd survived by knowing when to fight and when to vanish.

Thomas stared at Maria, shocked by her tactical decisiveness. This wasn't the frightened fourteen-year-old he'd found at the convent, or even the determined girl who'd declared her choice to continue the quest.

This was someone who'd learned to make strategic calculations, to weigh lives against mission, to accept necessary sacrifice with clear-eyed pragmatism.

"Blood memory includes forty generations of women who had to make hard choices to survive," Maria said quietly, meeting his eyes with unsettling composure. "I'm learning to make my own."

He grabbed Maria's hand, pulled her toward the restricted chamber marked with the "foot that walks" symbol. Used the Iron and Silver Keys to manipulate the door's lock mechanism—clever design that responded to specific key shapes and alignments.

The lock clicked open.

Behind them, the sound of crashing—Margarethe's distraction beginning. Shouts. Running footsteps. Warning bells ringing with harsh regularity.

Thomas and Maria slipped into the restricted chamber, found themselves in a smaller room lined with manuscript cases containing materials clearly older and more carefully preserved than anything in the general archives.

"The fifth key," Maria breathed, moving immediately toward a case marked with cipher symbols. "The Foot that Walks."

She placed her hands on the manuscript, activated blood memory with visible effort.

Her eyes went distant, unfocused, accessing inherited information from women who'd memorized this fragment across forty generations.

Thomas watched the door, listening for approaching guards.

Maria spoke in that strange dual-voice that came when blood memory dominated—partly her own consciousness, partly channeling ancestors:

"The fifth fragment shows movement. Migration patterns during Bronze Age collapse, Roman collapse, current medieval collapse. How people flee failing civilizations. Where they go. The Order tracked these patterns deliberately—positioned themselves along migration routes to intercept refugees carrying skills and information worth preserving."

Her voice grew troubled. "But also how they guided the migrations. Didn't just observe—they influenced. Created lures for skilled people to flee toward Order-held lands. Steered the movement of populations to serve the Order's purposes rather than letting disaster patterns determine who survived where."

"They were steering the refugees?" Thomas asked, horrified.

"Not causing the disasters that made refugees," Maria clarified. "But absolutely shaping where refugees went, who survived the migrations, what knowledge was preserved versus lost. The defensive purpose was: Help people survive and preserve their knowledge. The corrupted use became: Decide which people survive where to serve the Order's breeding designs."

Heavy footsteps approached outside. Multiple guards, moving with disciplined coordination.

"Can you access all of it?" Thomas asked urgently.

"Enough to document the corruption. The parts that prove intentional guidance rather than passive preservation—I have those now."

"Good. We need the seventh key."

They moved to the second restricted chamber, used the keys to bypass another sophisticated lock, found themselves in an even more protected room containing a single manuscript case.

The seventh key. The final joining.

Maria approached it like approaching something sacred or cursed—both reverence and fear visible in her expression.

"This is it," she whispered. "The Mind that Knows. The fragment that shows how all seven pieces connect, what they mean together."

She placed her hands on the manuscript, closed her eyes, activated the deepest blood memory Thomas had seen her access.

And gasped like she'd been struck.

"What?" Thomas demanded. "What does it show?"

"The truth," Maria said, tears streaming. "The Genesis Protocol was created to understand collapse, not prevent it. The Order tried to prevent Rome's fall anyway. Failed. That failure transformed them—made them believe collapse was inevitable, that they should control it rather than prevent it. The seventh fragment shows the corruption clearly: from learning the pattern to break it, to accepting it as inevitable and exploiting it."

Maria pulled her hands away from the manuscript, opened her eyes with visible effort. "I have it now—six of the seven fragments. Everything except the sixth key. The Genesis Protocol's shape is clear, and the documentation of corruption is undeniable."

The restricted chamber door burst open with a crash of wood against stone. Six Byzantine guards with drawn weapons, disciplined and efficient, surrounding them before they could reach the secondary exit. The smell of oil lamps and old parchment mixed with the sharp metallic scent of drawn steel.

"Fugitives with forged papers," the lead guard said grimly. "In restricted rooms without leave. You're under arrest for conspiracy against the preservation order."

Thomas reached for his knife—six trained guards against one exhausted monk and a fourteen-year-old girl. Hopeless.

Then Margarethe materialized behind the guards, crossbow leveled at the lead guard's spine. Her left shoulder screamed protest—the old wound making the weapon shake—but her aim held steady enough to kill at this range.

"Lower your weapons or your commander dies," she said in Greek. "I've killed men for less. I'll do it again without hesitation."

The guards froze, assessing whether she was bluffing.

She wasn't. Thomas could see it in her eyes—the cold calculation of someone who'd survived through willingness to do violence others hesitated over.

"Maria has the knowledge," Margarethe continued. "Six of the seven fragments accessed through blood memory. Killing us doesn't erase what she's learned. Let us leave, and maybe the Order survives the exposure. Force violence, and we'll make sure what we have reaches everyone who can use it against you."

"The Order survived two thousand years," the lead guard said. "It will survive three fugitives revealing fragments."

"Will it survive complete documentation of how you corrupted your founding purpose?" Margarethe challenged. "Will it survive current members learning that the transformation occurred because the Order failed to prevent Rome's collapse and decided controlling catastrophe was easier than preventing it?"

The guard hesitated, clearly weighing thoughts he'd never let himself think.

"We're leaving," Margarethe said firmly. "Through the service passages. You can report our escape. Can hunt us across Europe. But right now, you're letting us walk out because killing us accomplishes nothing except your commander bleeding out on these archive floors."

She gestured with the crossbow toward the secondary exit. "Move. Both of you. Now."

Thomas grabbed Maria's hand, pulled her toward the service passages Helena had described. Margarethe backed away from the guards, keeping her crossbow aimed.

They reached the tunnel entrance—narrow passage cutting through bedrock. Plunged into darkness. Behind them, guards organizing pursuit.

They ran through wet passages, emerged into one of Constantinople's massive cisterns—vaulted chambers supported by hundreds of columns.

"This way," Maria said, accessing blood memory. "Eastern cistern connects to the Augustaion."

They waded through water, following her inherited knowledge. Guards entered behind them with torches, but Constantinople's underground was vast—miles of tunnels the pursuers didn't know.

They climbed out through a surface grate near the Augustaion into morning light.

"Docks," Margarethe said, already moving. "Helena's ship leaves at noon. We have maybe thirty minutes."

They ran through Byzantine streets, three obvious foreigners moving with suspicious urgency.

The docks appeared ahead—forests of masts and sails, merchant vessels from across the Mediterranean.

Helena was waiting at the designated pier, standing next to a merchant galley flying Italian colors.

"You got them?" she asked urgently.

"Both keys accessed," Thomas confirmed. "Maria has six of the seven fragments—including the final joining and the documentation of corruption. Only the sixth key remains."

"Then get aboard before the Byzantine guards realize you're here," Helena said, gesturing toward the ship. "Captain has been paid to take you to Italy with no questions. You'll be in Venetian territory within a week."

"What about you?" Thomas asked. "The Order will know you helped us."

"I'll disappear into Constantinople's crowds. I've prepared for this for years. False names, hidden coin, roads out." Helena's expression was determined. "Don't worry about me—worry about using what you've learned to actually expose the corruption."

Thomas grabbed her in a brief embrace. "Thank you. You risked everything."

"My father would have done the same. Now go."

They boarded the merchant galley, the captain immediately ordering ropes cast off. The ship began moving away from the dock.

And then—shouting from the pier.

Thomas turned to see Gray Robes arriving at a run, pushing through dockworkers and merchants. Six men, weapons drawn, moving with trained coordination.

At their center: Inquisitor Christoph of Cologne.

He stopped at the pier's edge as the ship pulled away, twenty feet of water already between vessel and dock. For a long moment, Christoph simply watched them—his face showing neither anger nor frustration, just cold assessment.

Then he shouted across the water in Latin, voice cutting through harbor noise: "Thomas of Eltville! You cannot run forever! The Order's reach extends across Christendom!"

Thomas felt Margarethe tense, her hand moving toward her crossbow.

"Save the bolt," he said quietly.

Christoph continued: "You think you fight corruption? You serve chaos! I've hunted heretics for twenty years. I know how this ends. You'll keep running until exhaustion catches you. And when you fall, I will be there. Patient as stone."

The ship's sails caught wind.

"This quest will end in fire and rope!" Christoph's final shout carried across widening water. "And I will be holding the torch!"

He turned away, already organizing pursuit with methodical efficiency.

Thomas watched Constantinople recede. The Inquisitor's words echoed: *You cannot run forever.*

"He's right," Margarethe said. "Eventually he'll catch us. The Order has resources we can't match."

"Then we try for long enough," Maria said, her voice carrying steel. "Long enough to find the sixth key. Long enough to distribute the Protocol. Long enough to matter."

Thomas turned from Constantinople's receding skyline. They'd escaped again. Bought themselves time.

Time to finish what they'd started.

On the pier, Helena stood watching them leave, already starting to blend back into the crowd.

In the distance, Byzantine guards appeared, searching the docks. But the merchant galley was already moving into the Bosphorus current, heading toward open water.

Constantinople receded behind them—massive walls and church domes and the Great Library's ruins containing knowledge preserved across two millennia.

Thomas stood at the ship's stern, watching the city disappear. They had six of seven keys accessed through Maria's blood memory. Understood most of the Genesis Protocol, including the final joining that revealed how preservation had curdled into control.

But they still needed the sixth key in England. Still needed to figure out how to expose it in ways that would actually challenge the Order's power.

Maria joined him at the stern, exhausted but determined.

"I saw something else in the seventh fragment," she said quietly. "About the current collapse—this plague we're living through. The Order didn't make the Black Death come, but they knew it was coming years in

advance. Had predictions based on the collapse pattern. And they positioned themselves to benefit from it rather than prevent it."

"How long in advance?" Thomas asked.

"Thirty years," Maria said. "The Order's leadership saw the signs in the 1310s—failed harvests, strange weather, kingdoms splintering. They knew major collapse was coming within a generation. And they feared plague in particular. So they prepared: positioning chosen bloodlines, securing knowledge, arranging for their people to survive what they knew would kill a third of Europe."

Thomas's hands gripped the ship's rail. "They let it happen. Knew it was coming and did nothing to prevent or minimize it."

"Worse," Maria said. "They helped it spread faster than it would have on its own. Guided trade so plague reached the greatest cities. Whispered against closing gates or keeping the sick apart. Not because they loosed the plague itself, but because they recognized it as the collapse they'd been waiting for and wanted it to do its worst."

"That's mass slaughter by choice."

"That's what the Order has become," Maria confirmed. "They went from trying to prevent collapse, to accepting collapse as inevitable, to actively facilitating collapse whenever it appeared naturally because they'd positioned themselves to benefit from catastrophe they claimed was beyond their control."

The ship caught wind, sails filling, speed increasing as they moved from Bosphorus into the Sea of Marmara.

Margarethe joined them at the stern. For a moment, the three of them stood in silence, watching Constantinople disappear over the horizon.

Margarethe's hand brushed against Thomas's on the rail.

"Thank you," he said quietly. "For coming back for us."

"We're in this together," Margarethe said. "All three of us. To the end."

Her hand moved closer. Thomas let his fingers shift to meet hers—just a brief contact. But enough that his heart hammered.

Then the moment passed. Margarethe pulled back, scanning the horizon with her usual vigilance.

But Thomas had seen something shift in her expression. Somewhere between Cologne and Constantinople, they'd stopped being just allies.

They were becoming something more.

1348, Milan, Late March 1348

The safehouse contact was supposed to meet them at the church of Sant'Ambrogio at vespers. Helena's documents listed him as "Giacomo the Scribe"—network member, manuscript preservation specialist, noted as "morally conflicted."

Thomas watched from the shadows as evening gathered around the ancient basilica. The church was nearly empty—plague had reduced attendance at all but essential services. The few worshippers present prayed with desperate intensity.

Margarethe stood guard at the opposite entrance. Maria waited with Thomas, accessing blood memory for any information about this contact.

A man appeared at the south entrance—middle-aged, scholar's robes, carrying the described leather satchel. He glanced around with practiced wariness.

Thomas approached using the countersign Helena had provided: "Knowledge preserved serves all humanity."

The man's response should have been: "When preservation becomes control, humanity is betrayed."

Instead, he said: "I know who you are. And I know the Order is positioning to intercept you before you reach England."

Thomas's hand moved toward his knife. "You're not Giacomo."

"I am Giacomo," the man said quickly, holding up empty hands. "But I'm not here to trade countersigns. I'm here to warn you that the Order knows you're using Helena's contact network. They've identified several of her sympathizers. Some have been arrested. Others are being watched, waiting to see if you'll contact them so they can capture you."

"Why warn us?" Margarethe asked, materializing from the shadows. "If you're laying a trap, this is elaborate."

"I've spent thirty years preserving manuscripts for the Order," Giacomo said. "Believing we served humanity. Then Helena's letter showed me the truth—I've been complicit in mass slaughter disguised as preservation."

"So you're turning," Thomas said, studying him for deception.

"I already turned. Burned my ledgers. Warned families." Giacomo met Thomas's eyes. "But I came to warn you: The Order knows you're heading to York. They've set watchers. It's a trap."

"Alternative?" Thomas asked.

"Approach from the north through Scotland. Smaller ports, rural routes, outside the normal Order web. Weeks longer but safer."

He pulled out maps.

Thomas's suspicion warred with hope. Genuine help or elaborate trap?

"Why trust this?" Margarethe asked bluntly.

"You shouldn't. I'm Order-trained. This could all be theater."

He placed the maps on the floor, stepped back. "I'm giving you the information anyway. Your choice what to do with it."

Thomas studied Giacomo's face. Exhaustion and guilt.

"Maria," he said quietly. "Blood memory. Is he genuine?"

Maria accessed memory. "Those who are genuinely torn offer details you can test, admit uncertainty. He's showing those patterns. Consistent with genuine turning."

"Could be sophisticated deception," Margarethe cautioned.

"Everything could be trap," Thomas said. "But we've made it this far on calculated judgments."

He picked up the maps. “Thank you. We’ll use this.”

“One more thing,” Giacomo said. “Helena is alive. The Order arrested her in Constantinople but she escaped during transport to Avignon. She’s in hiding somewhere in the Balkans, continuing to organize those who’ve turned and distribute the Protocol. I thought you should know.”

Relief flooded through Thomas. Helena had risked everything to help them. Knowing she’d survived gave their escape meaning beyond just their own lives.

“Tell her we’re grateful,” he said. “If you have contact.”

“I’ll try,” Giacomo said. “But communication is fragmented now. Many of us are operating in isolation, doing what we can locally without shared plan. We’re more scattered groups than organized rebellion.”

“That’s how resistance survives,” Margarethe said with hard wisdom. “Scattered. Separate. No single head for the Order to cut off. Messier than organized rebellion but harder to destroy completely.”

They left the church separately, each taking different routes.

That night, studying Giacomo’s maps in a cold room they’d rented, Thomas made the decision.

“We trust it. The northern route through Scotland. It’s longer and harder but if the Order really is positioned in York, walking directly into that trap accomplishes nothing.”

“And if the northern route IS the trap?” Margarethe asked.

“Then we fight or die in Scottish wilderness instead of York monastery. I’m not sure that’s worse.” Thomas traced the route Giacomo had suggested. “But my instinct says Giacomo was genuine. The guilt in his voice wasn’t performance.”

Maria nodded agreement. “My blood memory says the same. Giacomo was the conflicted type—serving for decades while questioning, finally choosing to act on the questions. That’s real, not performance.”

“Then Scotland it is,” Margarethe said, already marking the route and calculating travel times. “Six weeks if weather cooperates. Eight weeks more likely given spring storms and rough terrain. But alive at the end instead of captured in York.”

They rested briefly in Milan, then continued northwest toward the French coast, following Giacomo’s route suggestions.

Behind them, if Giacomo was truthful, Order hunters waited in York for fugitives who would never arrive.

Ahead, Scottish highlands and rough northern approach that might save their lives or might be elaborate trap.

But they kept moving forward anyway.

Because calculated risks were all they had.

1348, Scottish Coast, Late April 1348

Scotland was brutal—rugged coastline, green hills rising into mist, harsh landscape clinging with stubborn determination.

Six weeks of brutal travel. Cold ships, rough paths, suspicious villages. The penetrating cold got into bones and stayed there.

“How much farther?” Maria asked, teeth chattering.

"Three weeks through the Highlands to York," Margarethe said, consulting Giacomo's maps. "Rough terrain. But not where the Order expects us."

They'd hired a Highland guide named Callum who led them through barely visible paths across endless moorland.

"York," Callum said in thick accent. "Dangerous now. Plague. Raiders. I guide to the border, then you're on your own."

They traveled through landscape designed to break will. Endless hills, sudden storms, swollen rivers. Food was scarce.

On the fifth night into the Highlands, huddled in a stone shieling that offered minimal shelter, Thomas watched Maria shiver despite being wrapped in both available cloaks.

"She's not going to survive this," Margarethe said quietly, checking Maria's temperature with a hand to her forehead. "The fever from before weakened her. This cold and exposure is breaking her down again."

"We can't stop," Maria said through chattering teeth. "If we stop, we fail. If we fail, everything—Johannes, Wilhelm, your parents, Helena, Giacomo, everyone who helped us—it's all for nothing."

"You'll be dead for nothing if we push too hard," Margarethe said bluntly. "Tomorrow we rest. Find a village, pay for indoor shelter, let you recover strength before continuing."

"The Order—"

"Won't find us in the middle of the Scottish Highlands," Thomas interrupted gently. "Margarethe's right. We rest tomorrow. Build your strength back. Then we continue to York when you can actually survive the journey."

Maria looked like she wanted to argue but another violent shiver stopped her.

That night, Thomas took first watch. One key left. Then they'd have everything—complete documentation of the Order's corruption.

The question that kept him awake: what would they do with it once they had it?

Margarethe emerged, wrapped in a blanket, and sat beside him in silence.

"You're thinking too much," she said finally.

"We're almost there. One key left. Then we have to figure out how to actually use what we've learned."

"Maybe there is no pattern," Margarethe said. "Maybe we just do what seems right in each moment. Expose the corruption wherever we can. Plant seeds for future generations."

"That's not very satisfying."

"Most worthwhile things aren't." Margarethe pulled the blanket tighter. "We've already accomplished more than anyone expected. That matters even if we don't live to see the Order fall."

"I'm glad you're here," he said quietly. "Wouldn't have survived past Cologne without you."

"I'm glad I'm here too. Glad I chose to act instead of just surviving." Her voice grew quieter. "My father taught me that survival for its own sake is just slow death. You need purpose to actually be alive."

Her hand found his under the blanket—intentional this time.

"This is purpose," she said. "This quest. This fight. This matters in ways simple survival never could."

They sat like that for a while, hands clasped, watching mist roll across the Highlands.

Some things didn't need words yet.

Eventually Margarethe's watch shift arrived. She squeezed his hand once more before letting go, disappearing into the darkness to patrol the perimeter with her usual vigilance.

Thomas returned to the shieling, lay down near Maria's sleeping form, and tried to rest despite his mind spinning with thoughts about patterns and purposes and a hand holding his in the Scottish darkness.

Some things just needed to exist quietly until the time came to name them.

CHAPTER 9 - THE SIXTH KEY

1348, York

They reached York on a gray morning—stone walls rising from mud, rain washing the medieval stench cleaner. England looked greener than the continent, less obviously ravaged by plague. But Thomas knew the appearance deceived. The Black Death was spreading through ports and cities. The Order had known it was coming, positioned themselves to benefit.

That knowledge burned.

Somewhere within York's ancient walls, hidden in a monastery's restricted library, the sixth key waited.

The Heart that Feels—the record of the human cost of the Order's breeding programs.

"The key is in the Minster's library," Thomas said. "St. Peter's Cathedral. Restricted section accessible only to senior clergy. We'll go in as scholars seeking religious texts."

"Or just steal it," Margarethe suggested. "Break in at night, find the key, Maria reads it, we slip out."

"That worked in Constantinople because Helena helped from inside. We don't have network contacts here. We don't know the library's plan or guards. Going in blind risks capture more than a careful approach."

Maria had been quiet since entering England. Now she spoke:

"The sixth key is different. The others contain practical knowledge—locations, routes, timing. But the sixth records individual stories. Families broken by breeding programs. Children raised as experiments. The human cost written in tears rather than ledgers."

"Why record that?" Margarethe asked.

"Because the founders wanted future generations to understand what bloodline breeding actually costs. Warning that those future generations ignored."

"St. Peter's Minster is in the city center," Thomas said, navigating by visible landmarks. "We approach as pilgrims, request library access for prayer and study. If that fails, we consider more direct methods."

The cathedral dominated York's skyline—massive Gothic structure still under construction in some sections but already magnificent. They approached as afternoon transitioned toward evening, three travel-worn pilgrims seeking shelter.

A monk met them at the entrance—elderly man with kind eyes and patient manner.

"Welcome, travelers," he said in English. "I'm Brother Edmund. You seek shelter or prayer or both?"

"Both, Brother," Thomas responded in the same language, grateful for months of travel that had given him rudimentary English. "We're scholars seeking library access. We study cipher marks hidden in manuscript ornament."

Brother Edmund's expression shifted—not suspicion exactly, but heightened interest. "Cipher systems? That's specialized knowledge. Most pilgrims seek spiritual guidance, not scholarly access to restricted materials."

"We're not most pilgrims," Margarethe said. "We've traveled from the continent specifically to study materials preserved in English monasteries that might not have survived plague and war elsewhere."

"From the continent," Brother Edmund said slowly. "The plague is worse there, we hear."

"A third dead or dying in many regions," Thomas confirmed. "Which makes preserving accumulated knowledge critical. We're documenting cipher systems before the scholars who understand them die and the knowledge is lost."

Cover story and truth together—they were absolutely trying to preserve knowledge, just not the knowledge Brother Edmund imagined.

"I'll need to consult with the library's keeper," Brother Edmund said. "We don't grant access to restricted materials lightly, especially to foreign visitors during plague times. Wait here."

He disappeared into the cathedral's interior.

"He suspects something," Margarethe said quietly.

"Suspects we're more than simple pilgrims," Thomas agreed. "But suspicion isn't certainty. If we're careful, we might gain legitimate access."

Brother Edmund returned twenty minutes later with an older monk—the library keeper, his expression showing the particular wariness of someone protecting valuable materials from potential damage.

"I'm Father Aethelred," the older monk said, studying them with sharp intelligence. "Brother Edmund says you seek access to cipher manuscripts. Explain your purpose and learning."

Thomas had prepared for this. "I studied manuscript preservation at a German monastery before plague forced me to flee. Margarethe has an eye for cipher patterns in decorative elements. Maria has family knowledge of scribal traditions passed through generations."

All technically true even if massively incomplete.

Father Aethelred considered them for a long moment. "The library contains materials dating to Roman and Anglo-Saxon periods. Some manuscripts show cipher marks in margins we've never interpreted. If you genuinely understand such systems, you might help us catalog materials we've preserved but never fully comprehended."

"We'd be honored to assist," Thomas said.

"Tomorrow, then," Father Aethelred decided. "You'll have supervised access to general collection materials. If you demonstrate legitimate scholarship rather than treasure hunting or heresy, we might grant access to more restricted holdings. For tonight, you'll stay in the pilgrim quarters. Meals are provided. Prayers are expected."

They were led to simple rooms—clean if sparse, better than many places they'd slept during months of travel. Thomas lay on his narrow bed that night thinking about how close they were. One more fragment. One more

piece of the complete Genesis Protocol.

Then they'd have everything except the way to actually use it to challenge the Order.

1348, St. Peter's Minster Library, Next Morning

The library was beautiful—rows of preserved manuscripts, copying desks, centuries of accumulated knowledge. Thomas forced himself not to weep. This was what Wilhelm had fought for. What Hamo had died protecting.

Father Aethelred supervised their initial access personally, watching as Thomas examined manuscripts showing cipher marks in margins.

"These symbols aren't random," Thomas said, pointing to decorative elements most people would dismiss as embellishment. "They hide additional meaning. See how certain flourishes appear at specific intervals? That's deliberate positioning marking key passages."

He demonstrated using techniques Wilhelm had taught him, showing how apparent decoration actually served as guide for hidden knowledge.

Father Aethelred's expression shifted from skepticism to genuine interest. "We've preserved these manuscripts for generations without understanding that dimension. The decorations are functional rather than purely aesthetic?"

"Both," Thomas said. "Beautiful and functional. The cipher system hides information in plain sight—make it look like normal decoration so that destroying encrypted knowledge requires destroying all decorated manuscripts, which even barbarians hesitate to do."

He spent the morning demonstrating cipher identification, building credibility while Margarethe and Maria examined different manuscripts looking for signs of which restricted materials might contain the sixth key.

By afternoon, Father Aethelred was convinced.

"The restricted collection is below," he said, leading them down stone stairs into underground storage where oldest materials were kept for preservation. "We maintain materials here that date before the Norman conquest. Some texts are unique—only surviving copies of works that exist nowhere else. You'll treat them with appropriate reverence."

"Of course, Father," Thomas said.

The underground chamber was colder than the main library, kept cool by stone and depth. Manuscripts lined shelves in careful organization.

Maria moved through the collection with blood memory guiding her—forty generations of women who'd preserved knowledge of where the sixth key was hidden, what manuscript contained it, what countersigns would identify it among thousands of preserved texts.

She stopped at a particular shelf, pulled out a manuscript marked as medical text from the twelfth century.

"This one," she said quietly.

Thomas examined it—appeared to be herbal medicine compendium, discussing treatments for various ailments. The kind of practical knowledge monasteries preserved routinely.

But the cipher marks in the margins told different story.

"Father Aethelred," Thomas said carefully, "this manuscript shows cipher encoding more sophisticated than the examples upstairs. Would you permit us to study it more carefully? We might decode additional medical knowledge the original scribes preserved."

"Proceed," Father Aethelred said. "But I'll remain present. That manuscript is valuable—one of our oldest medical texts."

Thomas and Maria worked together, using the Iron and Silver Keys to decode the cipher marks, revealing hidden content beneath the surface medical text.

Maria's hands trembled as she accessed blood memory, pulling up inherited knowledge about what this manuscript really contained.

Her eyes went distant, unfocused, seeing through forty generations.

Then tears started streaming down her face.

"What's wrong?" Father Aethelred asked.

"The text," Maria said, voice breaking. "It's recording suffering. Real people. Families separated. Children taken for breeding. Women forced into unwanted marriages."

She accessed deeper memory: "Anna of Kent, married at fourteen, died at sixteen in childbirth. Robert of York, separated from his siblings at seven, never saw his family again. Margaret the Weaver, whose community was scattered—families relocated, marriages rearranged, children redistributed."

Her voice grew stronger. "Hundreds of stories like these. The founders included this as warning—this is the cost in human lives. Harm that compounds across generations."

Father Aethelred looked disturbed. "This documents methodical cruelty?"

"A conspiracy that's survived for two millennia," Thomas said quietly. "Treating humans as breeding stock. The sixth fragment is evidence of their crimes."

He met Father Aethelred's eyes directly. "We're not treasure hunters or heretics, Father. We're exposing a conspiracy older than the church itself—corruption that taught it to play God with human bloodlines and call it preservation."

Father Aethelred was quiet for a long moment, wrestling with whether to believe them or call for guards.

Finally he spoke: "I've preserved manuscripts for forty years without understanding many of them fully. Trusted that knowledge worth hiding was knowledge worth preserving, even when I didn't grasp its complete significance. If what you say is true—if this conspiracy has operated across centuries—then exposing it matters more than guarding one monastery's rules of access."

He stepped back from the manuscript. "Take what time you need to study this fully. I'll ensure you're not disturbed. But understand—if this knowledge is as dangerous as you suggest, people will try to stop you from using it. Are you prepared for that?"

"We've been running from people trying to stop us for months," Margarethe said. "We're prepared."

Father Aethelred nodded slowly, then left them alone in the underground chamber—tremendous act of trust from a man who'd spent his life protecting these materials.

Maria returned her attention to the sixth fragment, accessing the complete emotional documentation with deep blood memory.

Thomas watched her process centuries of suffering—every family broken by the Order's interference, every child raised as bloodline experiment, every person whose life had been controlled and weighed and reduced to breeding value rather than human worth.

The cost of the Order's corruption written in tears and broken lives.

When Maria finally finished accessing the fragment, she looked exhausted and grief-stricken and determined.

"I have it all now," she said. "All seven keys complete in blood memory. The sixth fragment shows the human cost in ways that make the Order's evil undeniable. Anyone who reads these stories—anyone who sees what bloodline breeding actually means—will understand we're fighting not just a shadow plot but cruelty refined over centuries."

"All seven," Thomas said quietly. "We're done gathering."

"So we figure out how to use what we've learned to actually challenge them," Margarethe said.

Thomas thought about that—seven keys worth of evidence showing the Order's corruption from noble defensive purpose to catastrophe-making. Proof they'd known the Black Death was coming and positioned to benefit. Evidence of centuries of treating humans as breeding stock.

And one monk, one warrior woman, and one fourteen-year-old girl carrying all that knowledge while being hunted across Europe.

"We need to get this information to people who can use it," he said. "Not just preserve it for future generations, but distribute it now in ways that create immediate rebellion within the Order. Force current members to confront what they've become."

"How?" Maria asked. "We can't shout it from rooftops. Most people can't read. The church and lords are riddled with Order men who'll smother anything that threatens them."

"Then we use the Order's own preservation methods against them," Thomas said. "Encode the complete Protocol into manuscripts using their cipher. Distribute copies to monasteries and libraries across Europe—so many, in so many places, that destroying all of them becomes impossible. Hide the evidence in plain sight using the same methods they used to preserve knowledge across collapses."

"That's long-term preservation," Margarethe objected. "What about immediate action?"

"We also send plain letters to Order members directly," Thomas said. "Use countersigns and names Helena and Marcus provided. Show them what the complete Protocol actually says, forcing them to choose between continued service to corruption or rebellion to restore the original purpose."

Maria nodded slowly. "Some will suppress the information. Some will kill us for distributing it. But some—maybe enough—will read it and realize they've been serving evil disguised as preservation. Internal rebellion combined with preserved evidence. Both strategies together."

"We'll need time," Thomas said. "Months to encode the complete Protocol, distribute copies, send letters, create conditions for both immediate and long-term challenge."

"Time we might not have," Margarethe warned. "The Order is still hunting us. They know what we've been gathering. They'll set men to intercept us before we can distribute the evidence."

"Then we move carefully," Thomas said. "Stay in England where we have some distance from continental pursuit. Use monastery resources to create manuscript copies. Send them through church roads and trusted hands while avoiding men the Order has bought."

Father Aethelred returned as evening approached. “Have you learned what you needed?”

“Yes,” Thomas said. “And more than we wanted. The sixth fragment documents suffering we wish didn’t exist but must be preserved as evidence of crimes that need to be exposed.”

“Then preserve it properly,” Father Aethelred said. “The library’s resources are available for your copying work. I’ll provide materials and space. What you do with that preservation is your choice—I’m too old to fight conspiracies that have existed longer than kingdoms. But I can help ensure the knowledge survives long enough for someone to use it correctly.”

Relief washed through Thomas. “Thank you, Father. Your help matters more than you know.”

1348, That Evening

They spent the week in York creating manuscript copies, encoding the complete Genesis Protocol using cipher methods that would survive future catastrophes. Working in St. Peter’s Minster’s scriptorium alongside monks who thought they were just helping scholars preserve medical and philosophical texts.

The sixth key’s emotional record was hardest to encode—the human stories, the individual suffering, the accumulated hurt of centuries.

But it was also the most important. Because bloodless language about “population shaping” could be rationalized. But individual stories of children separated from parents, women forced into unwanted marriages, families destroyed for breeding purposes—those stories created emotional impact that cold reasoning couldn’t achieve.

Anyone reading the sixth fragment would understand the Order’s evil not just intellectually but viscerally.

On the fifth evening, Maria fell asleep at her copying desk just after compline, exhausted from channeling blood memory for hours. Father Aethelred had the monks carry her to the pilgrim quarters, told Thomas and Margarethe to rest as well.

Thomas walked Margarethe back through the darkening cloister, neither speaking until they reached the corridor where their cells waited.

She stopped at her door, turned to face him. “We did it. Seven keys. Complete Protocol.”

“We did,” Thomas agreed, heart hammering.

Margarethe’s hand found his—deliberate this time. Her fingers laced through his. “Whatever comes next, we face it together. Not just the quest. But this. Everything.”

“Together,” he said. “To whatever end.”

She stepped closer. “I didn’t choose this quest because of conscience. I chose it because of you. The monk who stood up to the Order looked like someone worth everything.”

Her voice grew quieter. “You’re the first person since my father who made me want to live for something besides revenge.”

“I’m not brave,” he said. “I shake before every fight—”

“And you keep going anyway,” Margarethe interrupted. “That’s bravery. Not the absence of fear but the refusal to let it stop you.” Her hand touched his face. “I’m not just in this for the quest. I’m in it for you.”

He kissed her then—or she kissed him. Suddenly they were pressed together, everything that had been building for months finally given permission to exist.

When they pulled apart, her expression showed fierce certainty.

"Whatever comes," she said. "Together."

She slipped into her cell, leaving him with his heart racing and the certainty that he'd just committed to something far more binding than any monastic vow.

1348, York, Two Days Later

The Gray Robes came on the seventh day.

Thomas was in the scriptorium working on the final pages of the seventeenth manuscript copy—carefully encoding the sixth fragment's emotional documentation into what appeared to be a treatise on herbal remedies—when Brother Edmund rushed in with fear bright in his elderly eyes.

"Four men," he gasped. "Gray cloaks. Armed. Asking for you by description—a German monk, a woman warrior, a young girl. They're searching the Minster methodically. Father Aethelred is trying to delay them but they're not listening to his authority."

Thomas's hands stilled on the manuscript. After months of flight, the Order had finally caught up.

"How long?" Margarethe asked, already moving to gather essential materials—the Iron and Silver Keys, the one completed manuscript they couldn't afford to lose.

"Minutes," Brother Edmund said. "Maybe less. They're on the main floor now—"

The door burst open.

Four Gray Robes, exactly as described. Disciplined. Armed. Moving with practiced precision of men who'd hunted fugitives across Europe and finally cornered their quarry.

At their center: Inquisitor Christoph of Cologne—the same hunter who'd shouted across Constantinople's harbor months ago. Patient as stone, just as he'd promised.

Christoph spoke in Latin: "Thomas of Eltville. Margarethe of Mainz. Maria of Mainz. You are charged with heresy, theft, and murder. Surrender peacefully or we take you by force."

"Murder?" Thomas said. "Only self-defense."

"Wilhelm of Prague. Guards in Constantinople. Surrender. Now."

Maria accessed blood memory. "They're not here for trial. They're here to execute us and destroy the manuscripts."

"You can't know that," Christoph said.

"Forty generations of women hunted by the Order. I know exactly how this ends. You'll kill Thomas and Margarethe. Take me for breeding. Burn every manuscript."

Christoph's expression shifted—not quite confirmation, but not denial.

Father Aethelred appeared in the doorway behind them, his elderly face showing distress and determination. "I don't know what authority you claim, but this is sanctuary. These scholars are under my protection. You will not arrest them without proper church procedure."

"Stand aside, old man," Christoph commanded. "Order business supersedes local church authority."

"Order business," Father Aethelred repeated slowly, understanding dawning. "You're part of the Order they've been exposing. Part of the corruption that's existed for centuries inside church ranks." He stepped forward despite obvious danger. "I won't let you murder scholars under protection of my library."

"Father, no—" Thomas started.

Christoph moved with trained speed—struck Father Aethelred across the face with mailed fist, sent the elderly monk crashing into the stone wall.

Father Aethelred crumpled. Didn't move. Blood pooled beneath his head where it had struck stone, spreading dark across the scriptorium floor.

Margarethe had her crossbow up before Thomas could breathe, aimed at Christoph with lethal efficiency.

"You just murdered a priest. In a cathedral. In front of witnesses." Margarethe's voice stayed flat, factual. "Whatever authority you claim—you just destroyed it."

She didn't flinch from Christoph's gaze. "Or does the Order operate above God's law now?"

"He's not dead," Christoph said, though Thomas couldn't tell if that was true given the spreading blood. "And you're not scholars—you're fugitives who've stolen the Order's secrets and are attempting to distribute them in violation of agreements that have maintained order for two thousand years."

"Agreements made without consent of the people being bred like livestock," Maria said. "Agreements that treated human lives as resources to shape. The Order betrayed its founding purpose. We're exposing that betrayal. That's not heresy—that's truth."

"Truth that will destroy carefully maintained orders," Christoph said. "Truth that will create chaos when humanity needs order to survive coming catastrophes. You think exposing the Order serves good? You're naive children playing with forces you don't understand."

The other three Gray Robes were spreading out, trying to surround them. Thomas's hands were shaking. His breath came short and fast. Sweat ran down his spine despite the scriptorium's cold.

They could surrender—be executed, have their work destroyed, accomplish nothing. Or fight—almost certainly die given four trained warriors against three exhausted fugitives—but maybe create enough chaos that the manuscripts survived.

"Margarethe," he said quietly. "The window behind you. Can you break through?"

"Ten-foot drop to courtyard. We'd be exposed during escape but alive long enough to run." Her crossbow never wavered. "Your call."

Thomas grabbed the completed manuscript—the one containing all seven fragments plus synthesis notes. Wrapped it in oiled cloth, sealed it carefully.

"Brother Edmund," he said to the terrified monk pressed against the wall. "This manuscript contains everything. The complete Genesis Protocol including documentation of Order corruption. If we die, you distribute it. Give copies to monasteries across England. Send messengers to the continent. Make sure it survives even if we don't."

Brother Edmund took the wrapped manuscript with trembling hands. "I don't understand—"

"You don't need to. You just need to preserve knowledge and distribute it. That's what you've spent your life doing. This is just one more manuscript that deserves preservation." His voice carried desperate intensity. "Promise me. Whatever happens in the next few minutes, this survives."

"I promise," Brother Edmund whispered.

The Gray Robes were advancing.

"Now," Thomas commanded.

Margarethe shot—crossbow bolt taking Christoph in the shoulder, not fatal but incapacitating enough to drop him. She spun, smashed the scriptorium window with the crossbow stock, knocked out remaining glass with quick efficient strikes.

"Go!" she shouted.

Maria went first—young and agile, dropping through the window with blood memory guiding her landing. Thomas grabbed the manuscripts, turned toward the window—

A Gray Robe burst through the scriptorium door. Young man, trained fighter, knife already drawn.

"Heretics!" he shouted.

Thomas lunged for the window. The Gray Robe's blade flashed—sudden, sharp pain bloomed in Thomas's left side as the knife caught him. Not deep, but deep enough. He felt the wet heat of blood spreading through his robe.

"Move!" Margarethe's voice from below.

Thomas went through the window, manuscripts clutched to his chest, blood already soaking through. Hit the courtyard stones hard enough to jar his teeth and make the knife wound scream. He rolled to absorb impact the way Margarethe had taught him, gasping as the motion tore at the cut.

Margarethe came last, crossbow abandoned, knives in both hands, dropping and rolling and coming up already running. She saw the blood on Thomas's robe, her eyes flashing with concern, but there was no time.

Behind them, shouts as the remaining Gray Robes organized pursuit. Boots on stone. Professional hunters who wouldn't be slowed long by one injured companion.

They ran through York's streets—three fugitives who'd been cornered but refused to surrender, carrying nothing but the clothes on their backs and the knowledge encoded in Maria's blood memory.

The manuscripts were behind them. The complete Protocol written in cipher-encoded copies that Brother Edmund had promised to distribute.

Whether that promise would be honored, whether Father Aethelred survived, whether their months of work accomplished anything—all unknown.

But they were alive. Still fleeing. Still carrying the knowledge the Order wanted destroyed.

They reached York's walls as dusk gathered, found a drainage culvert that led beneath the fortifications, crawled through filth and darkness to emerge in fields beyond the city.

Behind them, York's spires rose against darkening sky. Somewhere in that city, the Order searched for them. Somewhere in that city, manuscripts containing the complete Protocol waited for distribution or destruction depending on whether Brother Edmund chose courage or safety.

"We can't go back," Margarethe said. "The Order controls the Minster now. Probably searching every manuscript, every scholar, looking for evidence of what we created."

"So we trust it," Thomas said, though trust seemed inadequate foundation for months of work. "Trust that Brother Edmund keeps his promise. Trust that Father Aethelred survives to ensure distribution. Trust that some good monks choose preservation over obedience to authority the Order has bought."

"And if they don't?" Maria asked quietly.

"Then the Protocol died in York," Thomas admitted. "And we failed everyone who died helping us gather it. Wilhelm and Hamo and Johannes and Helena and all the others who risked everything thinking we'd accomplish something meaningful."

They walked away from York through spring fields turning to summer growth, three fugitives carrying only blood memory and desperate hope.

The quest that had begun in Mainz nine months ago had reached its completion point—seven keys accessed, Protocol understood, evidence encoded in manuscripts left behind for others to distribute.

Whether that evidence would survive and create the rebellion they'd fought for, or be destroyed and suppressed like so many previous attempts—that was beyond their control now.

They'd done what they could with the time and knowledge they had.

Now they could only hope it was enough.

York, The Morning After

Brother Edmund sealed the third manuscript package with trembling hands.

Three nights without sleep. Father Aethelred lay in the infirmary with skull fractured. The Gray Robes had burned eleven copies. But they hadn't found these three.

He addressed the first: *Brother Cuthbert, Canterbury*. The second: *Father Brendan, Dublin*. The third he would hide in York.

A knock. Brother Paulinus entered. "I have the horse ready."

"Truth," Edmund said simply, handing him packages. "Evidence of corruption. If these reach their destinations and are copied, they become too distributed to destroy."

"And if I'm caught?"

"Tell them everything. Give them my name. I'm old." Edmund met his eyes. "This matters more than my safety."

Paulinus took the packages. "Canterbury and Dublin. I'll see them delivered."

"Then find Thomas, Margarethe, and Maria. Give them this letter. Let them know their sacrifice accomplished something."

After Paulinus left, Edmund returned to work. Twenty more copies within the month. Scattered knowledge stronger than centralized control. One copy at a time until the truth was too distributed to burn.

Even if it cost him everything.

1348, Rural England, Three Days from York

They'd been traveling north for three days, avoiding roads and settlements, living on foraged food and water from streams, when the messenger found them.

A young monk, barely twenty, riding a horse pushed hard. He'd clearly been searching methodically along northern routes from York, following likely escape paths for fugitives fleeing the city.

"Thomas of Eltville?" he called, spotting them in a forest clearing. "Margarethe? Maria?"

Margarethe had her knife ready before Thomas could respond, hard-won wariness making her assume trap until proven otherwise.

But the messenger held up empty hands, showed no weapons except a scroll tube bearing Father Aethelred's seal.

"I bring news from York," he said. "From Brother Edmund. He asked me to find you, to tell you what transpired after you fled."

Thomas's heart hammered. "Father Aethelred—did he survive?"

"Barely. Head injury that may never fully heal. But he lives, and he's already ensured your manuscripts are being copied and distributed." The messenger pulled out the scroll. "Brother Edmund wrote this three days ago. I've been riding hard to find you before the Order realized someone had been sent."

Thomas unsealed the scroll with trembling hands, read Brother Edmund's careful script aloud so Margarethe and Maria could hear:

Thomas, Margarethe, Maria—

Father Aethelred lives, though he may never fully recover. But in his moments of clarity, he has been more committed than ever to ensuring your work survives.

The Gray Robes found most of the manuscripts. Destroyed eleven copies, claiming they were heretical materials.

But they didn't find them all.

Father Aethelred had moved three copies to hidden archive locations the night before the Order arrived. He suspected pursuit was closing in. Those three copies survive.

Moreover, I kept the promise. The complete manuscript you gave me—I made two copies immediately after you fled, working through the night. Sent one to Canterbury with our most trusted courier. Sent another to Dublin via ship. The original remains hidden in York.

So the Order destroyed eleven copies. But six survive. And we are creating more.

Father Aethelred has worked with other English monasteries. Within the month, twenty copies will exist. Within a year, perhaps a hundred distributed widely enough that destroying all becomes impossible.

You succeeded. The Protocol will survive. The evidence will be preserved for future generations.

But you cannot return to York. The Order has declared you excommunicated heretics. Your names and descriptions sent to church authorities across Europe. You are hunted now, with prices on your heads and warrants for execution without trial.

I'm sorry your reward for this service is continued flight and danger. But know that what you accomplished matters. The Order's corruption is documented. Their betrayal preserved in multiple locations. Future generations will know the truth you risked everything to expose.

May God protect you in whatever comes next.

—Brother Edmund of York

Thomas finished reading and passed the scroll to Maria so she could see it herself.

"Six copies," he said quietly. "Not the twelve we'd hoped for. But enough."

"And twenty more within a month," Margarethe added. "A hundred within a year. The Order can't suppress that. Can't destroy manuscripts spread across that many locations without revealing themselves publicly."

Maria accessed blood memory briefly. "This is the farthest any rebellion has gotten. Previous exposures were suppressed before multiple copies existed. Single manuscripts destroyed. Individual truth-tellers killed before they could distribute evidence widely. But six copies surviving, with twenty more coming—that's unprecedented. That's dangerous to the Order in ways they can't easily counter."

Relief hit Thomas—sharp and disbelieving—then settled into something quieter. Not victory—they were still hunted fugitives. But accomplishment. Purpose fulfilled. They'd set out to gather the complete Genesis Protocol and distribute it in ways that would survive suppression.

Against all odds, they'd done it.

"So what now?" Margarethe asked. "We're hunted across Europe. Can't return to any major city. Can't use our real names or show our faces anywhere the Order might have informants. We've completed the quest but we're no closer to safety than when we started."

The messenger spoke up hesitantly: "If I may—Brother Edmund also asked me to relay an offer. There's a monastery in the Welsh mountains. Small, remote, very old. Founded before Norman conquest, maintained by monks who value knowledge preservation above obedience to current church authority. Brother Edmund has connections there. He can arrange for you to stay, to live under borrowed names, to have sanctuary while the Order's attention focuses elsewhere."

"Teaching," Maria said suddenly. "That's what my ancestors did when they needed to hide. They taught. Passed knowledge to the next generation through patient instruction instead of banners and blood. Quiet work that lasts when loud defiance gets you killed."

Thomas looked at Margarethe, saw her watching him with that same fierce certainty she'd shown in the monastery corridor five nights ago.

"Wales," he said slowly. "Teaching. Living quietly while the manuscripts do their work."

It wasn't retreat. It was recognizing they'd done the dramatic part—gathering and distributing the evidence. Now the patient part began—preserving knowledge, teaching future generations, maintaining the quiet work that accumulated across time.

Margarethe nodded. "Like Helena. Like Giacomo. Like all the ones who read the Protocol and chose conscience. We add ourselves to that line—not through martyrdom, but through work that lasts."

She took his hand—openly this time, in front of Maria and the messenger, no longer hiding what had solidified between them during their week in York.

"Together," she said, echoing the promise from the corridor. "Wales. Teaching. Building something that lasts beyond just survival."

"Together," Thomas agreed, squeezing her hand. "Whatever that becomes."

Maria smiled—the first genuine smile Thomas had seen from her in weeks. "Teaching sounds good. Better than running. Better than hiding. Actually doing something with the knowledge we've gathered instead of just preserving it in blood memory for another forty generations."

The messenger looked relieved. "Then I'll guide you to the monastery. Three days' travel into the mountains. Remote enough that Order pursuit would be very difficult. You'll be safe there. As safe as anyone can be in these times."

They traveled west into Wales, following the young monk through increasingly wild terrain. Left behind the populated lowlands where church authority was strong. Climbed into mountains where ancient monasteries clung to hilltops like stubborn reminders of older faiths layered beneath Christian conversion.

The monastery was exactly as described—small, ancient, maintained by a handful of elderly monks who cared more about preserving knowledge than enforcing current political orthodoxy.

The abbot welcomed them without too many questions. Assigned them cells. Provided library and scriptorium access. Asked only that they contribute through teaching and manuscript preservation work.

It was sanctuary. Not freedom—they'd probably never be free of the Order's hunt. But safety enough to live instead of just survive. Space enough to teach instead of just flee.

That first evening, Thomas and Margarethe walked the garden together. Wildflowers grew between herbs the monks cultivated.

"This is it," Margarethe said. "The end of the quest. The beginning of whatever comes next."

"Teaching," Thomas said. "Preserving knowledge."

"Living." She took both his hands. "Building a life together. Not just sharing a quest. Actually choosing each other."

Her meaning was clear. Wales was commitment—to each other, to the work, to whatever future they could build.

"I'm not easy to live with," he warned. "I spend too much time with manuscripts—"

"And I'm a fighter who doesn't know how to be soft," Margarethe interrupted. "Who'll keep weapons under the bed and wake at every sound." She stepped closer. "But we've survived Constantinople and the Order together. I think we can survive building a life together."

She kissed him—open and certain under the Welsh sky.

"Together," he said. "To whatever end."

They stood as evening deepened, hands clasped, watching stars emerge. For the first time in nine months, Thomas felt something like peace.

The complete Protocol existed in six copies spreading across Europe. Twenty more being created. A hundred coming within a year.

The quest was complete. The rebellion distributed.

Ahead, the slow work of preservation and teaching.

And between them—a future they'd face together.

That was enough.

EPILOGUE - THE PATTERN CONTINUES

August 1348, Llan Hen Monastery, Wales

Llan Hen—the old place. Ancient beyond reckoning, maintained by elderly monks who cared more about preserving knowledge than enforcing orthodoxy.

Thomas stood in the scriptorium, looking at mist-shrouded mountains. The York wound had healed to a pale scar. Margarethe had gone to help with herb cultivation. They were building the rhythms of shared life.

"You're the pattern-reader," a voice said.

Brother Cadfael—ancient, sharp-eyed.

"I read cipher systems," Thomas said carefully.

"You were bred for it. Forty-one generations. And you've turned that gift against them." Cadfael gestured at the shelves. "I've preserved manuscripts for seventy years. Read things the Order thought safely hidden. I've been waiting for someone who might use it honestly."

"And you think I will?"

"You already have. You distributed the Protocol. That's more than anyone has accomplished in centuries." Cadfael's face showed satisfaction. "Now survive long enough to see whether it matters."

"By hiding here," Thomas said, feeling retreat's weight.

"By teaching. The village has forty children. None can read. Exactly who the Order dismisses—too poor, too remote to matter."

Cadfael stood with effort. "Teach them anyway. A man who can read a charter is harder to cheat. That's how you break a grip—one finger at a time."

"How long can we stay?"

"As long as you choose. The Order's reach doesn't extend this far. They have better targets than fugitives who've already distributed the evidence."

Eight children arrived three weeks later. Thomas tried explaining letters to students who'd never held a stylus.

By midday, he sat amid scattered materials, wondering how Wilhelm had found patience.

"One letter at a time," Maria said. "Lower your expectations."

Thomas adjusted. Shorter lessons. Simpler words. By the second week, the youngest recognized five letters. By December, twelve students, and Owain—the oldest—was reading Latin and asking dangerous questions.

"The priest says obey church authority," Owain said. "But you teach things that contradict him. Which should we believe?"

"What do you think?"

"His certainty comes from ignorance rather than wisdom."

"Dangerous to say out loud."

"But not false."

Thomas pulled out a cipher-encoded manuscript. "These truths could get everyone killed. So I hide them."

"Will you teach me?"

Teaching Owain cipher systems meant painting a mark on his back. But more people preserving hidden knowledge served the founders' purpose.

"Yes. But understand: this makes you dangerous. You'll need wisdom to survive it."

"Every skill is both tool and weapon."

"Right." Thomas began teaching pattern identification, substitution systems, encoding.

Winter deepened. A boy learned to hide truth.

May 1349

Nine months of teaching. Nine months of wondering whether their distribution had mattered.

Margarethe found Thomas in the garden, carrying harvested herbs. She looked different from the warrior who'd fled York—still dangerous when necessary, but changed deeper.

They shared a cell now. Brother Cadfael had handfasted them in the old Welsh way. Margarethe had worn wildflowers. Maria had witnessed.

"Helena's letter arrived," Margarethe said, sitting beside him. She handed him the sealed package.

Thomas opened it, read Helena's update:

Nine months since your distribution:

Sixty-seven Order members have broken away openly. More resist quietly. The breeding work is stumbling—too many stewards refuse, too many ledgers vanish.

The Order has split three ways: traditionalists, reformers, and radicals. The split has ended unified pursuit.

Two hundred copies of the complete Protocol now exist across Europe, North Africa, and the eastern Mediterranean. No purge can reach them all.

Thirty-seven former Order members and Gray Robes are now teaching in remote places. Your choice has kindled something. People bred to serve corrupt powers are choosing to serve the founders' first intent instead.

I don't know if this will survive beyond a generation. The Order is powerful. But you've created space for resistance that didn't exist before.

Keep teaching.

—Helena

Thomas read aloud. Sixty-seven who'd turned. Two hundred manuscript copies. Men who'd once hunted now teaching.

"We did something," Margarethe said. "Not perfectly. But enough."

She looked uncertain. "There's something else."

She took his hand, placed it against her stomach. "I think we're going to have a child."

Thomas stared. A child. Their child.

"Are you sure?"

"Two months without bleeding. Sickness in the mornings." She met his eyes. "I don't know whether to be terrified or hopeful."

Thomas pulled her close. "Both. But mostly grateful. That we're alive. That we found each other."

Margarethe kissed him—soft and certain.

"I told Maria this morning. She cried. Said this feels like choosing the future instead of just preserving the past."

"We'll teach them," Thomas said. "Not just letters. But the habit of asking why. The courage to resist. The wisdom to know when to shout truth and when to carry it quietly."

"And if the Order finds us?"

"We adapt. Move if we must. Carry the work in our hands."

Maria joined them. "A baby who'll grow up knowing the truth. Who'll carry this forward."

"If they choose to," Thomas said. "The choices they make are theirs."

That afternoon, Thomas taught seventeen students.

Owain was helping now—guiding the youngest. Charcoal on slate filled the room. Someone giggled.

Outside, spring transformed the mountains. Birds sang.

Inside, a shy girl sounded out her first word and laughed, startled by her own voice.

The Genesis Protocol was out in the world now. The rebellion distributed, spreading beyond their control.

Here, all Thomas could do was teach. One child at a time.

END OF BOOK 1: THE AETHELRED CIPHER

AUTHOR'S NOTE:

The medieval timeline concludes here, but the story continues in the modern era. Nearly seven centuries after Thomas, Margarethe, and Maria distributed the Genesis Protocol, Sarah Chen—a systems analyst working in public health—begins uncovering evidence that the Order they exposed still exists, still engineers catastrophes, and is positioning for something unprecedented.

The complete Genesis Protocol, preserved through centuries in cipher-encoded manuscripts, holds the key to understanding both the Order's current operations and the pattern of collapse that threatens modern civilization.

Their quest succeeded in wounding the Order and creating resistance. Sarah's quest, seven centuries later, must finish what they started.

Book 2: THE GENESIS PROTOCOL continues in the modern timeline, where small acts of resistance, repeated across centuries, can accumulate into patterns powerful enough to break cycles two thousand years old.

The pattern continues.

PREVIEW: BOOK 2 - THE GENESIS PROTOCOL

CHAPTER 1 - THE BURNING

November 9, 2019 — New Haven, Connecticut 1:47 AM

Sarah smelled the accelerant before she saw the flames.

Not wood smoke. Not the honest smell of a fireplace or a campfire or anything that belonged in November. This was chemical — kerosene or something close to it, the kind of smell that bypassed seven years of graduate training and went straight to the part of her brain that still lived in caves and understood: *fire means death. Run.*

She ran toward it.

Linda Marsh's driveway cut through Connecticut woods — gravel and pine needles, dark except for the orange light bleeding through the trees ahead. Sarah's sneakers slipped on frozen ground. Her laptop bag hammered against her hip with each stride. Her breath came in white bursts that November shredded away.

She'd gotten Marsh's encrypted message eighteen hours ago: *Found something at GenVault. Genetic research. Wrong numbers. Need pattern analysis. Come NOW.*

Eighteen hours too slow.

Her phone buzzed in her pocket. She glanced at the screen without breaking stride: **Martin Reeves — FBI**. Her contact. The man who'd connected her with Marsh two weeks ago.

She silenced it. Martin could wait. Whatever was happening at the end of this driveway couldn't.

The trees opened.

The entire second floor was engulfed. Flames poured from every window — not the yellow of natural fire but the white-blue of something burning at temperatures a house shouldn't reach. Black smoke rolled across the front lawn in a low fog, thick enough to lose your feet in.

No fire trucks. Not yet. Just the house dying and Sarah standing at the edge of the driveway with nothing useful in her hands.

"MARSH!"

Her voice cracked against the roar. No answer. Just fire crackling and something deep inside the structure groaning — a sound like the house was trying to hold itself up and failing.

Sarah walked toward it.

(Every part of her body was screaming *stop.* Every part except the part that had gotten her through MIT and doctoral defense and six months of investigating GenVault — that part said *go.*)

The heat hit her at the front steps. Not warmth. Violence. A wall of it that evaporated the sweat on her face and made her skin feel tight, shrinking, about to split. Her eyes streamed. Her throat clamped shut against the smoke pouring through the open front door — blown outward by pressure or kicked in by whoever had been here first.

Sarah pulled her jacket over her mouth. Useless. The smoke found ways in. Down her throat. Into her lungs. Tasting like burning plastic and melting insulation and underneath it something sweet and organic that her brain refused to name because naming it meant admitting what was burning.

She dropped low where the smoke thinned from black to gray and went inside.

The entryway was an oven. Three feet of visibility. The floor was hot through her sneakers. Wallpaper curled from the walls in blackened strips. Above her, the ceiling blistered and bulged and made sounds that meant it was going to come down soon.

"MARSH! WHERE ARE YOU?"

Nothing.

Then — a shape. Ten feet from the door. On the floor.

A body. Face down. White hair matted dark. One arm stretched forward toward the door as if she'd been crawling. The other arm bent at her side at an angle that living people didn't make.

And beside her, clutched against her hip: a small metal box.

Marsh had been trying to reach the door. She'd been carrying the box and trying to get out and something had stopped her ten feet short.

"Linda." Sarah crawled to her. The heat pressed down on her back like a hand. "Linda, I'm getting you out."

She grabbed Marsh's outstretched arm. Gripped the forearm through the sleeve of her cardigan — wool, or something that had been wool before the heat transformed it.

Pulled.

The sleeve came apart in her hands.

Not tore. *Came apart.* The fabric had fused with the skin underneath, melted into it by heat until fabric and flesh were the same ruined thing, and when Sarah pulled, the sleeve separated from the arm like a glove being peeled from a hand that wasn't a hand anymore. What was underneath was blistered and split and wet and *wrong* — the texture of paper that had been soaked and left to dry and soaked again until it forgot it was ever solid.

Sarah dropped it.

The sound she made wasn't a scream. It was something before screaming — a short, involuntary noise from lungs that had stopped working. She fell backward. Caught herself on her hands. The floor was hot enough to feel through her palms.

(Move. The ceiling is coming down. Move or die in here with her.)

But her brain — the part that never shut off, the part that recognized patterns in data sets and genetic sequences and population models — was already processing what it had seen in the half-second between pulling and dropping.

A wound. Small. Neat. At the base of Marsh's skull. Entry wound.

The fire hadn't killed Linda Marsh.

Someone had put a bullet in her head. Then set the house on fire to burn the evidence.

Something cracked overhead — the sound of support beams giving up. A section of ceiling plaster crashed to the floor three feet away. Sparks and ember rain. The fire reaching down from the second floor like fingers closing.

Sarah's eyes went to the metal box beside Marsh's body. Fireproof. The size of a shoebox. Marsh had been carrying it toward the door when they shot her. Whatever was inside, she'd thought it was worth dying for.

(Worth dying *with.* She'd been trying to get it out.)

Sarah grabbed the box with both hands and ran.

Through the entryway. Through smoke so thick she navigated by memory — she'd been crawling toward the door, the door was behind her, she turned and ran. Her shins hit something. She stumbled. Kept moving. The front door was a rectangle of cold air and darkness and she threw herself through it as the ceiling behind her surrendered.

The collapse sounded like the end of something.

Sarah made it to the lawn. Fell. Rolled onto her back in wet grass. Coughed so hard her vision went white, then coughed again, then couldn't stop coughing. Her eyes streamed. Her lungs felt scraped. Smoke poured out of her in ragged breaths as if the fire had followed her out and was still burning inside her chest.

(The sleeve. The texture of it. The way the skin and the fabric had become the same thing. The way it peeled.)

(Stop.)

She vomited into the grass. Her hands were shaking — both of them, pressing into the earth, fingers digging into cold dirt while her stomach emptied itself.

(Don't think about what you just held.)

(She couldn't stop thinking about it.)

Sirens. Growing louder. Red and white lights flickering through the trees at the end of the driveway. Fire trucks arriving twenty minutes after the fire had won.

Sarah sat up. The metal box was beside her on the lawn. She didn't remember setting it down, but her hands must have dropped it when the coughing took over.

She picked it up. Held it against her chest.

Watched Linda Marsh's house collapse into itself. Sparks rose into the Connecticut sky and died. The second floor was gone. The first floor was going. Everything Marsh had spent thirty-seven years gathering — evidence, research, whatever she'd found at GenVault — was ash now.

Everything except what was in this box.

A paramedic appeared. Young. Efficient. "Ma'am? Were you inside? Do you need—"

"I heard screaming." Sarah's voice wasn't her own. Flat. Controlled. The voice of someone who had already decided to lie. "Thought someone was trapped."

The paramedic studied her — soot-covered face, streaming eyes, the particular look of someone who'd just been inside a burning building and wouldn't stop smelling it for days.

"We'll need you to—"

"I'll be over there." Sarah pointed vaguely and stood up. Walked toward the street. The paramedic let her go because the burning house was a bigger problem than one disoriented woman walking in the wrong direction.

At the street, Sarah stopped.

A sedan idled across the road. Black. Tinted windows. Engine running, lights off.

Just sitting there.

She stared at it. The sedan stared back — two headlights like closed eyes, exhaust curling into November dark.

Then it pulled away. Slow. Unhurried. Making sure she saw it leave. Making sure she understood: whoever was inside had watched the fire, watched her go in, watched her come out carrying the box.

Message delivered: *We know. We saw.*

The sedan turned the corner and was gone.

Sarah sat in her car three blocks away. Doors locked. Engine off. The metal box on the passenger seat.

Her hands wouldn't stop shaking.

She gripped the steering wheel. Squeezed until her knuckles went white. Held on like the car might move without her. The shaking traveled up her forearms, into her shoulders, into the place behind her sternum where breathing was supposed to happen automatically but wasn't.

(The sleeve. The way it separated.)

She let go of the wheel. Looked at her palms. Soot in the creases. Burns she hadn't noticed — two on the right hand, raw patches where she'd caught herself on the hot floor. She couldn't feel them yet. Shock was handling that.

The lockbox sat on the passenger seat where Marsh had died carrying it. A fireproof container with a simple clasp, latched but not locked — the hiding place had been the security, and Marsh hadn't had time to lock it because she'd been running.

Sarah reached for the clasp. Her fingers slipped. She wiped her hands on her jeans — soot smeared across denim — and tried again.

It opened.

Inside: a thumb drive. A folded note in careful handwriting. A photograph. A small iron key with a paper tag reading **YUL-1912-ARIS**.

She picked up the note first. Unfolded it with fingers that left black smudges on the paper.

Sarah — The thumb drive has everything. Deployment schedules. Locations. The numbers are real. I've been gathering evidence for 37 years and this is what it comes down to. The key opens a box at Yale Sterling Library, Rare Books vault. Copies of everything they'll try to destroy. Find the pattern. Stop this. — M

Find the pattern.

Marsh had known Sarah would come. Had prepared for this — backup evidence in a vault where fire couldn't reach, and a key she'd carried against her body while crawling toward the door with a bullet in her skull.

(The sleeve.)

(Stop.)

Sarah set down the note. Picked up the photograph.

Two men in a conference room. Marsh had written names on the back in the same careful handwriting:

- **Dr. James Morrison** — GenVault Director of Genetic Research
- **Dr. David Lagos** — Lead Research Coordinator

Smiling. Conference table between them. A photograph that said *colleagues* — or *conspirators.* Marsh had kept it in a fireproof box with evidence of something worth killing for.

Her phone buzzed again. Martin. Third time since the driveway.

She stared at his name on the screen. Martin Reeves. FBI. She trusted Martin — but right now she couldn't form words. Her throat was raw from smoke and she'd have to explain what had happened inside that house and she couldn't. Not yet.

She declined the call. Texted: **At Marsh's. Too late. She's dead. I'm OK. Will call tomorrow.**

Then she plugged the thumb drive into her laptop.

Files loaded. Dozens. Research documents. Genetic distribution maps. Population data organized by region. A folder labeled **THRESHOLD — Deployment Targets**.

She opened it.

Maps. Forty-seven locations marked in red. Casualty projections beside each one — numbers so large they stopped meaning what numbers are supposed to mean. They looked like coordinates. Like data points in a model. Not like human lives.

She scrolled. The numbers kept growing.

The document header read: **THRESHOLD Protocol — Population Optimization Through Targeted Genetic Selection.**

Population optimization.

Sarah closed the laptop.

The car was quiet. Three blocks away, fire trucks pumped water into a structure already lost. Red and white lights pulsed through the trees. Someone was dead inside that structure and no one was coming to save her because the fire had already won and the people who'd set it were driving away in a black sedan.

(The sleeve. The texture of paper that had been soaked and left to dry and soaked again. The way it peeled from the arm like it was the most natural thing in the world, like skin was meant to separate from muscle, like the human body was just layers that came apart when you pulled.)

Sarah opened the car door and vomited onto the asphalt.

Closed the door. Wiped her mouth. Sat in the dark breathing through her nose until the shaking slowed to something she could work around.

She opened the laptop again.

Population optimization through targeted genetic selection. Forty-seven locations. Casualty projections in the billions. Deployment schedules dated three weeks from now.

This was what Marsh had found. This was what the bullet was for. This was what the fire was meant to destroy.

Find the pattern. Stop this.

Sarah looked at the iron key on the passenger seat. Old. Heavy. The kind of key that opened something that had been locked for a long time.

YUL-1912-ARIS.

YUL. Yale University Library.

Yale was ten minutes from where she sat.

Whatever Marsh had locked in that vault — whatever she'd duplicated and hidden where fire couldn't reach — was waiting. Had been waiting. And Marsh had trusted Sarah to find it because Marsh had spent thirty-seven years gathering evidence and she'd chosen Sarah's name for the note and Sarah's skills for the pattern and Sarah's key for the lock.

Sarah closed the laptop. Put the photograph and the note back in the lockbox. Kept the thumb drive and the key.

Started the car.

She didn't call Martin back. Didn't call anyone.

The drive took eight minutes. November streets. Empty and dark. Her headlights cutting through the kind of quiet that only existed at 2 AM in a college town between semesters.

Sarah's hands shook on the steering wheel the entire way.

She parked two blocks from Sterling Memorial Library. Got out. The November air hit her lungs like a slap — cold and clean after the smoke, and her body wanted to stand there breathing it forever, but there was a key in her pocket and a dead woman's evidence in a vault and the sedan's headlights were still behind her eyelids every time she blinked.

She walked toward the library.

Behind her, three blocks away, Linda Marsh's house was still burning.

Continue reading in Book 2: THE GENESIS PROTOCOL

Seven centuries after Thomas, Margarethe, and Maria distributed the Genesis Protocol, Sarah Chen discovers the Order they exposed still exists—and is preparing to do it again.

For more information on the books in this series and to better understand the meaning behind the concepts these books elicit, go to the author's webpage randypellegrini.com/series.

Looking forward to your feedback and correspondence,

Randy Pellegrini